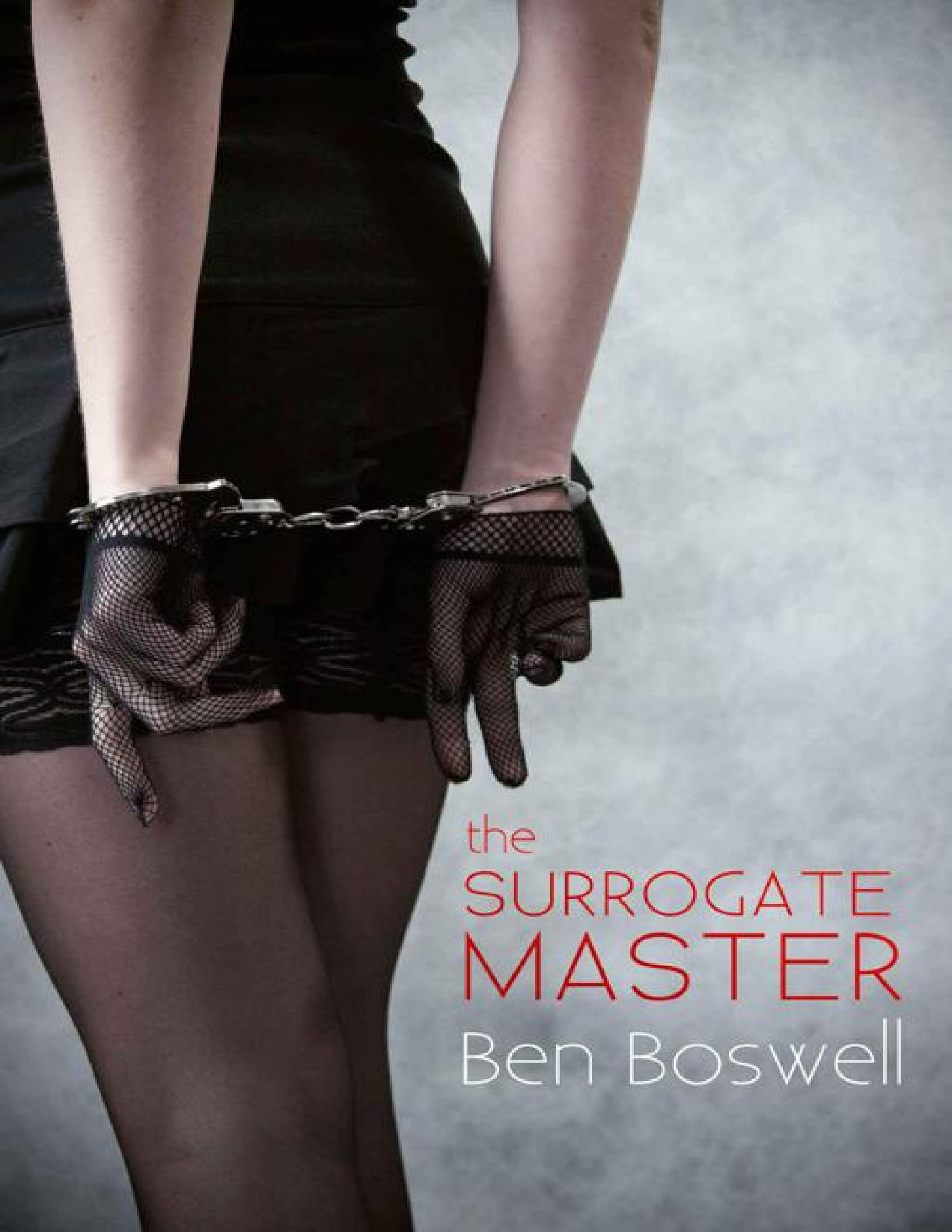




the
SURROGATE
MASTER
Ben Boswell

The Surrogate Master

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PREFACE

This is one of those books that began for me with a single image in my head. I don't want to give away what it was since it reveals a major plot point, but the process of writing this book was basically about constructing a plausible sequence of events to lead up to that image, and then grappling with the consequences of the situation when it happens. That's quite different for me. Most of my books and stories start with a beginning, a set-up, a premise. Here I had to invent a whole story about reaching a particular point. It felt, at times, like trying to hit a bullseye while riding on a bicycle.

As the first extended book I worked on after *Whatever It Takes*, I had planned for it to be light and a little silly. It isn't that. It isn't as dark as *Whatever It Takes*, but in trying to be emotionally true, it does spend a fair amount of time examining issues of jealousy, resentment, and mistrust. Still, I think there are enough moments of levity and wit to balance some of the more serious and introspective sections. At least I hope I got the balance right.

This is also the first book in which I delve into BDSM themes at any length. I have an ambivalent relationship with BDSM erotica. I find some of it quite sexy. And yet, I often find there is just not enough actual, you know, sex. The costumes, the bondage, the whipping... it's supposed to be foreplay, isn't it? But too often, it seems like that is the act itself. I have to admit, I don't understand that. Anyway, a word of warning to readers deep into the BDSM scene, if you like your BDSM pure, this book may not work for you. On the other hand, if your interest in BDSM is stuff like the *Story of O* (the movie rather than the book) then I think you'll find this a fun read.

In addition to Kenny Wright, as usual, I want to particularly thank Kirsten McCurran for her comments on an earlier draft of the book. But even more, I want to thank Kirsten for letting me read a draft of her book *Grooming Kitty*. It definitely put me in the mood to finish writing this book and gave me some inspiration as well. If you haven't read it, please do. You can find *Grooming Kitty* at Amazon: <http://www.amazon.com/Grooming-Kitty-Romance-Kirsten-McCurran-ebook/dp/B00NOFLXOU>. I would also like to thank Mrs. Kenny Wright for copyediting this book. And finally, I am grateful to RP for closely reading a final draft and making several additional typographical and stylistic suggestions.

Finally, thank you to all of you who've written with compliments or suggestions. I hope you continue to enjoy my work in the future.

PROLOGUE

I don't know how young I was. Too young. At least that's what my parents would have thought. But that was their fault for bringing me to Europe. Spring vacation in Germany.

The Berlin Wall had recently come down, so that would make me thirteen or so. My dad, a real history buff, had insisted we go see what was left of it before, as he feared, all traces were erased.

He walked us all over Berlin, my little sister pacified by a constant diet of rich German chocolates. It's a miracle she didn't develop diabetes during the trip. As for me, I was preoccupied with pussy. Well, not pussy. I mean, that was just an abstraction to me. But women, girls, whatever.

Dad would be going on about Checkpoint Charlie. Sis would be gripping a chocolate bar with two hands taking big bites. And me... all I noticed was the flouncy blonde with the heavy breasts. The cute brunette in the painted-on jeans. It was a warm day. My shorts were doing little to conceal my recurrent hard-on.

Not that I had any idea what I'd do with it. Porn was still hard to get. I'd seen a few soft R movies. A bare boob here and there. Maybe a naked couple writhing on top of each other under the covers on some TV show. A *Playboy*. But my fantasies, such as they were, had that sort of vagueness borne of lack of knowledge.

We were staying in a suite. Mom and dad had one room, sis and I the other. There was also a sitting room with a TV showing German programming, which, much to my surprise and delight, included nudity. I discovered that by accident, flipping the channels absentmindedly when we

first arrived. But once I did, I regarded the set with a mixture of protectiveness, apprehension, and excitement.

My big fear was that my parents would discover what I had, and find some way to lock the set away. But happily they didn't. That meant that each night, after going to bed, I would force myself to stay awake, listening for my parents to finally turn in. I could hear them sitting up, going through the guidebooks, making plans, and all I could think about was what I was missing on TV. If they showed fleeting nudity in prime time, what would they show late at night?

Then finally they went to sleep. I forced myself to be patient, to let them drift off. Then I snuck from my room. I turned the TV toward the wall, turned the volume so low as to be almost inaudible. For some reason, it didn't occur to me to turn it all the way off, even though I couldn't understand a word of it anyway.

I flipped through the channels, transfixed by ads that showed a flash of boob, but convinced that surely, surely, there would something even more interesting. And then I got lucky. I tuned in to a scene of a beautiful brunette being led through what looked like a medieval castle, into what seemed like a cave crowded with leering men. They stripped her, which was already more than I could have hoped, and the camera lingered on her, on breasts that seemed too small for my childish tastes, but which I now realize were perfect and then lower, over her flat belly, and then down to examine her dark brown triangle.

I'd seen *Playboys*, but those were just pictures. This was... a real, live woman, naked. I couldn't believe my luck, and would have been delighted if that had been all. But then, with a suddenness that bordered on violent, she was pushed to her knees, and then the camera swung wildly, the music swelled. It was not hardcore, no pink, no erections, but it was more than I'd

ever seen. On her hands and knees with a man thrusting behind her, on her back with a man between her legs, not just one man, but different men, and others behind, watching, leering.

I'd like to say it turned me on, but it didn't. It sort of scared me. But I was transfixed nonetheless. I watched the rest of the movie, where this beauty continued to be passed around, bent over couches and tables, the camera focused on her beautiful face as men took her. Sometimes she seemed angry, other times resigned, still others ecstatic. I couldn't make heads or tails of it. And then, she was taken into a room and stripped, and then, whipped. She writhed in pain... and pleasure? Her body glistened with sweat.

When it ended, I wished I could see it again. I talked my parents into buying a local TV guide as a souvenir. My dad tried to talk me into a model of an airplane from the Berlin Airlift. I insisted. I checked the previous night's schedule. *Histoire d'O* had been the movie. It meant nothing to me, though I obsessively searched through the guide, hoping it would be shown again. It wasn't.

That was, for six months, my idea of sex, though I was too embarrassed to speak about it to anyone, even my buddies who were increasingly bold about their sexual pronouncement. I felt like the grown-up in the group. I knew what real sex was like.

My obsession with that movie faded the day we returned from summer vacation, at the beginning of eighth grade. Becky Trainor's body had changed. Her wardrobe hadn't caught up. Every day, until her new clothes matched her developing physique, I couldn't help but leer at her too long legs in her too short skirts, her too large breasts encased in too tight shirts. And after her was Elise and then Maddie and then Trina, the first girl I actually kissed with erotic intent, and over time the image of the lithe

brunette, stripped and whipped, manhandled and taken, faded. That wasn't real sex. Real sex was awkwardly fumbling around in a movie theater trying to get my hands on some teenage girl's breasts.

CHAPTER ONE

Rachel and I have been together almost ten years. We met in business school. She was 24 at the time, one of the youngest students in the class, and easily the cutest. Slender, with dirty blond hair and blue-grey eyes hidden behind kludgy hipster glasses, she had by consensus a world-class ass. I hate to objectify her like that, but in her skinny jeans tucked into calf-high leather boots, it was hard not to notice.

I'm Max. A few years older than Rachel, when we met I was old enough to have a little cachet, young enough not to come off as a creeper. I started a study group and invited her to participate, a little subterfuge to get close to her without telegraphing my romantic intentions.

"Did that fool you?" I asked her, years later.

She grinned. "Not at all."

We soon ditched the other members of the group. One night, we celebrated a set of solid mid-term results. We went out to a dive bar. We ordered a pitcher of Natty Light, then another, and a third. We munched on stale popcorn and danced to OutKast on the jukebox.

Back in our booth, she leaned over and kissed me. I've always been shy with girls. I've never gotten the hang of making the first move. My sex life was almost wholly thanks to forward women. Happily enough, there have always been a few of them out there.

Our kissing progressed into a full-blown make-out session in the bar. I noticed our waitress, a middle-aged battleaxe, giving us the stink eye, though I couldn't be sure if it was because of the PDA or because we were too busy sucking face to keep up with our drinking.

The lights came on after last call, Semisonic's "Closing Time" suddenly blaring. We gathered up our things, walked unsteadily to the door. Outside, she wrapped her arm around my waist, I put my arm over her shoulder. She was so warm, soft; it was like her body was molded to mine.

My mind was racing, trying to find the right words to get her to come home with me. I needn't have bothered.

"My roommates have guests, can I crash at your place?" she asked.

"Um sure."

She gave me a reassuring smile that seemed to say, *Relax. Yes, we're going to have sex.*

I breathed a sigh of relief. She giggled at my awkwardness. It wasn't malicious. She seemed to think it was cute.

Nowadays, with that much booze in me, I am sure I'd have whiskey dick. Happily, that night I didn't. And being bombed probably kept me from coming right away. Even with a condom on, I don't think I've ever felt anything nicer than the moment when she took me inside her. She was on top, and she settled down on me, her beautiful, and surprisingly full, breasts right in my face. I reached around and squeezed her hard, perfect, ass.

She rode me slowly, expertly, rising and falling on my cock over and over, lifting herself up until I was just barely inside her, and then impaling herself firmly on my prick. I was content to explore her body with my hands, tweaking her nipples, exploring the crack of her ass, running my palm along her spine, until I could feel her silky hair on my hand as I caressed the back of her neck.

She came suddenly, gasping sexily, her pussy spasming on my cock. She fell forward, her face in the crook of my neck. She moaned softly in my ear. I could feel her hard nipples against my chest. She pumped her hips up

and down. I began thrusting upward to meet her. I came hard, seeing stars. The stars might have been the booze, but it was still a great fuck.

We both passed out after. She spent the night, and waking up to her naked body made the hangover seem like a small price to pay. She had no regrets. We made love that morning. And that evening. And every day thereafter for a week.

That was ten years ago.

We finished school. By then we were living together. A couple of months after our first “date” she informed me she was having trouble with her roommates.

“Oh my god,” she sighed, “Becky is going to drive me crazy. She’s such a fucking slob. And I’m sick of waking up to see Jenna’s latest lay at my breakfast table.”

“Well, if you hate it there, you could come live with me,” I offered tentatively.

She smiled. It was the response she’d been looking for.

We both landed solid jobs out West, closer to my folks. Rachel worked for a large mutual fund as an analyst. I got a similar position, but with a VC firm. We moved into a nice apartment, two bedrooms, a swanky address. Bonuses the first two years paid off our loans.

We got married. Neither of us is real religious, but to please her parents we married beneath a Chuppah, with my parents’ Unitarian minister presiding. The reception was small by modern standards, one hundred or so guests, but fun. Lots of dancing, drinking, the usual. Her cousins insisted on hoisting us up in chairs as the band played Hava Nagila.

It was a perfect wedding night. We'd reserved a suite at the Ritz-Carlton. Under her classic dress, Rachel was wearing the most wickedly gorgeous white lingerie. A lace demi-cup bra that made the most of her cleavage, matching thong panties, and sexiest of all, a garter and stocking set. I was exhausted from the long day, but it was an instant hard-on.

I threw her on the bed, slid her panties to the side and ate her out. Her hair there was darker, but closely trimmed. She has the tastiest pussy I've ever experienced. Hard to explain, but it feels like a mixture of pop rocks and honey on my tongue. She bucked up and down against my face. I sucked her clit into my mouth, my tongue flicking against her hard little bud. She grabbed my hair with both hands and pulled me tight, almost as if she were trying pull my head inside her. She came dramatically, with a robust cry of passion.

She pushed me off, onto my back, and immediately went down on me, swallowing me whole. Rachel is a very, very talented cock sucker. She stroked me firmly, circled my shaft with her tongue, took me deep so that I could feel the heat and wetness of her mouth against my entire shaft. I was close. She grabbed my balls, and squeezed firmly against the base of my scrotum to stop me from coming. I sighed in frustration. I'd been so close.

She ended my complaints by sliding off me, positioning herself on her hands and knees. If there is a prettier sight in the universe than a perfect ass, encircled with garters and lace, I don't know what it is.

I positioned myself behind her, again slid her panties to the side, pressed two fingers into her tight little pussy. She moaned and thrust back against my hand. I wanted to get my dick inside her, but that was just too sexy to stop. She reached between her legs, flicking her own clit. Again she came, this time her pussy clenching against my fingers.

Coming again drained her. She seemed ready to fall forward onto the bed, but I needed her first. I grabbed her by the hips, drove my cock inside her. She was loose, but amazingly hot and wet. I thrust inside her raggedly. She was on the pill, so no condom. I hammered her, hard. She moaned, reached between her legs to massage my balls. Then with a growl I came inside her.

We collapsed together onto the bed.

“Thank you for marrying me,” I said absurdly.

She laughed. “And thank you, Max, for fucking me silly.”

“You bring out the best in me.”

“Promise me it will always be like this,” she said.

“Always,” I sighed.

Two years later, Rachel was pregnant. When the ultrasound showed twins, we went through the stages. Panic. Desperation. Depression. Resignation. Acceptance.

It is weird. Somehow the idea of having one kid was appealing. The kid would be a trooper. Would sleep through the night. We would trade off childcare, and each still have time off, and also time together. The idea of twins, though, seemed overwhelming. It was always a delusion to imagine that having a kid would be just a minor alteration of our lives. But we were not even given the option of indulging in that fantasy. Faced with the reality of twins, we had to accept that nothing would ever be the same.

Not that things were perfect anyway. Not really. We still got along well. We worked well together as a couple. We had similar values, interests. But we were both working long hours, only seeing each other when tired or stressed.

Sex was still good, but increasingly routine. Once or twice a week, but pretty much by rote. I'd let Rachel initiate. I was always willing, but by habit, it fell on her to signal interest first. We'd strip. I'd flick her bean, she'd stroke my cock. Then either me on top, or her. A few minutes of very pleasurable sex. She would come first. Then me.

Even routine sex is good sex. And we were having sex often enough to keep us both satisfied. But "satisfied" is a weird standard. Sort of a minimal expectation. It is weird to describe a regular, mutually satisfying sex life as a "rut." But what better word is there for something that becomes routine?

When we accepted twins were on the way, we realized we'd need more space. We moved out to a house in the 'burbs. Nice place, though we bought at the height of the market. Four bedrooms, a fenced yard.

The pregnancy was tough on Rachel. Given her small frame, carrying twins was particular difficult. She gained a lot of weight, had blood-pressure issues. She had twelve weeks of maternity leave, but burned through more than half of it on bed rest even before the twins came.

It became almost a foregone conclusion that she would want or need to drop out of the workforce for a while to take care of the kids. Money wasn't really an issue. Even with the markets roiling, my firm was doing well; I was doing well.

But Rachel worried about how she'd deal with being a stay-at-home mom. She'd always been a hard charger. Graduated at the top of her high school class, prestigious college, a Wall Street internship for a year, then business school. Being primarily a homemaker would be quite a change of pace.

As it turned out, Rachel really enjoyed it. She brought the same kind of energy to childcare as she had to everything else. Play dates, educational

activities, trips to petting zoos, museums. But she also let the kids have the opportunity to be kids. She was a natural.

CHAPTER TWO

I can't say I was really surprised when Rachel told me she wanted to go back to work. She'd been out of the workforce for a little over five years since we had the twins, but with Brent and Allison now in all-day kindergarten, I knew she'd be feeling restless.

"Are you sure? We don't really need the money."

"Well, but we could always use more money."

I nodded. We'd talked about maybe buying a vacation home at some point. We were saving toward that, but it was slow going.

"Anyway," she continued, "it's not about the money. It's more that I can't see just sitting around the house all day eating Bon Bons."

"I doubt you'd do that."

She laughed. "No, probably not. I could write one of those idiotic mommy blogs or pester our school board about something. But it's time to get back out there unless I want to give up on a career."

"Whatever you want is fine with me. Just tell me what I can do to help."

She had a prepared list of action items. *Of course*. But I was happy to make the calls and send around her resume. As it turned out, she got a job through her own efforts.

It wasn't a great job. Or even a good job really. She was offered a position as an Executive Assistant to the CFO of a tech startup. She'd worked on that sector back at the mutual fund, so it was a match to her experience. It was a step down from where she'd been, both in terms of salary and responsibilities, but after five years, she needed something to get back into the workforce.

She was so excited her first morning, even nervous.

“Don’t worry. You’ll do great,” I offered. “I’ve already let Taylor know that you’re going back to work, so he knows I might have to leave early some days to cover the kids. Knock ‘em dead.”

She kissed me on the cheek. “Thank you! You’re being great about this.”

We’d already arranged for me to pick up the kids the first few days so that she wouldn’t be stressed about getting out of the office as she settled in. I picked them up early and took them to the park for an hour. We were sitting at the kitchen table, the kids eating pizza, when she came home.

It was obvious things hadn’t gone well. She looked shaken and immediately poured herself a glass of wine.

“Everything okay?” I asked.

“Later,” she mouthed in reply, nodding toward the kids.

She drained her glass and then plastered a smile on her face. She sat down with us and proceeded to ask the kids all about their day. They babbled happily. Brent, in particular, is a big talker, though at five years old, he often doesn’t make a lot of sense. Or more accurately, he often doesn’t make *any* sense. But he was happy and enthusiastic about school. Then Allison broke in and spent a good twenty minutes talking about the class hamster, Noodles, who she had signed up to take home this coming weekend.

After the kids’ dinner, we did their usual bedtime routines: Baths, reading, cuddling. We finally got them down around 7:30pm, with Rachel doing the final tuck-ins.

I made a chicken and pasta dish for us. I poured us some more wine.

Rachel sat down heavily at the table and took a big gulp of Chianti. She dug into the meal.

“You okay?” I asked again.

She smiled wanly. “I didn’t have time for lunch.”

“Oh?”

She shook her head. “And my boss is an asshole.”

“Uh oh.”

“First thing he says to me is, I quote, ‘who the hell are you?’”

“He didn’t hire you?”

She shook her head. “No. That was through HR. I just got assigned to him. I guess I should have reached out and introduced myself before today, but it never occurred to me.”

“Well, he could have reached out as well.”

“Um, that doesn’t seem to be Mr. Stewart’s style.”

“You have to call him by his last name?”

She rolled her eyes. “Yeah, I called him Jack to begin, which was another mistake. I made a lot of mistakes today. Or at least, he seemed to think so.”

“Oh baby, I’m so sorry. You don’t need this. You can just...”

“Quit? After five years out of the workforce, I can’t see that quitting on my first day back is going to do much for my resume.”

“No, but –“

She cut me off. “I know, Max. We don’t need the money. And this job is not quite what I wanted... which is another thing that got me in trouble.”

“You didn’t say that to him?”

“No, of course not. He asked me about my background, and when I told him, he rolled his eyes and said, quote, ‘so you think you’re too good

for this job?’ So I had to reassure him that I just wanted to do a good job for him.”

“He does sound like an asshole.”

She shrugged her shoulders. “I’ll make the best of it.”

Things got worse. Every day Rachel seemed to come home with a new story of abuse and humiliation. He made her get him coffee, and snapped at her if it wasn’t right -- too hot, too cold, not enough sugar, too much milk.

He demeaned her about her work, especially if she had the temerity to ask him for clarifications on his expectations. He’d sigh, roll his eyes, then respond in baby talk as if it was all too obvious to misunderstand. Yet, he nitpicked at everything. Her work, according to him, was too slow, too sloppy. Nothing was right.

She tried to say it didn’t bother her. But I could tell the constant negativity was wearing her down.

There are two different types of assholes in the business world. The first is the get-things-done, doesn’t-suffer-fools-gladly type of asshole. The second is the drunk-on-his-own-power, bully-for-fun type.

I couldn’t imagine Mr. Stewart was of the first variety, mainly because I knew Rachel was better than he deserved. Yes, she’d been out of the workforce for five years, but even still, the idea that she was some simpleton unable to perform basic office tasks was laughable. No, he was a bully, pure and simple. I imagined he might even have felt threatened by Rachel and her background. Or maybe he just hated women.

I advised her to quit at least a dozen times when she came home in tears or close to them. But each time she rebuffed me. It became like a trial she was determined to overcome, dealing with his bullshit a mark of pride.

And slowly things got better. Rachel didn't seem to need a glass of wine first thing after getting home as often. Then she started referring to her boss as Jack rather than Mr. Stewart. Slowly her confidence returned. She still had Jack stories. He was still an asshole. But she increasingly seemed wryly amused by him rather than frustrated.

With us both working, we had less time for each other. So we were determined to have regular date nights. Her mom came to visit, and Rachel and I decided take advantage of it to go out to dinner at a trendy restaurant downtown. I got there early and sat at the bar to kill time. I ordered a martini and checked out the "scenery."

I wouldn't say I have a roving eye. I don't. I don't look for hookups. But I like women. I like looking at them. Some people like art. For me, I'd rather check out a little taste of cleavage, a pair of big blue eyes, even a nicely done set of painted nails.

I had just sat down when, out of the corner of my eye, I sensed rather than directly observed a sexy girl walk by. As she passed me, I turned to check out her ass. Yummy. A perfect heart-shaped ass, moving with a sexy shimmy, encased in a charcoal grey pencil skirt. I watched the girl reach the end of the bar and then turn back toward me. I glanced up at her face and was met by Rachel's smile.

It marked the return of was her world-class ass. Not that it had ever really gone away. She lost the baby weight almost immediately. But for the next five years, she usually dressed pretty casually in sweat pants or mom jeans.

There is something weirdly exciting about lusting after a random woman in a crowd and having it turn out to be your wife.

“Hey baby,” I said as she approached. “You look great.”

She grinned. “Were you checking out my ass?”

“I didn’t know it was yours,” I admitted

“Are you telling me you look at other women?”

“Every chance I get. Because, you know, I’m a man. And that’s what we do.”

“You’re telling me,” she said with an amused sigh.

It was the same tone she’d taken to using when describing her boss’s latest outrageous behavior.

“Jack?”

She nodded. “He liked the skirt too.”

“What? Did you catch him looking?”

She shrugged. “That would have been okay.”

“He said something?”

“I’ve learned to ignore two-thirds of what he says. Maybe even three-quarters...”

“What did –”

She cut me off. “Do we have to talk about my asshole boss? Shouldn’t you be offering to buy the girl with the nice ass a drink instead?”

“So now that you’re back at work, I need to get you drunk to get laid?”

She shrugged. “It can’t hurt.”

She was right. After a nice, boozy dinner, we went back home and had a very pleasurable night in bed. Rachel was particularly sensuous. She sucked my cock longer than usual, her technique wetter, sloppier than normal. She pulled me on top of her, raised her legs to the ceiling and with her hands on my ass urged me to fuck her harder, harder, until we both came hard, gasping.

Rachel's grey pencil skirt was a harbinger of things to come. Over the next few weeks, I noticed that she was dressing sexier. She was digging through her closet, pulling out and wearing clingier, more provocative outfits. She was also shopping a lot, buying clothes that were professional, yet stylish and sexy.

At one level, I got it. Most of her wardrobe dated from before we had kids and was as much as ten years old... an eternity in women's fashion. And it wasn't an issue of money. She wasn't breaking the bank. And it wasn't the clothes themselves. She wasn't dressing like a hooker or anything, just contemporary and attractive.

It seemed to make her happy. I liked looking at her in her new outfits. So what was the problem? It was one word: Jack.

By her description, he was now more of an incorrigible rogue rather than an abusive asshole. But she'd told me that he'd noticed her figure, commented on it even, and it was hard to avoid thinking about how he might be responding to her new, sexier attire.

Having an attractive wife results in complex emotions. I liked seeing Rachel dressed up, confident, appealing. And yet, I also knew that although she might only doing it for her own self-esteem, or even my enjoyment, she was out in public and other men were benefitting as well. As a man who likes watching women, I knew that all too well.

Whatever nagging concerns I had were routinely swept away by the fact that our sex life was better than it had been in years. She seemed to be in the mood more often than ever. She was again on the Pill, but I wondered if subconsciously she was pining for another baby. Or maybe it was instead just that the confidence boost of being back in the workforce turning her on. Whatever was going on, we were banging like newlyweds again.

Rachel was still the primary instigator. It wasn't real subtle. If she wanted to fool around, she'd often climb into bed naked. She was often amazingly responsive, her body hot like a furnace as I pulled her close. Foreplay seemed almost superfluous, not at all required to set the stage, but just a way of building our intimacy, drawing out the pleasure.

There is literally nothing more enticing than a woman ready for sex. Her hot, moist breath. Her erect, sensitive nipples. The wetness, tenderness between her legs. Feeling a woman responding to your touch... it is the ultimate in positive reinforcement. And that is what it was like almost constantly with Rachel. She was suddenly so ready, so eager, and sometimes even surprisingly kinky.

One night, after an early dinner, the kids had begged to watch some cartoons before bedtime. I was standing in the doorway to the family room, checking my email on my phone, listening to the kids singing along to the SpongeBob theme song.

Rachel reached out and grabbed me by the forearm and pulled me back into the kitchen. She pushed me back against the fridge and without a word, squatted down in front of me, grinning at me lewdly.

I went wide-eyed as I realized what she had in mind.

"The kids," I hissed, nodding toward the family room.

"We have eleven minutes," she replied, referring to the run time of an episode.

"Rachel, no," I said without conviction. My sweats were beginning to tent.

She rubbed my crotch and then firmly seized the waistband. She yanked down, freeing my cock. She locked eyes with me and began stroking my shaft up and down. She leaned forward and licked my prick,

starting near my balls and trailing all the way the underside of my shaft. She swirled my cockhead with her tongue and took me deep into her mouth.

“Oh God, baby,” I moaned.

I ran my fingers through her hair, letting the silky strands brush against my hands, feeling her head bobbing up and down on my prick.

It was amazing, but I was too anxious to come. With every sound from the next room, I worried that the kids were about to burst in on us. But despite that, it was incredibly hot -- furtive, sudden, unexpected.

We heard the episode end. Rachel let my cock slip from her mouth with audible plop. She stood quickly and I jammed my erection back into my sweats just as the kids rounded the corner, asking for dessert and anticipating the beginning of their bedtime routine.

She came to bed naked that night, her body blazing. I had planned to question her about the impromptu hummer, but her passion was just too urgent to resist.

I slid beneath the covers, the scent of her excitement almost overpowering. Her pussy was drenched, swollen. I licked her slit up and down, my face quickly becoming coated with her juices. She grabbed my hair and pulled me against her as she began to gasp. She came hard, humping my mouth with her sex.

She released me and I moved up between her legs. We kissed wetly. She licked me, seemingly eager to taste herself on my lips.

“What’s gotten into you?” I asked.

“Nothing yet,” she sighed.

She reached down and wrenched off my PJ bottoms. I was rock hard. I stabbed wildly between her legs with my erection, plunging deep into her

drenched, steaming cunt.

She grabbed my ass, urged me to fuck her harder, even as she continued to kiss me so passionately that it felt like she was trying to swallow my tongue. If she hadn't been so wet, I would have come right away. As it was, I started doing multiplication tables in my mind to keep from finishing too soon.

It was a hopeless effort. She was just too hot. She wrapped her legs around my waist, sucked on my ear.

"Oh fuck," I cried out as I climaxed.

I collapsed on top her, both of us breathing hard.

"That was fun," she said with a giggle.

"I'll say. You were on fire."

We kissed and I rolled off her. We lay side by side on our backs, holding hands.

I hesitated. As quick as it was, it had been the best sex we'd had in years. But I couldn't help looking the gift horse in the mouth.

"So, Rach? What's going on? Why the sudden outburst of passion? In the kitchen I mean."

"I don't know," she replied. "I was just thinking about how great you've been recently, what with you picking up the slack around the house with me going back to work. I just thought I'd give you a treat."

"It was definitely a treat."

"I liked it too. It felt so dirty, you know. I couldn't stop thinking about it after. I couldn't wait to get you into bed."

"So, that's it?" I pressed on gingerly.

There was a half-second pause, just barely noticeable. "Yeah, what else could it be? Am I not allowed to show my appreciation to my wonderful husband?"

I forced a laugh. “Of course, baby. You just took me by surprise.”

But there was something weird about it. Something that made me uneasy. I’d been quietly wishing for a little more passion for years now, but when it happened, it somehow felt wrong, out of place.

CHAPTER THREE

My firm was involved in a major acquisition. I was crunching the data. Every day seemed to bring a new mass of numbers to examine, so I had a little less time to help with the kids.

Happily, Rachel's work situation had improved to the point that she was a bit more flexible on her end. I was a little surprised. Jack hadn't seemed like the kind of guy who'd be willing to show that kind of consideration, although, in truth, it had been a while since she'd complained of his abuse. Indeed, in our conversations, he often now came across more as a jokester than anything else.

He still had a dark side, though. Rachel told me of a crisis at work. One of their significant projects was coming in way, way over budget. Or so it seemed. As it turned out, the project manager, a young techie named Dave, in his first management role, had miscoded a tracking spreadsheet.

Rachel found the mistake quickly and informed Jack. But they decided not to tell Dave. Instead, they let him spend the day thinking he'd fucked up, that he might have to fire half his programmers, that his future was screwed. It struck me as a cruel prank. But Rachel giggled through the story as she described him coming by the CFO suite over and over, apologizing and bemoaning his fate.

"Poor kid," I said finally.

"Oh come on Max, it was only a few hours. And it was *his* own fault."

"I guess," I replied warily. Her lack of empathy surprised me.

"It's a good lesson for him. In a lot of places he'd have just been fired."

"Maybe."

She frowned. "I thought you'd find it funny."

"I guess it is funny," I said, forcing a laugh.

I wasn't looking for a fight. In the end, what did I care about how Jack treated Dave? They were just names to me, not actually people. Still, it did feel more like hazing than seizing a teachable moment. It occurred to me that Jack had done the same thing with Rachel when she'd first started working there. It was odd that she'd come to identify with Jack rather than Dave as a result.

I had just put the kids down and told them to go to sleep. I knew they wouldn't right away. They loved chatting and giggling until they both dozed off. Even though one was a girl and one was a boy, they insisted on sleeping in the same room. A twin thing. I wondered how that would play out as they got older.

I walked into the kitchen. Rachel was wiping down the kitchen counter. Damn, she looked great. She was still wearing her work clothes, a tight skirt, heels.

I walked over and slid my hand up her thigh, under her skirt. She would normally have giggled and pushed me away with a mock, scolding, "Stop it, silly."

This time she instead sighed and jutted her ass out toward me.

"That feels nice," she cooed.

I was pleasantly surprised. I ran my hand further up her thigh. I felt her hand cup mine, encouraging me go to higher. My fingertips tickled her inner thigh, relishing the soft, warm skin. I brushed against her panties, expecting her to now push me away. But she didn't. Instead, she began to roll her hips slightly.

I cupped her ass, slid my hand between her legs. Her panties were damp. I could feel the heat coming from her pussy. I massaged her sex through the silky fabric. She gasped and bent at the waist, her hands sliding forward until her chest rested on the counter.

I pulled her panties aside, ran my fingers along her slit. Her labia split, giving me access to the wetness within. I pressed a finger inside her. She moaned and thrust back against me.

I hesitated. This was so novel, so unexpected. We had sex in bed. Period.

“What are you waiting for?” she prompted. Her voice was husky.

I lifted up her skirt and rubbed her hard ass. My finger was still inside her. She was so wet, so hot. I was in a sexual fog.

I don’t even remember dropping my pants, but suddenly there I was, my slacks around my ankles, my hard prick in my hand. I stepped forward and rubbed the head of my cock against her pussy. Her swollen labia seemed to grasp at my cock, trying to pull it inside.

I entered her slowly, tentatively. I needn’t have worried. She was so ready that my cock slid into her without resistance. I fucked her slowly, relishing the feel of her pussy, but also shocked at the situation. Was I really screwing my wife bent over the kitchen counter?

She was fully dressed. Her skirt hiked up over her ass, her panties merely pulled to the side. A slut giving her man a quickie.

“Harder,” she hissed.

Her request hit me like a lightning bolt. I grabbed her hips, drove into her roughly. She moaned sensuously, the best kind of encouragement. I pumped my cock into her over and over. She reached back between her legs, squeezed my scrotum.

She looked back at me, over her shoulder. Her blue-grey eyes were half-lidded with passion. Her full lips pursed, moist. She was gasping, grunting. And then suddenly her eyes seemed to roll back in her head as her pussy began to clench of my rod. I gasped. I'd rarely seen anything sexier. I came inside her, thrusting raggedly.

Because of the big deal we were working on, I was working long, often unpredictable hours. As a result, Rachel was doing the same, working late to make up for those days when I couldn't take care of the kids.

Most mornings I got up first and went into work before Rachel even got up. But one morning, I asked to sleep in. The deal we were working on was with a Chinese firm, and we had a big conference call planned. I knew it would be a late night for me.

I was half-asleep, half-awake as Rachel got ready. She came out of the shower wrapped in a towel, and I watched as she put on her underwear, a very sexy matching lace panties and bra set. It occurred to me that in addition to new outfits, she'd also restocked her lingerie. I'd been admiring it on occasion when she stripped down and came to bed in the evenings, but suddenly it occurred to me that she might not be wearing it in preparation for going to bed, but rather in anticipation of going to work.

For the first time I admitted to myself what had been bothering me for weeks: The weird, nagging sensation that my wife was having an affair.

I shook my head, trying to banish the thought from my mind. I had no evidence, after all. But how much of that was just because I didn't want to find evidence?

I heard her wake the kids, get them dressed. I could hear snippets of their conversation downstairs as she got them ready for school.

She was acting so normal. No weird late-night phone calls, no unexplained absences. But, of course, if what I suspected was true, there was no need. She was spending eight hours a day or more, every day, with her lover.

Again I tried to purge my fears. This was all just paranoia on my part. Jack was an asshole. And Rachel knew better than to have an affair at work. He'd be the last person with whom she'd cheat.

I heard her shooing the kids out the front door, her heels clicking on the tile in the foyer. Those heels. I suddenly imagined them up over his shoulders. I could picture her, on her back, lying on his desk, her skirt bunched around her waist, her panties pulled to the side as he fucked her with his big cock, her heels jiggling as he banged her hard.

No! I had to stop torturing myself. This was all in my head. These were just my own insecurities. They had nothing to do with Rachel, or with Jack.

And even if my fears were well grounded, so what? She was still a loving wife, an attentive mother to our children, my best friend. Would it be that bad if she did have a lover? I mean, what difference did it really make? I shuddered. What kind of man was I that I could even think those thoughts?

I had planned to sleep in, but instead I got up and took a shower. It would be a long day, but at least at the office I'd be too busy to worry about what Rachel was doing at work.

My ability to keep my fears at a distance collapsed abruptly just a few days later.

“What does your schedule look like the end of next week?” Rachel asked at dinner.

The Chinese deal had fallen through when I’d found a bunch of debt they’d tried to hide in a subsidiary, so I was actually pretty flexible. So much so that I’d actually been thinking of seeing if Rachel and I might be able to go out of town together for a couple of days. For a brief moment, I thought she might be about to propose the same thing.

“Actually, I’m open. I was thinking about taking some time off. Wanna shoot out to Vegas?”

She frowned. “Oh honey, I’d love to. But Jack wants me to go down to San Diego for a couple of days to meet with some of our investors. I was hoping you’d be able to cover childcare while I’m away.”

“Is he going too?”

She gave me a queer look. “Of course,” she answered cautiously. “I mean, he is the CFO.”

“You both need to go?”

“No, I guess I don’t need to go. But I think Jack would like to get me more in the mix of things. He knows I’m overqualified to be his Executive Assistant. I think he’d like to promote me to Assistant CFO.”

“That’s very considerate of him.”

She eyed me suspiciously.

“Max, is everything okay? You’re being a little weird.”

“Am I?”

She hesitated. “A little. Do you not want me to go?”

“Why wouldn’t I want you to go?”

She sighed.

“I feel like we’re talking in riddles,” she replied. A note of frustration had crept into her tone.

I shook my head quickly. I had no reason to suspect her. Meeting with investors was a perfectly legitimate reason to travel out of town. And I also realized that if she did get a promotion it would likely involve at least some travel.

“I’m sorry,” I said. “I guess I’ve just gotten used to you always being around. Go ahead. I can take care of the kids. You just do what you need to do.”

“Okay.” Pause. “Thank you. I’ll try not to make a habit of it. But Jack really wants me there for this meeting. It could be a good opportunity, and I think I should go if I can.”

She was speaking fast, not quite making eye contact with me. It felt almost like she was trying to talk herself into it.

She packed the night before her trip. Her suitcase sat on our chest of drawers that night as we went to bed. It felt like it was taunting me, a reminder that the next evening she’d be in a hotel, out of town, with her boss.

As if to reassure me, she’d been coming to bed naked every night for the past week. She seemed perpetually horny. She couldn’t seem to get enough of me. I’d never seen her this sexed up. And the sex was hotter, more adventurous than normal. She was louder. She moaned excitedly when I playfully spanked her ass. She bit my shoulder. She was now constantly encouraging me to fuck her harder, leaving bruises on my ass as she urged me on.

On the day of the trip, she woke me with a blowjob, and then climbed aboard. She sat upright, threw off the covers and rode me enthusiastically. I grabbed her boobs, squeezed them harder than usual. She moaned and her

pussy seemed to get even wetter. She ran her fingernails across my chest, leaving scratch marks on my skin. She was bouncing up and down hard enough that I actually worried that she might injure me. But it felt too good to protest.

She reached down and rubbed her clit as she rode me. She'd never done that before. It was so incredibly sexy, especially when she threw her head back and came with a lusty growl. I couldn't hold back. I came as well.

She gave me a big smile.

"That should hold for you a couple of days," she said.

"You too," I replied.

She nodded, though she seemed somehow unconvinced. She disentangled herself from me and walked sexily to the bathroom. I heard the shower turn on.

I glanced back over at her suitcase. I got out of bed and unzipped her bag. I sighed. Her intentions could not have been plainer had she packed a box of condoms. She'd packed tight skirts. A thin camisole. Silk blouses. Three pairs of matching sexy, lace underwear. A satin nightie. A pair of black, stiletto pumps.

I zipped up her suitcase and climbed back into bed.

She came out of the shower wrapped only in a towel. When she saw me propped up on my elbow, she dropped the towel and flashed me her naked body. Had she touched up her close-cropped triangle? I couldn't be sure.

"You sure you need to go?" I asked.

She didn't answer right away. She pulled on a pair of plain black panties, cute, but nothing like those she'd packed for Jack.

"I think so. Yes. It's something I need to do."

There was something in her tone that seemed to acknowledge this wasn't about work.

"You know I love you," I said.

She looked at me, a bit sadly I thought. Then suddenly she rushed me, kissed me hard, and wrapped her arms around my neck.

"I will always love you," she replied forcefully.

She broke the embrace.

Without making eye contact, she dressed. She reminded me about the kids' schedules. There were a couple of play dates. And Allison had become obsessed with wearing a particular pair of leggings. They were in the dryer. Then, fully dressed, she leaned over and kissed me on the cheek.

"Have fun," I said.

"Okay," she replied.

She grabbed her suitcase and left. I listened to her footsteps going down the stairs, then clicking across the foyer. I heard the front door open, then shut. I heard her car start up and I heard her drive away.

I sighed.

Then I got up and woke up the kids. It was another day.

CHAPTER FOUR

It is hard to describe what it is like to try to go through a normal day when all you can think about is the fact that your wife is currently with another man.

Of course, I didn't know for sure that she was "with" him. Just because she was excusing his obnoxious behavior, and dressing sexier, and always horny, and now going out of town on business with him... no, I had no real evidence. I was just being paranoid, right? Right? RIGHT?

Were they even meeting any investors? Were they going through the fiction of getting separate rooms? How long had it been going on? Did she do things for him that she wouldn't for me? Was he better? Bigger?

Still, it was all just speculation. And offensive. What was wrong with me that I couldn't trust my own wife, the mother of my children? Wasn't all of this just my own insecurity? My own sexism, misogyny? Was I just threatened by her getting back into the work force, annoyed at how the demands on her time inconvenienced me? Was this just about me wanting a "traditional" marriage?

I'd never felt that way before. I'd always been proud of Rachel, of her brains, her professional accomplishments. We met in graduate school after all. I'm a good liberal. I like strong women.

I pictured her on her hands and knees, encased in the sexy lingerie she'd packed, getting fucked hard from behind. Was he slapping her ass? Pulling her hair? Did she let him come in her mouth? On her face?

I shook my head. Where the hell had that come from? Is that what I wanted to do to her?

It was a rough night. I didn't sleep well. I tossed and turned, tormented by my imagination, my worries. I couldn't get them out of my head, couldn't escape my thoughts.

The contents of her suitcase had been the final straw. But what did it really show? What was I expecting her to pack on a business trip? Bulky flannel PJs? Jeans? I was overreacting. I had to be.

I heard a noise from downstairs. It was 4:30am, still dark outside. I sighed. The kids being up so early usually meant one of them had had an accident.

I pulled on my bathrobe, crept down the stairs.

"Brent? Allison?"

The light was on in the kitchen. I went inside. It wasn't the kids. It was Rachel, sitting at the breakfast table.

She looked up at me, her eyes wet, her cheeks tear-streaked.

"Rachel? What are you doing here?"

"I drove all night to get back. Oh God, Max, I'm so sorry."

She broke down into sobs.

I sat down next to her. "What's the matter?"

She looked at me. I knew of course. And she seemed to know I knew. She didn't speak.

"You're having an affair." I said. It was half a statement, half a question.

She nodded, but then added incongruently, "We haven't had sex."

"But you're planning to?"

She shook her head. "What? No. Of course not. I quit. I won't be seeing him again."

“I don’t understand then.”

“I’ve been inappropriate. Done things.”

She was being so cryptic. What the hell was she talking about? Was it just an emotional affair? I could feel myself getting angry, though I wasn’t sure if it was because she’d had an affair, whatever the fuck that meant to her, or because she was talking in riddles.

“Did you blow him?” I asked coarsely.

She turned deep red. “No. I mean, yes. Just tonight. Last night. Just for a minute. He didn’t. I stopped. That’s when it hit me.”

“Jesus, Rachel, what the fuck are you talking about? You’re not making any sense. Just tell me what you did.”

“Max, please. It doesn’t really matter —”

“It does to me, Rach. It does to me. I need to know. Tell me everything.”

She sighed and looked away. For a while she didn’t speak. Neither did I.

I put my hand on her arm. “Please Rachel. We can get through this. But I need to know. Just start from the beginning.”

She nodded.

“Can I have a tissue?”

I gave her the box.

She blew her nose and dried her eyes.

“God, Max, I don’t know how it happened. It was just step-by-step, and before I knew it...”

She paused and shook her head again in disbelief at her own memories.

“It started with just words. You know, he’d compliment my clothes, or say how lucky you were. Silly stuff and borderline inappropriate. But it was

back when he seemed to hate everything I did. I should have stopped it then. But I didn't.

"He started getting more explicit. You know, now it wasn't just that he liked my skirt, but that he liked how I looked in that skirt, and then how my ass looked in that skirt. But it was just so gradual. I don't know. It didn't seem worth it to make a stink over it.

"Plus," she paused. "Plus, I don't know. Maybe I liked it a little? I liked the compliments. It felt fun, playful. You know, not like harassment."

"Is he good looking?" I asked. I'd never met Jack. I realized I didn't have any idea.

She blushed again. That was answer enough. But even still, she confirmed it.

"I guess so. Yeah, he's a good-looking guy."

I shook my head and thought ruefully about the Internet meme about how to avoid a sexual harassment charge: "First, be handsome. Second, be attractive. Third, don't be unattractive."

"He's tall, you know. Fit. Salt and pepper hair."

"George Clooney?" I asked.

She shook her head. "No, not quite. But... but that wasn't it. It was more like, you know, I was part of the club all of a sudden. I didn't want to be the prissy bitch who can't take a joke."

I nodded as if I understood, though I really didn't. "Okay, so then what?"

"Then one day I was wearing a sheer skirt, and he was like, 'There's no way you can be wearing underwear under that.'

"I assured him I was. He didn't believe me. He asked if I was wearing a thong. I told him it was normal panties. You know, it was just silly talk. Then he said, 'I still don't believe you. Prove it.'"

“You didn’t?” I said in shock.

“Not at first, but he kept working on me. He kept saying that he couldn’t concentrate on work knowing I was sitting out there bare assed. Then he threatened to ask for other opinions. You know, ask what other people in the office thought. And I thought, he’s just crazy enough to do it.”

She paused and took a deep breath.

“So I flashed him. Just pulled up my skirt real quick so he could see I was wearing panties. It was so silly. But then it became like a thing. You know, every day he’d come in and be like, ‘panty check’ and I’d go into his office and give him a quick peek.”

I gaped at her, open-mouthed. Who was this woman? Had she lost her mind?

“So, wait, you’re telling me that you just went along with it?”

She nodded. “I don’t know what to say. It didn’t seem like a big deal. It was just silly, a dumb in-joke, you know?”

“No, I guess I don’t.”

“It... shit... I dunno. You’re right, it seems crazy now that I think about it. But at the time, I got, I guess, a kick out of it.”

“Did you start wearing sexier panties for him?”

She blushed. “Yes. I’m sorry Max, but I did.”

“And?”

“It turned him on. He started getting more graphic. The peeks were getting longer, and he’d tell me how he’d like to peel them off and do... things... to me. Then one day he started rubbing himself through his pants while he talked.

“I couldn’t believe it. I was like, ‘Stop it. Are you crazy?’ And he was like, ‘you make me crazy.’ I told him I was leaving, he told me to stay. ‘Just

a minute,' he sighed. And then he came, I guess. I don't know. When he started moaning real loud, I ran out.

"But after, he came out and apologized. Said he was sorry that things had gotten out of hand. That he hoped it wouldn't affect our working relationship. I told him it couldn't happen again."

"But it did," I interjected.

She nodded. "Yeah. And then one day he didn't just rub himself through his pants. He actually pulled it out, you know?"

I couldn't believe it. "Your boss just exposed himself to you, and you didn't run?"

"Max, please. How many times can I say I was wrong?"

"I know, sweetie. I'm sorry, but this is all just crazy."

She nodded. "Can we stop now?"

I shook my head. "No. I'm sorry, but I need to know."

She sighed in frustration. "God this is so hard. I don't even recognize myself when I talk about it."

"We all make mistakes."

She blew her nose again and looked up at me, red-eyed. She swallowed hard.

"I'm worried. Worried that when I tell you the rest, you won't be able to forgive me."

"You didn't have sex with him," I said. "How bad can it be?"

"Bad. Bad because it's, I dunno, it's creepy."

"Rachel, please. You're just making it worse. Just say it."

She sighed. Then, "Fuck. Fuck. Fuck."

She began sobbing, quietly, staring down at the table. She knew better than to ask me to feel sorry for her.

There was nothing else I could say. It was on her whether she wanted to come clean, to try to rebuild our relationship. I knew I could never trust her if she didn't, but I also didn't know if I could trust her even if she did. I knew she wanted more reassurance before proceeding. But that wasn't something I could give. Not in good conscience.

She blew her nose again. She took a deep breath and composed herself.

Finally, she continued. "He played it cool for a while. You know, acting contrite. It was all a fucking act."

For the first time she seemed really angry with him. In a weird way, that was what I most needed to hear. That she felt used, resented him. Until now, she'd been letting him off the hook, and that suggested a residual affection I knew I couldn't live with.

"At first he acted like he felt guilty. He backed off. But then when he read my... my weakness... he went back at me hard. He said it was my fault he couldn't control himself. That I was teasing him. He made me actually feel guilty for having led him on. He said I owed him."

I could see it. He'd sucked her in. Made her feel like part of the team. Then suddenly made her feel like a traitor. He was good at this. Rachel was, I was sure, just the latest woman he'd work in this way. He was a predator.

"Rachel," I said softly. "What happened?"

"He said I owed him. That he wanted to see me without panties. He called me into his office, and said it was time. Said I'd teased him enough. That it was time for more.

"God, Max, I'm so sorry... but I did it. I stood in front of him, and I lifted up my skirt. And then I pulled down my panties."

"But it didn't stop there, did it?" I asked.

She shook her head.

“No. He touched me... there. I told him to stop. He called me a tease. He said I wanted it. And fuck, maybe I did. I didn’t stop him, didn’t push him away. I let him touch me. I let him, God... I let him put his fingers inside me. And while he did that, he pulled out his prick. He rubbed himself. And I couldn’t take my eyes off him. I just watched, watching as his fist pumped up and down his shaft while he... he molested me with the other hand.

“Then he took my hand. He put it on his prick and covered it with his own hand. I told myself, you know, that I wasn’t doing it. He was. It was him moving my hand. I dunno. I can’t explain it, Max. It was like an out-of-body experience. Like I was watching it all. Watching this slut, with her skirt bunched around her waist, a strange man’s fingers inside her, jerking off a cock.

“Up and down, up and down. He was so hard. Leaking on me. He was moaning. And then suddenly he came, you know, all over my hand and his...”

She stopped and gave me a surprised look as if she were suddenly realizing how much she confessed.

“I’m sorry,” she said softly.

“Sorry? Sorry?! What the fuck, Rachel? Have you lost your mind?”

“I don’t know. Maybe. I didn’t mean it to happen. It just did.”

“But that still isn’t all, is it?”

She shook her head sadly. “No, we did it again.”

“How many times?”

“Please Max, why does it matter?”

“How many times?” I repeated coldly.

“Five or six? Maybe more.”

“And what, always the same thing?”

“Yeah, I guess. More or less.”

“More or less? What does that mean?”

She grunted in frustration. “More or less. One time he dragged me into a storeroom and dropped his pants. He told me he wouldn’t let me leave until I took care of him. What choice did I have? I was worried someone would walk in on us. Another time he bent me over his desk and played with himself while he molested me from behind. One time we did it while we were both on a conference call. Okay, Max? Enough details? Or did I need to tell you how many fingers he used? Where his come went?”

I snorted.

“You’re mad at *me* now?” I snapped incredulously.

She started to answer, but stopped herself. She took a deep breath. “No. But I wish you were not making me relive it. It was a mistake. I’m sorry.”

I looked away, thinking. It seemed like a nightmare. I couldn’t process any of it. Not really. My wife bent over her boss’s desk, her skirt bunched up around her waist, his fingers in her cunt, as he jerked off onto her ass? It was unimaginable. And yet, I knew it was true. I could hear it in her voice. And anyway I had suspected something like this for a while.

“Did he make you come?” I asked finally.

“Max...”

“Did he make you come, Rachel? When he was fingering you, did he give you an orgasm?”

She hesitated. I waited her out.

“Yes.”

“Is that why you went away with him?”

“It was for work.”

“Oh, and you weren’t thinking it would lead to more?”

“I knew,” she admitted.

I flushed with anger at her casual admission.

“So Rachel, tell me, why aren’t you on your back right now with his dick in your twat?”

“Would you have liked that better? It would let you feel even more superior, wouldn’t it?”

I shrugged. “Sure. Make this about me.”

“I came back here. I drove all night to get back here. To confess and apologize and make things right. And all you seem to want to do it make me crawl through the mud.”

I almost felt sorry for her. Almost. “You didn’t answer my question. What happened in San Diego? Why did you decide to come back?”

“I... I don’t know. Jesus Max. It just hit me, you know. We got to the hotel. He’d gotten just one room with a king bed. Not even any pretense. And once the bellhop left, he was immediately all over me. He pushed me to my knees and pulled it out. I was in shock. I dunno. I didn’t stop him. And then he was in my mouth, just going back and forth.

“It was another one of those out-of-body sensations. And I was looking around. I saw the bed. And the TV. And the flyer for Papa Johns. And mini-bar. And I dunno. It just hit me. What the fuck was I doing? I didn’t even like this guy. Why was I blowing him in a hotel room?

“So I stopped. I told him I couldn’t do it. His voice got real low. He called me ‘baby.’ Told me how much he liked me, how special I was, trying to romance me now. But suddenly the very sound of his voice was repulsive. I told him that I quit. I grabbed my bag and went back to the airport. And when I couldn’t get a flight, I rented a car and drove back, through the night.”

I was too angry to engage. All I wanted to do was hurt her. “God, you’re pathetic.”

She didn’t dignify that with a response. I could feel her eyes on me, but I refused to look at her.

For a long time, neither one of us spoke.

Then finally, she said, “So, Max, can you forgive me? Can you ever forgive me?”

I continued to look away. I couldn’t bring myself to make eye contact.

“I don’t know, Rachel. I really don’t know.”

She sobbed, swallowed, and then let out a small laugh. “Well, at least that isn’t a no.”

Part of me wanted to hug her. Let her off the hook. But I was too angry. I just turned and walked out of the kitchen.

CHAPTER FIVE

We went to marriage counseling. I didn't quite know what to expect. But we both knew we'd need help to work through the situation.

Finding a counselor was a bit of a challenge. I didn't feel comfortable with a man. It just felt too emasculating to have to discuss it with a guy. We ended up with a youngish woman, Michelle Martin. She was plump, with long, stringy brown hair and thick glasses. She had a kind voice, listened well.

Initially, we didn't even address the infidelity. Instead, Michelle began by asking us why we were together.

That's actually a hard question to answer. Or at least it is hard to answer honestly in front of your significant other.

"We love each other?" I offered tentatively.

Michelle suppressed a smile. I'd given the clichéd, easy answer. And I'd added a question mark to it. It wasn't an honest answer. It was my attempt to give the "right" answer. A lot of marriage therapy, it turns out, is about overcoming the impulse to provide pleasing answers rather than honest ones.

"What does that mean to you?" she pressed.

"That we like being together?"

She nodded to show she'd heard me, but her lack of response otherwise made clear that I was still not getting it.

"I guess, that doesn't help, does it? You asked why we are together and I replied that we like being together."

She tilted her head. "Go on."

“I guess I don’t know how to answer,” I replied after another few moments.

“Well, that is something we need to work on,” she said gently.

Being the victim of an affair by your spouse is a complicated thing. The word, victim, hints at it. You’re hurt. But in a weird way, having been victimized gives power. For weeks after her confession, Rachel was walking on eggshells with me. She was always kind, solicitous.

I wish I could say the same, but instead I got perverse pleasure from picking at the wound, forcing from her additional displays of guilt and contrition. She’d hurt me and I was hurting her back.

After a while, the victim becomes the abuser, the cheater the new victim. I think it is that tit-for-tat cycle that destroys the marriage as much as, or more than, the original illicit sex.

Counseling helped me recognize that pattern, recognize the destructiveness of it. If you want to rebuild the relationship, you need to stop adding toxins to the mix. That’s one of the weird paradoxes of this sort of thing. The way out requires more restraint on the part of the victim than of the cheater.

But nothing is easy. Even as I recognized that and learned to bite my tongue, learned not to go for the cheap jibe at every turn, it triggered a response from Rachel. She felt guilty. My anger in a weird way let her off the hook. My quiet disappointment ate at her more deeply.

It was very, very fucked up.

It was three weeks before we had sex again. When the man cheats, it is, I guess, pretty common for the wife to withhold sex for months, or more, as punishment. But I didn't want to go without sex. Even though things were very, very raw, that was something I wasn't willing to give up.

I've said that even bad sex is good. Our experience after Rachel's admission put that adage to the test.

We were in bed talking, as had become usual, about our day, vomiting out details, minutiae, irrelevant shit that created the illusion of conversation without requiring any real involvement.

She was wearing a long tee shirt. Nothing else. I had noticed. I was sick of jerking off. I reached over and cupped her breast. She startled, but didn't push me away.

I leaned over and kissed her. She kissed back, following my lead. This was new for us, and awkward. She'd initiated sex for the most part. I wasn't feeling very romantic. It was more instrumental.

I continued to cup her breasts, circling her nipples with my thumb, feeling them harden at my touch. I began to pull up her tee shirt. She finished the process and lay back on the bed naked. I continued to fondle her.

She reached into my pajamas and began stroking me. It was oddly mechanical, but effective nonetheless. I stiffened. She ducked beneath the covers and pulled down my bottoms. She took me in her mouth, her tongue circling my shaft.

I couldn't help it. I pictured her on her knees in that hotel room, bobbing up and down on Jack's cock. In my mind's eye it wasn't the quick scene she'd described. I imagined her making love to his prick, slobbering over it, her tongue circling the head, her hands fondling his balls.

The image sickened me, and yet it didn't. I was still erect. Rachel was working hard. That was most of it... maybe.

I reached down and pulled her up toward me. I moistened my fingertips, explored her pussy. She moaned loudly. It felt forced. She wasn't wet enough to match that level of excitement, but she was ready enough at least.

I rolled on top of her. She spread her legs wide. I entered her slowly. She moaned again, even louder than before. I knew now that she was definitely faking. At that moment, I didn't really care. I just wanted to take my pleasure.

I thrust into her harder, faster.

"Oh God," she cried out after a few minutes.

She grabbed my ass hard and shuddered. I felt her pussy squeezing my cock, though not the rapid, spasming I was used to, but rather three firm contractions. She sighed and lay back on the bed. A passable performance if I'd been a stranger, but I knew Rachel too well to be fooled.

Her faked orgasm made me wonder what else she'd lied to me about. Was I really supposed to believe she accompanied him to a hotel out of town without having fucked him already?

I imagined her on his desk, naked, her legs over his shoulder. I could see him hammering his fat cock into her pussy. Imagined her boobs jiggling violently. I could see her head swinging back and forth in passion. Screaming in ecstasy as she pinched her nipples.

The image encouraged me to thrust harder. Rachel was urging me on, a weird forced cheeriness to her tone.

"That's so good, honey, so good."

I wished she'd just shut up. I hated that the Rachel in my bed was obviously less excited than the Rachel in my imagination, though I knew

that my imagination was a projection of my own anger.

Fuck, I couldn't get out of my own head long enough to enjoy it. I just wanted it to be over. I thrust into her hard, kept my cock inside her and pretend to come as well.

I pulled out and lay beside Rachel. She gripped my hand.

"Mmmm, that was nice," she sighed.

"Yeah," I replied. *No, it fucking wasn't.*

Her affair hung heavily over us for weeks after. We seemed to be trying to avoid anything that would be a reminder of her time with Jack. That didn't leave much. No flirting, no sexy lingerie. Their affair had been very heavy on manual manipulation, and that felt weird. I didn't want to eat her out. That felt too submissive for the moment. She relied on me to initiate sex, which was never comfortable to me. I was actually longing to get back into our old rut.

I was pretty sure Rachel was as dissatisfied as I was, even if she was pretending otherwise. Then one night she essentially confirmed it.

I woke up to find her side of the bed empty. That wasn't like her. She usually slept like a log. Despite the tensions between us, I still worried about her. I wondered if she might be sick or if maybe the kids had woken her.

I got up and walked down the hall. The kids' room was quiet. I crept down the stairs. All the lights were out. I began to get a little freaked out. In the foyer, I grabbed an umbrella from the stand. Somehow I felt better with a "weapon" in my hand.

I noticed a light flickering from the family room, but no sound. Was Rachel watching TV with the volume down?

As I peered in, I got the jolt of a lifetime. She was sitting in front of the computer, headphones covering her ears, her nightgown bunched around her waist as she vigorously rubbed her pussy.

I'd never seen Rachel masturbate before. It was insanely hot. She was entranced, staring at the screen, her lips pursed apart, her tongue flicking out periodically. As I looked closer I saw that she was not just rubbing herself, but also sliding her finger in and out of her pussy.

It struck me suddenly. She was Skypeing with Jack. Even though she'd quit her job, she was still cheating on me. I was heartbroken at the realization, though I could feel my cock throbbing with excitement. Jesus, did I really like the idea of her being with Jack?

I needed to see him. Needed to see the image that had Rachel so hot.

I edged into the room slowly, keeping to the shadows along the wall. I needn't have worried. She was so mesmerized that I could probably have walked in playing the tambourine without her noticing.

I looked at the screen again and gaped in shock. She wasn't Skypeing with Jack. She wasn't communicating with anyone. She was watching porn. And not "women's porn," nothing romantic, not "couples' porn."

No, what she was watching was hardcore even by my standards. There was a woman, bound, her hands cuffed behind her back. She was on her knees, her face jammed into a sofa. A guy with a huge cock was ramming her pussy roughly from behind. They were both covered in sweat. Every few moments the man would roughly strike the woman, spanking her ass, battering her tits, slapping her face.

Rachel was staring, rapt, frigging herself with ever-increasing intensity as the action on the screen ramped up. Then sudden I saw Rachel shudder, her body convulsing in waves.

She slumped in the chair, sighing loudly, her eyes still glued to the screen. She continued to rub her pussy, slowing now.

I backed out of the room quickly and jumped back into bed. A few minutes later she returned, padding silently. She climbed into bed as cautiously as possible.

I pretended to be asleep, but I was still hard. The image of Rachel playing with herself ran through my head, as did snippets of the porn she'd been watching. It might have been my imagination, but I thought I could feel the heat radiating from her body, smell her sweat and excitement.

CHAPTER SIX

In therapy we'd moved on from listing reasons for us to stay together to exploring how we communicated.

"Do you feel Max listens to you?" Michelle asked Rachel.

Rachel nodded. "Usually. I mean, I know I'm sometimes needy and he's humoring me."

"What do you think, Max?" Michelle redirected.

"I guess. I mean, yeah. Look we've been together for a decade. I don't hang on her every word anymore."

I looked over at Rachel. She nodded.

"And I think that is okay," Rachel said. "I'm not under the illusion that everything that comes out of my mouth is of earth-shattering importance."

"But?" Michelle prompted.

Rachel hesitated, thinking. "But... but nothing. No, I get it. I know what you're hinting at. The idea that Max takes me for granted, ignores me..."

"I don't," I snapped defensively.

Rachel reached out and put her hand on my forearm. "Slow down."

She turned back to Michelle, "He really doesn't. I wish it were that simple, you know? I wish he were a crappy, self-involved, indifferent husband. That would make it easy. But he isn't. That's not it. I didn't... Max didn't push me into... Jack's arms by being emotionally distant."

"So what did happen?" I asked. "Why?"

Rachel looked at me sadly. "I don't know."

"You don't know? Or you don't want to say?" Michelle pressed.

"I don't know," Rachel replied.

It was only hours later that it occurred to me how ambiguous an answer that was.

We had just finished another crappy bout of love-making. I'd managed to come this time, but only by giving my mind free reign. I finally blew my load as I imagined Jack taking Rachel from behind, fucking her up the ass, and coming on her face.

It was fucked up. The only way I could get a hardon, achieve an orgasm, was to conjure up a picture of my wife being manhandled, abused, humiliated by her lover.

"Mmmm, that was nice," she sighed.

"Yeah... actually, Rachel, no. It was fucking awful."

I gasped as I said it. Holy shit, had I really just said that out loud?

Rachel seemed equally shocked. "What did you say?"

Her tone was a weird mixture of disbelief, anger, and, I think, relief.

I sighed, swallowed hard. "Oh, come on Rach. You've been faking it for weeks."

"No... I..."

"It's not going to get better if we keep lying about it."

"I'm not lying..."

I sighed. "Forget it."

For a while we just lay there, side-by-side, naked, post-coital and yet it felt as if we were separated by a fence a mile high.

"Do you want me to leave?" she asked finally.

"Is that what you want? Has Jack invited you to move in with him?"

"Fuck you," she hissed. She reached over and slammed me repeatedly with her forearm across my chest. "Fuck you, Max! Fuck you! Fuck you!"

She finally stopped.

“That fucking hurt,” I said softly.

“It’s not what I want,” she said. “It’s what you want. I want to try to make this work. But you hate me.”

“No, don’t deny it,” she snapped as I took a breath to speak. “I just don’t know what to do. I don’t know how to make this better. We spend all our time in therapy talking about what we want, about fucking trust, about the kids. But the truth is, you hate me, and you don’t want this to work.”

“You’re blaming me again.”

“What do you want me to say, Max? I’m a fucking whore. I let my boss play with my cunt. I jerked him off. I sucked his cock. It was the biggest fucking mistake of my life.”

“It wasn’t one mistake.”

She sighed. “Jesus Christ, Max. No, it wasn’t. It happened a bunch of times. What the fuck does it matter if he fingered me once or ten times? Who cares how many times I jerked him off? Is that it, Max? Three handjobs you can forgive? Five you can’t?”

“No, it’s not that. Fuck Rachel, I just don’t know how I can trust you.”

“You want me to wear a tracking chip, like our fucking dog?”

I sighed. “Again, I’m the unreasonable one?”

She paused and then took a deep breath. “Max, look, I love you. I’m so sorry. But I don’t know that I am strong enough to do this. You’re right to be angry. And I guess you’re right not to trust me. But if that’s that, then that’s it, and we’re just killing time. Delaying the inevitable.”

“That’s not what I want,” I replied firmly. It wasn’t. “I just don’t know how to get back to where we need to be.”

“You’re going to need to trust me... but it’s more than that. You’re going to need to find me sexually desirable again. To see me as something

other than a piece of spoiled fruit.”

“Jesus, Rachel, I don’t...”

“Fuck Max, you want to be honest or not? You’re disgusted with me. You’ve just been fucking me to drop a load. You don’t think I can sense that I am nothing more than a blow-up doll to you right now? You expect me to come when you make me feel like nothing but a convenient hole?”

She sighed. “Whatever. If that is what you need, I can do that. It is my penance. But I don’t know if that *is* what you need. And I don’t want to keep doing this if you can never again trust me.”

I couldn’t help but laugh. “Penance? I didn’t think members of the Tribe did that.”

“Oh sure,” she replied with a chuckle, “it always comes back to that. See, your grandma was right, you shouldn’t have married a Christ killer. Don’t worry, though. Yom Kippur is coming up. I’m sure there are some prayers I can say to make it all right.”

“Well, sure, but you’ll never wash away the taint of original sin.”

“That was Adam.”

“Yeah, but Eve, that whore, was behind it.”

She laughed. “See, you could have avoided all of this if you’d married a dude.”

“Don’t tempt me. Pizza, beer every night. Sports on the TV...”

“A dick in your mouth...”

“Well, you seem to like it...”

I held my breath. Too much?

She giggled. “Don’t knock it ‘til you try it.”

I laughed.

“Okay, so what do we do now?” she asked.

“I dunno. To tell you the truth, I just don’t know. But maybe this is what we should be talking about in therapy.”

We sat down, the three of us, Rachel, Michelle, and me. At first it had felt like Michelle was between us, with Rachel and I farther apart. Then it had become an equilateral triangle. And now, somehow, it seemed like an isosceles triangle, with Rachel and I closer than either of us was to Michelle. The chairs hadn’t shifted. It was all about emotion.

“So, what shall we talk about today?” Michelle asked.

I looked at my wife. She looked at me. Neither of us spoke.

Finally, Rachel sighed. “Our sex life sucks.”

“Amen,” I said.

“Thanks, Max,” Rachel smirked at me.

I shrugged. “What?” But I was grinning as well.

Michelle suppressed a smile. “Okay, so, you two have started talking. And what have you figured out?”

Rachel jumped in. “An affair kills intimacy.”

“Yes,” Michelle replied. “But...”

Neither Rachel nor I filled the silence.

Michelle sighed. “Okay, so... you guys wanna keep talking about kids and jobs?”

“You giving up on us?” I asked

Michelle suppressed a smile. “Why would you say that?”

“Do these games really work?” Rachel asked.

Michelle fought harder, kept, barely, her poker face. “I have no idea what you’re talking about.”

Neither Rachel nor I spoke.

Michelle broke the silence. "Why are you here?"

"We want to, um, fix things," I replied.

Rachel nodded.

"Okay," Michelle replied slowly, "so how about a little honesty?"

She turned toward Rachel. "Look, you and Max love each other, right?"

My wife nodded.

"You seem to have similar values. You support each other. You actually seem to communicate pretty well. It doesn't seem like you were looking to sabotage the relationship."

More nods.

"So, what did Jack give you that Max doesn't?"

Rachel recoiled. She shook her head. "No. No. This isn't his fault. He's not... I didn't... it's not that."

Michelle sighed. "Okay."

Rachel flushed. "Fuck you. What the fuck do you know? This isn't about Max. It's about me. And just because you can't help us, that doesn't mean..."

"I'm sorry you feel that way," Michelle replied.

"No, you're not. You get paid either way," Rachel snapped.

Michelle shrugged. "Yes, I get paid by the hour. I admit it."

"Then maybe we need someone else," Rachel replied.

"Hold on," I said softly. Both women looked at me.

I took a deep breath. "Rachel, I appreciate you wanting to protect me. But Michelle is right. He gave you something, met some need. What was it?"

"I dunno," she muttered under her breath.

“You don’t know? Or you don’t want to say?” I pressed, repeating the question Michelle had asked weeks ago.

Rachel looked up at me through red-rimmed eyes. She began to speak, two, three times, but no words came out.

Michelle said, “Rachel, just because Jack provided something doesn’t mean that Max was falling short. It isn’t a competition between them. He’s just trying to understand what happened.”

I nodded. “It’s hard for me to trust you if I don’t understand what happened. And right now, I don’t understand it.”

Michelle continued, “And without trust, you won’t recover the intimacy.”

I put up my hand. “Okay, let’s not badger her,” I said. I didn’t want Rachel thinking we were teaming up on her.

“I... Jesus... this is so fucking hard.”

I knew better than to interrupt. I could tell she was working up to a difficult admission.

She sighed. She was wringing her hands, her eye in her lap.

“I was eighteen...” she began.

I looked up at Michelle who seemed equally surprised by this. After all, Rachel and I hadn’t even met until she was twenty-four.

“It was after graduation. I had gotten this internship, so I was supposed to be out all day. Which is why, I guess, my folks were willing to hire Tony to do some work around the house.

“He was an ex-con. There was this program, you know, to help these guys adjust to the outside world. My parents were good liberals and also, I guess, his salary was subsidized. So it was win-win.

“Well, anyway, I had thought my internship was for eight weeks, but it was just for four. But I didn’t tell my folks. I knew if they found out, they’d

make me get another job, and you know, I just wanted to hang out for a few weeks before college. So in the morning, I'd get up, pretend to drive to 'work,' and then instead head over to a girlfriend's house or whatever, get coffee, chill. Whatever.

"But then, one day, I decided to go home instead. I don't know what I was really thinking. Tony was there, shirt off, working on the railing of the pool deck, which annoyed me because I wanted to sit out there, but didn't feel comfortable with him there.

"It's not like he was that scary, at first glance. He was short, barely taller than me, but without his shirt on I realized he was much more muscular than I had thought. He was covered in these nasty tattoos. He was also older, like in his thirties. Totally not my type, you know. But, well, I kept spying on him through the window resenting that he was keeping me away from my own pool."

I could see where this was going, and found it oddly arousing. I still didn't know what this had to do with Jack, but I wasn't about to interrupt.

"So I put on my bikini and went out there. He was eying me. And I was so fucking... entitled... or something. It was like I was a fucking princess and that he'd never have the guts to approach me."

She laughed darkly.

"That lasted, like, five seconds. He walked right up to me. He asked me what I was doing at home. I told him. What could he do? He asked me if my parents knew. I told him to fuck off."

She paused.

"He grabbed my hair and shoved his hand down into my bikini bottom."

She was breathing harder.

“I told him I’d tell my parents. He sneered, ‘go ahead.’ Then he... then he took me.”

Shit. “Oh God, Rachel, I’m so sorry,” I sighed.

Michelle jumped in as well, “Rachel, it wasn’t your fault. Many young women, too many, are victimized this way.”

Rachel was shaking her head. “No! Fuck! You two don’t understand a fucking thing. He didn’t assault me; I seduced him. I loved it,” she said furiously. “For a week that man... did things to me. He ordered me around. He used me as his plaything. And... I loved it.”

I looked at Michelle. She was staring open-mouthed. It was as if she were out of her depth. She was a marriage counselor and suddenly we were in the realm of sexual trauma.

But we weren’t. Rachel wasn’t broken. She was embarrassed. She was looking at me, eyes red, but unwavering.

“Max, I have dark fantasies. I watch porn. And when I do, it is rough, dirty. I don’t want to see kissing, gentle caresses. I want to watch a dirty, cheap, slut being forced to service a man.”

I looked away. I knew. I’d seen it. But despite her admission, I didn’t mention it. I didn’t want to embarrass her further, or embarrass myself.

And now she was back in the present. “Being with Jack was like that time with Tony. God, he seemed to know just how to play me. Can you imagine how humiliating it was to have him molest me, bent over his desk, hearing people just outside the door? It was mortifying... and Jesus, Max, I’m so sorry. But it was so fucking hot.”

I stared at Rachel in shock. Who was this woman?

Happily, Michelle had recovered her equanimity. “Okay. Hold on.”

She looked at Rachel, “We all have sexual fetishes. As long as it doesn’t involve children or animals, there is nothing wrong with embracing

your desires. You have been amazingly honest. I suspect Max wishes he'd heard about this earlier."

I nodded.

"But," Michelle continued, "you two can build on this if you want."

I shook my head. "I don't know," I said. "I don't know what that means."

"That's what you're going to have to work on then."

CHAPTER SEVEN

The moment we left the therapist's office we recoiled from those admissions. I think Rachel was too mortified to bring it up. I was, frankly, more than a little freaked out by the whole thing. We retreated back into those banalities that we'd been using to avoid talking about real issues.

The cat was out of the bag. Even though it was now roaming the house clawing at the furniture, we both seemed to want to pretend it wasn't there. But I, for one, couldn't stop thinking about what Rachel had said. She was obviously equally consumed.

We managed to go to bed that night without any uncomfortable interactions. The kids and household chores provided a welcome distraction. But the moment I closed my eyes, I drifted back to the therapist's office. And from there to the pool deck.

I'd been to Rachel's parents' house many times, had swum in that pool, had soaked up the sun in those lounge chairs. The lounge chairs... is that where they'd done it?

The image in my mind was as clear as day. Young Rachel, eighteen, her body trim and tight, stomach flat, tiny bikini barely covering her perfect ass. And Tony, a wiry little punk, with corded muscles and skin stained with a jumble of dark blue prison tats.

She said he'd grabbed her hair, forced his hand into her bottoms. And then what? Had he forced her to her knees? Jammed his hard cock into her mouth? No, I could picture it. He'd torn off her bikini and pushed her to hands and knees on one of the loungers.

I could imagine her saying "no" in a plaintive, hissing tone, too embarrassed to shout out. I could see her expression, a mixture of shock and

fear, and then wide-eyed as he rammed his prick into her tight little pussy. And then the look on his face, turning from sneering intensity to a huge grin as he felt how wet she was for him.

“You love it, you dirty slut,” he’d have hissed.

“No!” She’d insist.

But her body would have given her away. Her pussy getting soaked as he plunged into her again and again, her hips moving in languid, sensuous circles despite her protestations. Had he pulled out and come on her ass? In her mouth? No, in my vision he finished inside her and then forced her to her knees, made her clean up his slimy prick.

I was closer than I realized. I shifted slight in bed, and as my cock pressed into the mattress I came in my pajamas with a groan.

“Are you okay?” Rachel asked.

“Yeah,” I replied quickly

I hoped she wouldn’t roll over and snuggle me. Happily, she seemed content to stay on her side of the bed.

Rachel spent the next couple of days avoiding eye contact. She was obviously embarrassed by her revelation. I probably should have done something to reassure her, to let her know that I didn’t think she was a freak, that I didn’t hold her in contempt.

But to tell the truth, I was just as happy not to have to address it. I wasn’t quite sure how I felt about it. And worse, I didn’t know what to do about it.

I realized right away that I would have to do something. The status quo was impossible. Rachel was too young, too energetic, too talented to remain locked away in our house like a wayward daughter consigned to a convent.

She was an active, social person, and that meant that she would meet other men like Tony or Jack.

What would happen then? And even if she did resist the temptation, how would that affect us? Would she resent me? Would she ultimately give in? Could I live with that?

Was there some way to “cure” her? God, did I even want that? I hated the sound of it. Did I want to encourage her to suppress her sexuality, like those religious fanatics peddling treatments for homosexuality? Well, I knew that answer to that. No, that wasn’t the kind of person I was, nor the kind of person I wanted to be.

The more I thought about it, the more I realized that at the very least we needed to talk. I dreaded the very idea of it. Even broaching the topic seemed like running a gauntlet. But it was that or just give up, and I knew I didn’t want to do that.

“Rach, can we talk?”

The kids were in bed. Rachel was in sweats, her hair in a messy bun, carrying a basket of laundry. I’d poured us two glasses of wine.

She nodded toward the pile of dirty clothes. “I really should do this.”

“No, you should do *this*,” I replied gesturing toward the end of the sofa where I’d placed a goblet of cabernet.

She hesitated, then slumped her shoulders. Looking a little like a condemned prisoner she took her seat.

She took a gulp of wine and looked up at me.

“I shouldn’t have said anything.”

I laughed. “Jeez, Rach. Good to see therapy is working if you feel that way.”

“Wait, you mean that’s not the lesson I should have learned?” She laughed as well. Then she added, “I don’t want to hurt you.”

“And I don’t want to lose you.”

She snorted. “You’d be better off if you did.”

I shook my head. “Am I allowed to make that decision for myself?”

“Max, you deserve –”

I cut her off. “Fuck Rachel, enough. Enough with the self-pity. God, that’s almost worse than what you did with Jack. You want to go, go. But don’t try to make it seem like you’re just sacrificing yourself for me.”

“I didn’t mean...”

I softened. “No, I know you didn’t. But let’s be honest about it. That’s the easy way out. I don’t forgive you; you don’t face any of it. We both nurse our resentments. Over time we turn each other into monsters. She’s a slut. He’s a controlling bastard. I know that’s not what you want.”

She nodded. “No, it isn’t. I don’t want to lose you and even more I don’t want to hate you, or you to hate me. But I wouldn’t blame you...”

I sighed. “Yes, yes, you’re a dirty, cheating whore. Okay, now that we’ve gotten that out of the way, can we talk?”

“I just... I just...”

“You don’t know what to talk about?”

She nodded.

“Well,” I suggested, “let’s begin with Tony and Jack.”

Her shoulders slumped again.

“God Rachel, I swear, I am not looking to score points. I am not looking to build a file against you. I just want to understand.”

She looked at me skeptically.

“Oh, you think you’re the only one with some sordid episodes in the past? I’ve had my one-night stands, my coyote ugly dates.”

“Coyote ugly?”

“You know, when you wake up cuddling a girl so ugly that you’d rather chew off your arm than wake her up and talk to her.”

She scrunched up her nose. “Ewww, that is so rude. Do guys really think like that?”

I laughed. “Oh, so now I’m the sexual deviant? But yes. Tequila is an evil bitch.”

“I’ll say,” she replied.

“Have there been others?” I asked.

She shook her head. “No, Max, I swear, the thing with Jack, it was a one time thing. I’ve never cheated on you.”

“No, I know that.”

It was weird. I didn’t really know it. Except I did. Somehow I did.

“I meant before you met me,” I clarified.

She rolled her eyes. “God, this is so embarrassing.”

“Why? You were single. Sowing your wild oats. It’s sort of hot actually.”

“Oh really, Max? Hot like cheerleaders banging the football team, babysitters screwing dads, hot like that?”

I shook my head. “Huh?”

“It is such a fucking cliché. Nice Jewish girl, her daddy is a doctor, and she’s got a taste for some rough trade.”

“Rough trade? Is that from a 1970s gay bathhouse?”

She raised her eyebrow.

I shrugged. “I read it in a book.”

She snarked, “It is almost as pathetic as a Southern belle craving dark meat.”

“Dark meat?” I laughed.

I'd never heard Rachel talking like this. I didn't even know she thought in those terms.

"You know what I'm saying," she continued. "It's like the plot of a bad porno."

I shook my head. "No. That would be a good porno. At least it would have some depth, some characterization."

"Maybe," she replied.

I noticed that she was less anxious. She had curled her legs beneath her, taken a sip of wine.

"We can discuss what makes a good fuck film later. But for now, will you answer my question?"

She hesitated, and then nodded.

"Yeah, it's always been my weakness. You know, in college, I knew I should be dating that serious pre-med guy, but I was always attracted to the bad boys."

"Were there a lot of bad boys at Brandeis?"

She laughed. "No. But," her voice rose into a high, giggly schoolgirl tone, "come on Brenda, let's check out that bar on Moody, I hear they have a cool band."

"And?"

"And, well, there weren't a lot of pre-meds there. Ugh. Band guys, townies... believe me, it was like a mutual understanding. Blue collar guys looking for slutty college girls, slutty college girls looking for..."

"Rough trade?"

She nodded.

"So, that was your college experience? Hit a bar, bang a construction worker?"

“Yeah. Not always. I mean, it’s always been more of a fantasy, but yeah, sometimes.”

“How often?”

She grimaced. “How many men have I been with that I couldn’t, wouldn’t, bring home to mom and dad?”

I nodded.

“Five or six, I guess,” she sighed.

I sighed as well, in relief in my case. I had been expecting, fearing a much bigger number.

She sensed my reaction.

“Really Max, how many men do you think I’ve slept with?”

“I don’t know. You’ve built this up so much that, well, I wouldn’t have been surprised if you said fifty.”

She groaned. “Oh God, Max, really? If that is what you thought, how could you stay with me?”

“I don’t know. I mean, what difference does it make?”

“So, you’d be okay knowing I’ve been plowed by fifty guys?”

“Plowed?”

“I’m just trying to use guy lingo.”

“Your command of guy lingo is a little unsettling... and I hate to say it, weirdly sexy.”

She gave me a strange look. “What is wrong with you?”

I was a little taken aback, but then realized what she was saying.

“Rachel, I’m not upset about your fantasies. I’m upset that you needed to go elsewhere to get them fulfilled. I don’t care what you did before me, either. I don’t think you’re weird or impure or whatever.”

“Even if I do?”

“Do you?”

She sighed. “A little. More than a little. There was always a lot of guilt associated with it. You know, I’d indulge it, and then hate myself.”

“Why?”

“Oh God, Max. Because it was inappropriate. Because I was too easy.”

“Those are different things.”

“Yeah, they are. The men I ended up with –”

“Men?”

She laughed. “You’re catching every detail. Yes. That was my mindset. College boys versus real men. I can’t really explain it. Having sex with older, dangerous men made me feel grown up. With college boys, I... I felt like I was doing them a favor.”

“And with me?”

“You weren’t a boy when we met.”

“But I wasn’t inappropriate either.”

“No. It was something of a point of pride for me that I was having a normal relationship and that it felt good.”

“But I never excited you the way...”

She put her hand on my forearm. “Max, please don’t.”

“Rach, I just want to understand.”

“Maybe there are some things better left unsaid.”

I wanted to press on. I wanted to get inside her head. Really understand. But I realized I’d pushed enough for now. And anyway, I was no closer to a solution. When Rachel finally got it all off her chest, what was I going to say?

CHAPTER EIGHT

I tried to do some research on my own. The Internet didn't provide any solutions. Type in "rape fantasies" in Google. Or, for Christ's sake, don't. We live in a dark, dark, weird world.

I wanted Rachel to be honest with me. But the reality is, I wasn't sure I could handle the truth if it turned out to be like what I'd seen online.

Even some of the things I read were wildly disturbing. The human mind is a weird thing. We cope with tragedy in strange ways. We eroticize our worst fears. We sometimes feel compelled to relive our most terrible experiences, in a strange way gaining control over them in the process. But it did make me wonder what had happened to Rachel as a girl. What had happened to make her, wearing nothing but a skimpy bikini, go out onto her pool deck occupied by an ex-con?

She had known what would happen. She was too smart not to. She went out there knowing she would be... what... propositioned... seduced... raped? Was that what she desired? Would she have been disappointed if he'd simply made a pass at her, taken no for an answer?

I didn't know. Couldn't know. Not until she confided in me fully.

And where had this come from? I shuddered at the worst case. Was her dad, Dr. Bernstein, an abuser? Jesus, was my sweet Rachel just reliving some horrible formative experience?

Still, I realized that we tend to pathologize female sexuality. If a woman just wants to get fucked, she's a slut. Damaged. A man with the same desires is just a man. I understood that intellectually. And yet, faced now with the fact that the woman I most cared about was attracted to dirty, unemotional sex, I didn't know how to react.

Women are supposed to want to be cherished. Protected. They're expected to like deep passionate kisses, slow tender sex. They want a deep emotional connection. Most of all, they want respect.

It is a fucking cliché. *Will you respect me in the morning?*

But that was not Rachel. At least not always.

I watched the videos, read the stories online. Could women really be the author of those scenarios? Even now, I doubted it. In the catalogue of degradation that I witnessed, it all felt like crude male fantasies, misogyny run amuck.

Still, there was something exciting about it. About the idea of taking a woman. Using her for my pleasure. It felt so wrong. So disrespectful, so uncivil. But also so hot. And if that was what Rachel wanted...

God damn, she looked good. The kids were at her folks, and she had just come back from yoga. Those stretchy pants were just obscene. She still had a sheen on her from the exercise. She'd be showering soon.

I thought of her soaping herself up in the shower, lathering up her breasts, her nipples firming under her touch. I could see her washing her ass, her hands rubbing her trimmed muff. Would she give herself a little tease, let her soapy finger slide along her slit, tweak her clit?

I thought to wait for her outside bathroom door with a bottle of champagne, usher her back into the bedroom. I would dip my fingertips in the bubbly, trace a line along her jaw line and lick it up after. Then another dip, more kissing and licking down her chest, circling her nipples...

But that was nice Max. Gentle Max. Considerate husband and lover Max. And I knew now that wasn't what she wanted.

Instead, I walked up to her, and firmly ordered, “On your knees, whore, and suck my cock.”

She looked at me in shock. I fought back the immediate urge to apologize.

“What did you say?” she asked.

Was I supposed to slap her? Grab her hair? Push her to her knees.

“I... I said, get on your knees and suck my cock.”

Her shock turned to amusement. She looked away.

“Um... okay,” she said softly.

Was I supposed to reprimand her for not calling me “sir” or something?

She edged down to her knees and looked up me.

Our eyes met. It was supposed to be fiery. Instead it was just absurd. We broke at the same time, laughing like maniacs. It made my sides hurt.

She tried to control herself. “I’m sorry, I’m sorry,” she said as she clawed at my pants. But she couldn’t stop giggling.

I grabbed her hands and sat down beside her.

“Well, that didn’t work,” I said with a chuckle, wiping away tears of laughter.

“You, you just took me by surprise,” she said. “Let’s try again.”

But the notion of repeating my demand seemed even more ludicrous now.

“Um, I don’t think so.”

Instead, I shooed her off to shower. After, we cooked together. I made the salad. She seared the shrimp. We opened a bottle of wine. We both wanted to talk about it, but neither of us broached the topic.

Instead, we cuddled up in front of the TV, under a blanket. We watched one of the kids’ movies, *Despicable Me 2*, which was just cute and harmless

enough for where we were emotionally.

Later, we climbed into bed and made love. It wasn't fiery. It wasn't hot. It was, however, for the first time since the affair, genuinely comfortable and enjoyable. When Rachel came during our lovemaking, as far as I knew for the first time in weeks, it almost moved me to tears, this time of joy.

God I loved that woman so much, that fucking complicated, half-insane woman. It would have been so much easier if I didn't. So many people hate their spouses, though they may not realize it. Their every peculiarity becoming oppressive. For them an affair is almost a Godsend, an escape, an excuse for the collapse of intimacy.

My ham-fisted effort to give her what she craved had broken the ice. It had let her know I was willing to struggle. And yet, it had been a laughable disaster. Well, not a disaster. That's too strong. Maybe a fiasco? It hadn't scratched her itch. It hadn't come close.

It was another couple of days before I broached the topic of Rachel's fantasies and her past again. It was a weeknight, so we were in bed early. She was reading one of those appalling James Patterson books, mass produced in some Bangalore sweatshop. I turned toward her.

"I want to know more about how you were before we met... and before you can say it, yes, it is important to me."

She suppressed a sigh and sat up, "So what do you want to know?"

"So, when you were with these inappropriate men. Your word, not mine, by the way --"

"Oh, they were definitely inappropriate," she insisted.

I put that aside for the moment. That seemed like an issue to raise with Michelle.

“Okay, okay, but how did these things come about? Were you always having these fantasies, and then what, at some point it would build up and you’d find yourself in a dive bar?”

“Um, well, actually, sort of. But not quite. I mean I’ve always been, pretty much, a serial monogamist.”

Pretty much. That was a loaded little qualifier. I’d save that for later as well.

She continued, “It was like a see-saw or something. You know, I’d be little Miss Normal, doing the usual college thing. I’d be hanging out with kids from my dorm, or class, or orchestra, or whatever. And then, you know, I’d be closer to a guy, and we’d sort of pair off. No one at Brandeis really dated. It was much more fluid. Increasing closeness, intimacy, then, you know, boredom, whatever.

“I had a couple of boyfriends, I guess. Just close enough to bother mentioning to the ‘rents, invite them home for Thanksgiving, make summer plans. Jason, sophomore year. Brian, for the first half of senior year. He and I had been in Brussels together for a summer program, but we only started dating when we got back.”

“What happened to them?” I asked.

“Oh, I think Jason went to law school. Pretty sure Brian was going to be a dentist.”

“No, Rach, I mean between you and them?”

“Oh, right. With Jas, we were just too young. And we both knew it, so I don’t know, we just pulled back. Brian, though, I ran into him in a bar sucking face with a bleached-blond tramp.”

“What did you do?”

She smirked at me. “What do you think? I found myself the first tattooed-up biker and threw myself at him.”

“Really?”

She shrugged. “No, first I threw a drink at Brian. Then I cried. Then I got drunk. Then I passed out. Then, after my hangover faded, my next boyfriend,” she made air-quotes for my benefit, “was, yeah, inappropriate.

“But that was always the pattern, nice guy, bad guy. I never really cheated,” she hesitated, “not until Jack.”

Ouch! Knowing I was the first man she’d actually cheated on was rough.

She read my reaction. “Oh, Jeez, Max, no that didn’t come out right. With the others, the relationships were more fluid. No clear beginning and end point. No real expectation of exclusivity. Believe me, there was ugliness, but just the usual, kids-will-be-kids drama.”

“Do you think some of those relationships faded because you were thinking of other men?”

“No...” she paused. “I dunno. Max, this is hard. I like to think of myself as a nice person.”

“You are a nice person. You just happen to be a nice person who gets turned on by rough trade.”

She laughed. “God, I am *never* going to live that phrase down, am I?”

“Probably not,” I acknowledged. “But you’re deflecting.”

She didn’t respond.

“Come on Rach, this is about the past. But I want to understand.”

She continued to hesitate, so I pushed harder.

“Rachel, how many of those relationships faded out because instead of thinking of the man next to you in bed, you were thinking about some brutish stranger?”

She took a deep breath. “What do you want me to say, Max? That while I was having sex with my nice, appropriate boyfriends, I was secretly fantasizing about being taken by a muscular thug?”

“If that’s the truth.”

She sighed. “Okay, yes, sometimes. After the initial bloom of new love,” she rolled her eyes, “wore off, then yes, sometimes. And yeah, I am sure it affected the relationships. There are so many ways to sabotage things. You don’t even realize it until later.”

“Yeah?”

“I was seeing this guy, David, I think. Yeah, David. David Brill. He... well, it was never really great. You know, he’s one of those self-described nice guys, but not really nice. More than a little a passive-aggressive, I guess. Needy. But whatever... he was sweet in his own way. We sort of ended up in bed together almost by accident. We were at a house party with some friends, and they were all sort of pairing off, and I dunno, it just happened.

“I’d have been just as happy to let it go at that. But he guilted me into more. You know, ‘Oh Rachel, you’re so special. I’ve always had a crush on you. You’re not like the other girls.’ He threw me up on a pedestal. But it was sort of oppressive in a way.”

“I’m guessing the sex wasn’t so hot?”

She laughed. “No, it was pretty good. He was very attentive. Very. He was constantly going down on me. And I’m pretty sure my tits were pruned up by all the attention he paid them.”

I felt myself blushing, and looked up to see Rachel watching me with an amused grin.

“Was that the reaction you were looking for?” I asked.

“This is your line of questioning,” she replied, but still with that grin.

We were locked in a bizarre contest of wills. I couldn't quite explain it. I wanted her to unlock her past. She seemed determined to control the pace of her disclosures. I wasn't sure what my motivation was, but I knew that the more she dragged it out, the more she deflected, the more she sought to embarrass me into backing down, the more I wanted, needed to know.

"So while nice guy David Brill was eating you out, you were thinking of, what, some guy in combat boots bending you over a dirty sink in some trashy bar, plowing you from behind?"

"Sometimes," she admitted.

"And what did you do about it?"

She snorted. "I accused him of cheating on me. I said I knew he was fooling around with another one of our friends, Ellen. He denied it. I made myself insufferable. He finally snapped, called me paranoid. We had a fight. I walked out."

"Then what?"

She laughed. "He hooked up with Ellen. They got married. It was the best thing I could have done for him."

"And you?"

She smirked.

"I dragged a girlfriend to the Cellars. Told her there was a cool band I wanted to hear."

"Was there?"

She laughed. "No. Anyway, the acoustics were awful. Just white noise, well, more like a jet engine noise. But no one went to the Cellars for witty repartee. The entire atmosphere was predatory. The girls checking each other out, squinty-eyed, 'who's the competition?' the guys looking for weakness, 'which one of these whores is gonna give it up with the least work?'

“I was definitely an easy mark. I was wearing a tank top over a lace bra. I’ve never had the boobs to flash cleavage, so that was the next best thing. I was wearing skinny, low-rider jeans. Before we walked in, I pulled up my thong so it was on display.”

“You must have been fighting them off with a stick.”

She laughed. “I wasn’t fighting them off at all. I spotted this guy, by the bar, real tall. Six-three, six-four, square-faced, shadowed with stubble, he was wearing a Metallica concert tee shirt. Just what I was looking for. I made sure he’d seen me, and then looked away, slowly made my way through the crowd toward the bar.

“By the time I got there he was waiting for me with six shots of tequila lined up. He handed me one and we clinked glasses. Salt, shot, lime. Then a second. Then a third.”

“Real subtle.”

She shrugged. “I wasn’t looking for subtle.”

“So did he bang you in the bar?”

“No. After the third shot, he took my hand and led me outside. We got on his motorcycle. It was chilly. I wrapped my arms around him. He didn’t live far. And well, you can guess what happened next.”

“You cuddled by the fire and he read you poetry?”

“Sure. If by cuddled by the fire, you mean he threw me on his messy futon on the floor. And by reading poetry, you mean he hammered me like a rusty nail.”

“Does one hammer a rusty nail differently than one hammers a pristine nail?”

“You have to hit them harder.”

I couldn’t help but laugh. “I asked for that, didn’t I?”

“That you did.”

“Okay, so then what happened between you and our motorcycle-riding carpenter? What was his name, by the way?”

“I, um, never found out. We practiced several different techniques of nail hammering. Then he passed out, or pretended to, and I took a cab of shame home around sunrise.”

“And that was it? Were they all one-night stands?”

“No, not all of them. But they were all pretty quick. I mean, the point wasn’t a relationship. It was, I dunno, refreshing the thrill.”

She suddenly blushed a deeper red than before. She was thinking of something. Something even more embarrassing than she’d admitted so far.

“What?”

“Nothing,” she lied.

“You still fantasize about him, about them, don’t you?” I guessed.

She leaned her head to the side, half-nodding, half-shaking her head.

“No. I mean, well, yes, you know sometimes. It’s not a regular thing. But it isn’t that. It’s... oh god, this is so creepy.”

“Come on Rach, out with it.”

She sighed. “Jeez, it makes me feel like such a serial killer. But I’d take a, um, trophy. Just a little thing. A bandana, a tee shirt, a shot glass, something. And then I’d, well, you know, keep it with me, fondle it, play with myself and relive it. It was so fucking embarrassing. And then I’d meet a nice guy, and I’d promise myself I was through with the assholes, and I’d throw away the trinket. But then, you know, I’d get bored and start having those fantasies again. And before I’d know it I’d be sabotaging the relationship, looking for an excuse to act out.”

I nodded, but didn’t speak. It was creepy. She was right. But then I remembered Tina. I was between jobs, and had taken a trip down to the Bahamas. It wasn’t Spring Break or anything, but it is always a party. I met

this girl in a bar, well, a woman, whatever. Early twenties, maybe older. I was shit-faced already. We drank margaritas, walked on the beach. She blew me sitting up against a palm tree.

We went back to my room and had a couple of hours of very passable, essentially anonymous sex. When we were done, she went to the bathroom. There was no real question of her staying over. It's not what either of us wanted. While she was gone, I stole her thong and hid it. She looked for it for a while. Badgered me a little. She knew I had it, I guess. But anyway, after a while she left.

So I understood Rachel's impulse. The excitement of sex with a stranger. The desire to keep a trophy. Thing is, for me that was something that had just happened, a momentary impulse. I don't even think I took her underwear home after the trip. I certainly never jerked off with it later.

Rachel's revelations had me reexamining all of my own experiences. Tina wasn't my only one-night stand. There was this fellow intern at one of my summer jobs. After a company happy hour, we hooked up, and then immediately agreed not to admit it to anyone. She didn't want the reputation and I didn't want the commitment.

I realized the big difference between Rachel and me. We'd both had some tawdry little flings. The difference was, for me they just happened, were almost immediately regretted. For Rachel they were sought after, plotted, cherished for a period of time until the excitement faded and the embarrassment became overwhelming.

Then she'd force herself into a "normal" relationship. But that was never enough. Sooner or later, she'd get that itch for the inappropriate... That was the word she used most often. But that wasn't quite right.

They were humiliating. Tony on the pool deck, jamming his hand into her bikini bottom and then using her for his own pleasure. The man in the bar, approaching with three shots and an attitude that said, “Here slut, drink so we can get to fucking.” Jack, treating her like an incompetent child, valuing her only as a sexual plaything.

That feeling of being used, of being reduced to nothing more than a sex toy, for some reason she found it intoxicating. And like an alcoholic, she’d come to regret her binge, will herself onto the wagon. Until...

This last time, with me, she’d lasted ten years. A commendable dry streak for anyone. And yet, I didn’t think I could exist that way. It would be living perpetually beneath a Sword of Damocles, knowing that at any moment I could be blindsided by the discovery that she had again succumbed to her obsession.

Worse, though, in some ways was the idea that she wouldn’t. That instead, she’d just dream of the idea, reflecting daily on my inability to give her that charge. It was a terrible dilemma. I could live either with the fear that she would one day cheat on me or the nagging suspicion that she forced herself to tolerate me.

The way out was, again, obvious. I needed to become the man who could both be her loving husband, a partner in raising children and building a home, and a sexual partner who met her deep, dark desires to be dominated.

Squaring that circle was no easy task, as my previous effort at it suggested. It had worked out okay. She’d apparently appreciated the effort, if not the execution. And we’d recovered some lost intimacy in the process. But I was not fooled into thinking that an effort that ended in giggles was likely to meet her needs for long.

CHAPTER NINE

It occurred to me that the big problem I'd have with meeting that goal was simple familiarity. Having me bark out a command to suck my cock struck her as ridiculous. As it should. It was so out of character as to be instantly absurd.

So the key was to shift expectations, to establish a new context, a new set of rules. I dimly remembered that movie from my youth, thought of the woman being led into a dungeon of sorts, sending a signal that things were about to change. I considered ways to do that, and inevitably ended up exploring the whole BDSM culture on the Internet.

It's funny. I was familiar with each of the words that composed the acronym: bondage, domination, sadism, and masochism. But the words themselves don't really describe the scene any more than the word cuckold, which just refers to a wronged husband by itself, can prepare one for the ritualization associated with that scene.

I have to admit, I didn't completely get it. There were specialized clothes, equipment, instruments. But this wasn't really my fantasy. It was Rachel's, and while I was struggling to understand it, there was this whole community living it that I could try to tap into. And in a strange way, what I found the most appealing was specifically the artificiality. I thought that was the key, putting Rachel in the mindset not of being my friend, my wife, the mother of my children, but rather being my sex toy.

I've never really had domination fantasies. But watching those videos definitely sparked my interest. Those women, so meekly obeying their masters, dog collared, often bound, sucking cock while getting their tits lashed with a cat o' nine tails. It was surreal, and yet, exciting.

There was one video that I couldn't get out of my mind. She was a young woman, a spitting image of Britney Spears at the peak of her fame. She was barely dressed, just a short, pink skirt and a matching belly shirt.

The video began with her already bound and a facing door, her hands above her head. She turned to look at the camera. She had a red ball gag in her mouth, secured by a leather strap. There was something insanely erotic about that image, her pink lips stretched around that bright red orb, the straps digging into her cheek, pinning her hair to her neck.

The camera lingered on her body, then panned down to show her toned legs held apart by a steel bar attached to her ankles. As the image moved back up, it gave a little peek under her skirt, exposing a perfect little ass, giving a quick glimpse of her bare, shaved pussy.

The video again focused on her face. Porn stars are not usually known for their acting chops, but this one managed to convey a credible mix of wide-eyed innocence and looming apprehension. Or maybe it was real. She was a small, skinny little thing, probably not much older than twenty, bound, in a room with, probably, several men on the production crew. Did she have any idea what was going to happen to her? Surely, but gagged and bound, she wouldn't have much opportunity to protest if things went too far.

The camera panned to a man entering the scene. He was a good-looking guy. Tall and well-built, with three days of stubble and bulging muscles. He wore faded jeans and nothing else, a heavy wallet chain dangling from his pocket. He grinned at his captive as he approached her.

He spanked her left cheek, hard enough that her firm ass jiggled and immediately reddened. She let out a muffled whine. He spanked her right cheek, then alternated back and forth until her entire bottom was scarlet. He stepped away and the camera again focused on her face. Her mascara had begun to run, strands of hair were plastered to her forehead with sweat, and

spit ran down from both sides of her mouth with the streams meeting at her chin. Her eyes widened again.

The camera swung back to the man. He was now holding a black riding crop. He approached the girl again and ran the flattened tip of the whip over her body, up and down her legs, between her ass cheeks, against her pussy. He yanked up her belly shirt to expose her cute little tits, and circled her nipples with the hard leather. He used to crop the caress her face, almost tenderly.

Then suddenly he stepped back and snapped his wrist, bringing the switch down against the sensitive skin of her inner thigh. She whined through her gag and pulled at the restraints. He whipped her again, this time across her ass. And again, this time across the belly.

The video returned to her reddened face. Her eyes had a wild look. She was slobbering around the gag. Then suddenly her pupils seemed to roll back into her head.

The camera zoomed out. He was fingering her roughly, two fingers jamming into her shaved pussy. With his other hand he yanked off his pants and stroked his big cock. He withdrew and grabbed her by the throat. With a hard thrust he entered her completely, immediately fucking her hard enough to lift her off her feet.

It seemed like the sort of thing Rachel might like. And it was definitely something that got me going. I decided to try to reenact the scene with my wife.

Though I had a script, I didn't have the necessary toys. There is a shop near our house, Night Dreams, sandwiched between a bar and grill and a cell phone store in a local strip mall. I've walked past the place a million

times, always glancing, with forced casualness, at the trappy lingerie and costumes in the display window.

It's weird, but I've always been too shy or embarrassed to go inside, even though I've always been curious.

Rachel had taken the kids overnight to visit a college friend who'd moved out West. It was a perfect time to go shopping, and would also give me an opportunity to bring my purchases into the house without anyone seeing. So it was a Saturday evening when I finally got a chance to go inside. I grabbed a burger next door, fortified my courage with a few beers, and then headed in.

The display window was pretty lewd, but nothing compared with what was inside. I hate to sound naive, but until you've seen an entire wall covered with dozens of dildos of various shapes, sizes, and colors, it is hard to imagine it.

I spent almost twenty minutes just getting my bearings. Well, that and gawking at all the toys, imagining using them on Rachel.

It wasn't all fun. At one point I passed a young couple. I studiously avoid eye contact. But even still, as I walked away I heard him clearly.

"Is there anything sadder than a old dude alone in a sex shop on a Saturday night?"

I looked back over my shoulder involuntarily and immediately regretted it. The girl had looked toward me as well, and our eyes met. She was a pretty little thing, barely five foot, with big, heavily made-up eyes. She was both embarrassed at her boyfriend's comment, but also in agreement with his sentiment. Or at least that is how I interpreted her expression.

I took a step toward the door to flee. Then I took a deep breath. Fuck 'em. I was on a mission.

Funny thing about sex shops, they don't have shopping carts. Or even shopping baskets. At least this one didn't. So as I found my supplies, I cradled them awkwardly in my arms.

Door straps. A spreader bar. Choosing a ball gag was particularly difficult. What is the right size? And what is the best consistency? Solid? Gel? I bought three of different types. I needed a whip. Should I get a stropper? A riding crop? A cat o' nine tails? I bought all three of those as well.

I headed toward the cashier, but stopped. What was Rachel supposed to wear? I thought of the girl in the video, her short, pink, frilly skirt and matching top. God, Rachel would be sexy in that. I reversed course, walked toward the clothing and costume section.

Nothing was exactly right. I wanted something more than lingerie, something less than a full costume. I wanted to put Rachel in the mood of submission, not Halloween. Still, it was fun to imagine her as a slutty nurse, a slutty schoolgirl, a slutty whatever.

I paused at a slutty secretary outfit. A short black skirt, a sheer white blouse. It was almost what she really wore. Too close really. When I imagined her in it, I immediately pictured her with Jack, bent over his desk, exposed, vulnerable, looking back over her shoulder as he stroked his fat cock.

I shivered and almost dropped my armful of sex toys. A wave of doubt came over me. What the fuck was I doing? This was crazy. I should be trying to tamp down Rachel's dangerous fantasy, not stoking it. But it wasn't just her fantasy anymore. It had infected me as well. It wasn't just that I wanted to meet her needs so that she wouldn't be tempted to cheat; I also wanted to participate.

I scanned the wall. My eyes alighted on a leather skirt and bustier, both inlaid with metal studs. They were absurd, trashy, and very sexy. I added

them to the pile.

I brought home my purchases, hid them behind a bunch of a files in my home office. I was in a weird mood. Excited and angry at the same time.

Again I wondered if I wasn't mistaken to be picking at scabs. Is that what this was? Was my growing desire to be the kind of man that Rachel had so often sought out to save her from the boredom of conventionality, was that desire really about saving our marriage? Or was I in a weird way trying to keep alive the pain her affair had caused? Or was all of that just rationalization? Rationalization of what? My own desires? Or my desire to punish Rachel?

Affairs suck. And it is not because another man has put his dick, or his fingers, or whatever, in your wife. Jesus, that is so fucking trivial in the big picture. In my case, it wasn't either the fear that she loved another man more than me. She didn't, and it never occurred to me she would leave me for Jack.

No, the real problem is that it complicates everything. Rachel and I had been together for a decade. And suddenly, I couldn't trust any of it. I thought I knew her, but I didn't, obviously. Every moment we'd shared, every conversation we'd had, both before and since, now seemed somehow counterfeit. I didn't feel like I could trust any of it. Hidden motives beneath the surface. Alternate meanings.

It wasn't so much that I felt she was misleading me. Rather it was that everything I'd known and believed was now uncertain. That's the problem with an affair. It isn't about dicks and vaginas. It is about no longer being able to trust that things are indeed as they seem.

CHAPTER TEN

It took me longer than I expected to engineer a night alone at home with Rachel. The last thing I wanted was the kids to wake from a nightmare and barge into our room with Rachel dressed in leather, bound to the door, getting whipped by Daddy. Is there even enough therapy available to deal with the consequences of that? I mean for Rachel and me, never mind the impact for the kids.

I finally managed to get the kids packed off to my folks for the weekend. I had the whole day planned out. Lots of couple's time during the day. Rachel and I would go for a jog. Then we'd go to the nursery to buy flowers. An afternoon working together in the yard. I had a nice dinner planned, light enough for sex, involved enough for foreplay.

As we sat together, with the windows wide open and a lovely breeze playing over the dinner table, we ate our meal of mussels, French bread, salad, and a delicious bottle of Sancerre. I'd made a "mixed tape" of songs I knew she liked.

Rachel was glowing. I thought I could read her expression, a sense of relief that we were over the hump, that things between us were going back to normal. It gave me pause. Would it be better for me to just forget about Jack and the rest? To just accept her transgression as an aberration? To forgive, which I believed I had already done, and forget, a much harder task?

I shook my head. No. That was the road to disaster. Denying her needs was just a form of cowardice. Or was it? I was suddenly taken with a deep annoyance at Michelle. She was so fucking good at getting disclosures, so

bad at telling us what to do about it. The last two sessions had been barren, just plowing over the same ground.

“Are you okay?” Rachel asked, concerned.

I forced myself back into the present. “Yes. Sorry, was just thinking about work.”

It was a clumsy lie. Why was being honest with her still so difficult?

She nodded, unconvinced. She was walking on eggshells and had been for weeks. I recognized it, hated it, and yet in a way relished in it. I detested myself for it, but it was weirdly empowering. As long as she felt guilty, I had an odd power over her. Yet another weird, pathological, consequence of an affair.

“I love you, baby,” I reassured her. “Today was fun. No kids. Just us.”

She looked a little shocked, which was in a weird way, hurtful. She had tears in her eyes.

“I like it being just us,” she replied. Then she corrected herself, “And the kids.”

I laughed. They were not the issue. “I know what you mean.”

There was a pause in the conversation. I stepped into it.

“Would you be up for something new tonight?”

“Um, sure?” she replied ambivalently.

“It’ll be fun,” I reassured her.

“Okay,” she replied.

Then after another moment, she continued. “So, what is it?”

I gave her a smile. “You’ll see. Have another glass of wine.”

I’d opened a second bottle of wine and gave her a generous pour.

“I need to be drunk for this?”

I laughed. “Well, it can’t hurt.”

I thought of the man in the bar, buying her three shots. Here baby, get hammered so I can take advantage of you.

We were both pleasantly buzzed as we did the dishes. I let her start the dishwasher while I went upstairs to get her outfit. I was waiting for her in the living room.

When she walked in, I held up the skirt and bustier.

She raised an eyebrow. “You don’t think I’m going out in that, do you?”

“No, it is just for us.”

Was that the wrong answer? *Fuck you bitch. You’ll wear what I tell you and go where I tell you.*

She gave me an amused smirk. “Okay.”

She wasn’t supposed to be amused. She was supposed to be cowed by my demands and overcome with lust at being told how to dress.

Rachel took the clothes from my hands and went upstairs. She returned a few minutes later.

Fuck, she looked hot. The skirt was tight around her ass and only covered her to mid-thigh. The top fit perfectly, giving her the rare impression of cleavage and showing off her flat belly to perfection.

She’d said she wouldn’t go out in this outfit. I could see why. Dressed like that she’d be “asking for it.” I shuddered. Was that what she wanted? Deep inside? As she zipped up the skirt, felt the leather encase her ass, did she imagine what it would be like to be out in public dressed like that?

She reached down and gripped the hem of her skirt. She lifted it up and gave me a quick flash of her naked, closely trimmed pussy.

“It’s so short, I didn’t think you’d want me to wear anything underneath.”

I nodded, dry mouthed. She gave me a lewd grin. Fuck, she wasn’t supposed to be teasing me. I was the one who was supposed to be in control. But I didn’t feel in control. Right now, dressed as she was, exuding sexuality, I was completely in her power. Had she asked me to crawl over to her and lick her pussy, I probably would have.

I took a quick breath and stood.

“Come with me,” I said tersely.

I walked past her, not making eye contact. Should I have taken her by the hand and dragged her with me? Grabbed her hair?

I didn’t dare look back at her. I knew she’d be close to giggles. If I looked at her, she’d begin to laugh, completely breaking the mood.

I entered the bedroom. She was just a step behind me. I’d rehearsed this in my mind, but it just didn’t feel the same as it had in my imagination. I wasn’t dominating her. It frustrated me. Why was she so eager to hand over control to others, but so resistant with me? I could feel my frustration building. I decided to use it.

I slammed the door behind her. She startled and looked at me in surprise.

“Did that get your attention?” I hissed.

She nodded. Was that a small glimmer of fear in her eyes? Good.

I took her by the shoulders and spun her around. I pressed her firmly against the closed door.

“Hey!” she protested.

“Quiet!”

“Okay.” She sounded amused again.

I reached for the restraints that I'd stashed in the top drawer of the dresser by the door. I could feel her looking at me. I worked without comment, attaching the straps to the top of the door, the cuffs dangling above her head.

I took her hand. This was the big moment. Would she resist? She didn't. She let me place her wrist in the cuff. I tightened it. Then I moved to the other wrist. When both her wrists were firmly strapped, I tightened the straps, pulling her arms above her head.

"Kinky" she said, a smile in her voice.

I shushed her.

I stepped back a little to take a look at her like that. Damn, that was a sexy look. I reached under her skirt. She let out a startled squeak as I palmed her ass. I gave her a light spank.

"Hey!" she gasped.

"Hey yourself," I replied.

I cupped her ass again. It was tempting to just fondle her like that, explore her body, feel her hard buns, her flat belly. She squirmed at my touch, giggled a little.

"Stop it, this is so silly."

I reached for the gag. When she saw it she yanked at the restraints.

"No, Max. That's too much."

I hesitated. Should I take no for an answer? That girl in the video. She hadn't protested. Not even when the man had pressed a butt plug into her ass.

"Okay, but no more complaints," I replied.

She hesitated and then nodded.

I slid my hand between her legs, but she spun away from me. She wasn't complaining, but nor was she being compliant. Time for more

restraints. I grabbed the spreader bar.

“What’s that?” she asked.

“Shhhh.”

She rolled her eyes. She was supposed to be wet with passion, overcome with excitement at being dominated. Instead, she was humoring me.

I hesitated. I was tempted to untie her, end the charade. But damn, she did look sexy that way.

I knelt down and attached the first ankle cuff. I glanced up, under her skirt, catching a glimpse of her naked snatch. Despite my mixed emotions about how it was going, I could feel myself getting hard. I adjusted my cock to be more comfortable.

I spread her legs apart. I could sense her about to protest, but she didn’t. One of the consequences of the spreader bar that I hadn’t foreseen was that Rachel was now unsteady. She almost toppled over, but I stood her back up and leaned her against the door.

I reached for the riding crop. I wasn’t really planning to whip her. I just couldn’t see doing that. But I liked the idea of teasing her with it. Jammed up against the door, she couldn’t see what I was up too until I pressed the rigid leather against her inner thigh.

“What is that?” she demanded.

I didn’t get a chance to respond. She caught a glimpse of the riding crop.

“No, Max!”

She yanked on the restraints. With a loud crack the strike plate tore free of the door jamb. The door itself, with Rachel attached, swung open. With her legs bound, she couldn’t steady herself. Rachel fell backward, her weight on the door increased the torque and tore the top of the door from its

hinges. Weakened now on both sides, the door sheared apart. I tried to catch her and fell backward hard.

She landed on top of me, both of us covered in door fragments, paint and dust. I lay there stunned. There was a throbbing pain in the back of my head where I'd hit the floor.

"Are you okay?" I asked.

I had cushioned her fall, but she'd absorbed most of the impact of the door itself.

"You were right. I did need to be drunk for this."

I removed the restrains and she went off to shower as I cleaned up as best as I could. I was sitting on the bed when she returned, the trashed doorway a silent, yet screaming, reminder of my plans gone wrong.

But even before the door had betrayed me, things were already not going as I had planned. Rachel had humored me, but I don't think there was even a moment that I had tapped into her desires. And I hadn't adjusted my game plan to that. Instead, driven on by my own fantasy, I had plowed ahead heedlessly.

I was discovering something about my own fetishes, but I was no closer to solving the puzzle she posed.

I must have looked forlorn because when she returned wearing a bathrobe, her hair wrapped in towel, the first thing she asked was, "Are you okay?"

I forced a smile. "Sorry this turned into a disaster."

She laughed. "It'll give us an excuse to repaint... once we get someone to replace the door."

She paused and then persisted, "You didn't answer my question."

“Yeah, I’m okay. You?”

She shrugged. “It was your scene that, um, got ruined.”

“See, that’s the thing. It was supposed to be your fantasy.”

She tilted her head. “I... what?”

“I’m trying to be the kind of man who can, you know...”

I trailed off. It sounded weird to say it.

“I don’t want you to feel like you need to go elsewhere...”

Her face sank. She had thought we were past this.

“Okay, I understand. I guess all I can do is say again that I’m sorry, that --”

“No. Jeez, no,” I cut her off. “Rachel, no, I’m not fishing for more apologies. I’m being honest when I say I want to be... to be everything to you.”

“You are.”

I didn’t challenge the lie. “Let’s go to bed.”

We cuddled and then fell asleep. Neither one of us seemed much in the mood for sex.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

I should have just forgotten about it. But the truth was, I was becoming as obsessed by the fantasy as I thought Rachel was. It wasn't something I could just let go.

I'd been spending time on various BDSM forums online. So far, I'd just been a lurker. But now I decided to ask for some advice. My post was brief and to the point.

—I think my wife would enjoy being dommed, but I don't really know how to get started in this. Would appreciate any advice. PM me with suggestions.

It was chum in the water. The responses came fast and furious and kept coming. Most of them were straightforwardly horny and completely useless.

—Send me pics.

—I'll Dominate her.

Many of those came accompanied by penis pics. Here I was trying to spice up my sex life with my wife, and instead I now had a mailbox full of cocks.

Proper capitalization and terminology are very important in the community. I'd offended several by failing to capitalize "dommed" in my message, and almost every response was very careful to distinguish between Master and slave, Dom and sub. For some of these folks, it almost seemed like an exercise in typography.

But there were other responses. A lot of folks in the BDSM community seem desperate to let someone know what they are up to. So in addition to the unsolicited WIE, wieners-in-email, I also received several long, long stories of a couple's journey into BDSM. Most of those started off with the phrase, "So after our kids went off to college," or "after thirty-five years of marriage," which is fine. It is great to know that older people have active sex lives, wild even, but as a practical matter they were discussing a whole different kind of situation than the one I was in.

Then there were a whole slew of emails that, for lack of a better word, were just creepy. Signed by people who called themselves The Master or Lord Spankbottom or Emperor Pumpatine (I admit, I got a kick out of that one), they were full of rules and regulations. The good Emperor insisted I had to have Rachel sign a "slave contract", which began:

§1 ¶1: The Slave's Role

The slave agrees to submit completely to the Master in all ways. There are no boundaries of place, time, or situation in which the slave may willfully refuse to obey the directive of the Master without risking punishment... The slave also agrees that, once entered into the Slavery Contract, their body belongs to their Master in that they now exist solely for the pleasure of said Master.

It continued in that vein for an additional ten sections of dense legalese defining the who, what, when, and where of being dominated. It was like the product of some demented law school study group session.

Another correspondent sent me "submissive's creed," that read like a list of daily affirmations and included:

I will accept the responsibility of discovering what pleases my Top, and will do my best to fulfill his wishes and desires.

and

Above all, I will wear my title of submissive with honor. I will never cause others to think that being submissive means to be weak or sub-human. I will take pride in who and what I am and will never show myself in a negative way.

I was about to give up and delete that account, if for no other reason than that I wasn't crazy about the ever accumulating number of schlongs in my inbox, when I received a message from Tommy. Not Baron Tommy or Duke Tommy of Torment, but just Tommy.

—Hey man, I don't know if you're for real or if you're just getting your kicks from trolling the list, but I get what you're going through. If you want to talk, let me know.

It was brief and while I didn't really like the implication that my honest query might have been an exercise in trolling, this was the first authentic response I'd gotten. Actually, authentic is the wrong word. Most of my other respondents were probably authentic in their own way, but they were just in a very different place from where I was.

I wrote him back and assured him I was for real. I gave him a cursory run-down of the situation, though I didn't mention Rachel's affair, or her name for that matter. I told I'd just found out that my wife had a kinky side, that she didn't seem comfortable revealing it to me, and that I didn't know how to bring it out. He replied immediately.

—Why do you want to? Is this for you, or for her?

I thought about it and answered.

—I've been asking myself that question as well. It's mostly for her, because I want her to be able to enjoy all aspects of her sexuality.

But it is also for me because I don't want her to feel tempted to go elsewhere for it if I can't meet her needs. And, I like the idea of dominating her. It seems like a sexy experience.

He didn't correct my capitalization. Instead, he honed on the sentence I'd buried in the middle of the response.

—Go elsewhere?

I sighed. We'd exchanged five emails in an hour, but now I had to take a step back and think. How much did I want to tell him? He was just an email address. I knew that. And yet, there was something difficult about getting into the details of Rachel's affair, even if it wasn't a fully consummated affair. Just admitting it, talking about it, was difficult and emasculating. I decided not to write back.

If he'd pushed me I'd have cut off all communications. But he didn't. He gave me time, and it was Rachel who ended up provoking me into renewing a few days later, though she didn't know it at the time.

CHAPTER TWELVE

It is funny how some things seem to happen in slow motion and yet you are unable to react in time. I was sitting at the conference table, reviewing some financial projections before the start of our weekly status meeting when I noticed Barry walking toward me. He was holding a cup of coffee in one hand, had a stack of papers wedged under his arm, and was trying to carry on a conversation with a pretty young intern at the same time. His foot caught the edge of the table. I actually saw the coffee arcing toward me, individual drops of mocha separating from the main flow and spotting my suit jacket before the rest of the cup spilled all over me. At least it wasn't scalding hot.

"Aw, fuck," he grunted.

The intern stared at me wide-eyed.

"You owe me a new suit," I said, coffee dripping from my forehead.

I sat through the meeting in my soaked clothes, but since I had an important lunch meeting, I headed home afterwards to change. I drove home absentmindedly, thinking about various work projects.

When I pulled into the driveway, I noticed the plumber's van parked out front. Right, the garbage disposal. Rachel had mentioned she was getting it replaced.

I walked into the house quietly. I wanted to see the look of surprise on Rachel's face when she saw me. It would be good for a laugh. I heard voices from the kitchen, so I started in that direction. I was just short of the doorway when I saw them. I paused. There was something about the scene that made me freeze.

He was a big guy, tall, and very powerfully built. His company tee shirt was at least one size too small. It stretched across his thick chest, distorting the lettering and biting into his oversized biceps. The guy was ripped. And tattooed. Swirls of colorful ink up and down his arms, rising out the back of his shirt and up his neck. I sensed immediately he was the sort of man Rachel would have sought out in the old days for an inappropriate encounter.

They were standing close, talking softly. He was showing her something, some plumbing part. She was staring at it attentively, but his eyes roamed over her body. She was wearing jeans and a thin, white cotton tee, her hard nipples poking through the fabric. She brushed the hair out of her eyes, shifted her weight from one foot to the other.

He asked her a question. She turned to point at the sink. His eyes went immediately to her ass, her hard, perfect, heart-shaped ass. His hand twitched as if he was fighting back the urge to cop a feel.

She turned back around. She should have seen me out of the corner of her eye, but she didn't. She was too focused on him, he on her. Tunnel vision. Her eyes were wide, a little glassy.

It would only take an instant for something to happen, I knew. He would take a step forward and caress her nipples with the back of his hand. She'd retreat, shocked. He'd advance on her, backing her into a corner. She'd try to escape, but he'd grab her wrists, hold them together above her head in one hand, while his other hand pawed at her breasts.

"No, stop it! Get off me!" she'd hiss.

He'd chuckle and tear off her tee shirt. He'd lean in and kiss her hard, his hand pinching her nipples in turn.

"Don't! I'm married."

He'd give her a smirk, an implicit question now hanging in the air. *And what if you weren't?*

His hand would slide down over her belly and into the front of her jeans. He'd kiss her again. To the casual observer it would look like he was forcing himself on her. A careful observer, though, would notice her hips thrusting against his invading hand.

"We shouldn't be doing this."

We. Her changing tone wouldn't be lost on him.

He'd drag her to the floor and wrench off her jeans.

"No, don't," she'd repeat, now as a sigh.

He'd tear off her panties. Still pinning her arms above her head, he'd climb between her legs and fumble with his own zipper.

"Please, no...." Then, "AHHH," she'd cry out as he thrust in hard.

"Fuck, you're wet."

He'd fuck her right there, on the cold kitchen floor, hard and fast. It would be quick. Over in a just a couple of minutes. Both of them left panting and gasping and wanting more.

And then he'd stand and lift her to her feet. Half-dragging, half-leading her, he'd take her upstairs to our bedroom for rounds two, three, and four. And then at the end of the day, when he'd enjoyed her every way a man can a woman, he'd prepare to leave. He'd look back at her, lying exhausted on the bed.

"I'll be back tomorrow to finish. But I think this is a two-man job."

I shook my head, clearing my mind. It was a vision so powerful that its underlying truth seemed undeniable. He *could* have her if he wanted her. Just like that. And looking at her, standing too close to him, her nipples hard, slightly flush, I knew she was thinking the same thing and that she was torn between wanting it to happen and fearing that it would.

I was tempted to sit back and just watch if for no other reason than to confirm my intuition, but also because if that was the woman my wife had become, or perhaps become again, then intervening was pointless. It was just a matter of time before she was in the right place at the right time -- or is that wrong place at the wrong time? -- for her to cheat on me again.

No, I wasn't going to give up. Not that easily. We'd been together too long, I loved her too much, to just surrender her like that.

I strode loudly into the kitchen.

"Guess what happened at work?" I said.

Startled, Rachel turned toward me, blushing guiltily. He looked at me as well, a malevolent hardness in his gaze for interrupting what he too realized was a sure thing. Their reactions seemed to confirm my own assessment. I pushed that from my mind. Later. I forced a smile.

"Oh good, getting the disposal fixed? That racket it makes was driving me crazy."

I walked toward the fridge planning to grab an apple nonchalantly.

"What happened to you?" Rachel asked.

The plumber moved over to the sink, resigned, I hoped, to fixing the disposal rather than laying pipe.

I explained about Barry, the coffee, and my lunch meeting.

"That'll never come out," she said, inspecting the damage. "And that was my favorite suit of yours."

I shrugged. "We'll send Barry a bill. Come upstairs and help me pick out a new one."

She looked over at the plumber, but he was obviously just getting started.

We walked to the bedroom. Rachel filled me in on the details of her morning. Brent spilt his milk, Allison refused to wear the clothes Rachel

had picked out. There was an accident so she was almost late getting back for the plumber, but then he was late anyway.

I could hear her words, but all I could think about was her and the plumber. The realization that but for Barry's clumsiness Rachel would even now be on her back, naked, with a muscular stranger between her legs, getting fucked hard.... It was dizzying.

She walked in ahead of me, my eyes on her swaying ass. I closed the door behind us. She was peering into my closet. She was bent slightly at the waist, just enough to give her bottom a little extra rounded definition.

I couldn't help myself. I stepped up close, one hand cupping the firm curve of her rear, the other reaching around to palm her breast.

"You look extra hot today."

She squirmed a little. "Stop it, silly. What are you doing?"

I pulled her toward me, her firm ass pressing into my groin against my raging hard-on. It startled us both. I hadn't realized how excited I was; she hadn't realized I was excited at all. I continued to fondle her, grind against her.

"We can't do this. The plumber is downstairs," she insisted.

"Do you want him to join us?"

"No! God. What I meant –"

I laughed. "I know what you meant. Don't worry, he won't hear us."

I knew what she meant, but I didn't know why I'd said it in the first place. It just came out. Was I testing her? Teasing her? Just being an ass?

I slid my hand over her flat belly and unbuttoned her jeans.

"What if he needs to talk to us?"

"Don't worry, I'll be quick."

"You're a real charmer," she giggled back.

I pressed my hand into her panties, slipping my fingertips through her downy muff...

“Don’t,” she sighed. I felt her stiffen anxiously.

... below to her sex. God, she was wet. Soaked.

“My charm seems to be working.”

She sighed and relaxed. I knew it wasn’t my touch or words that had gotten her worked up. But I was willing to let her believe she’d put one over on me.

I ran my finger up and down her slit. She was as excited as I’d ever seen her. When my digit found her swollen clit, she groaned and thrust back against me. I leaned forward and kissed her neck. She moaned louder.

I reached down and pushed her jeans down past her hips. Once the fabric cleared her womanly swells, it fell to the floor, pooling at her ankles. She turned her head to the side and kissed me wetly.

I slipped my other hand under her tee, pinching her nipples. It struck me that she wasn’t wearing a bra. Was it just because she’d forgotten the plumber was coming? Had she gone braless on purpose to tease him? I felt a rush of heat at the thought and groaned in response. I needed her, now.

I took a step backward, pulling her with me. She stepped out of her jeans and we stumbled together toward the bed. I yanked off my suit jacket, and clawed at the buttons on my shirt, popping two of them clean off in my haste to get free of the fabric. We reached the bed and I shoved her onto the mattress, harder than I had intended, but she didn’t seem to mind.

She looked so hot lying there, her nipples threatening to poke right through her shirt, her hair wild with strands crisscrossing her face. My gaze was drawn between her splayed legs. She was wearing a pair of thin, white panties. Simple and innocent underwear in normal circumstances. But she

was so wet that the fabric had become transparent, showing off her swollen, pink snatch.

I pulled my tee shirt off and dropped to my knees by the side of the bed. I grabbed her thighs, yanked her roughly toward me until her ass was right at the edge of the mattress. I slid her soaked panties aside and took her cunt into my mouth, sucking on her puffy lips, tonguing her clit. She reached down and took my head in her hands, holding me tight as she thrust her crotch against my face.

“Oh my God, oh my God, oh my Gawd!” she cried out in passion as I felt her body spasm against me.

I fumbled with my own zipper, just as I’d imagined the plumber doing earlier. I managed to free my prick. I rose up on haunches and launched myself at Rachel. With her panties still just yanked aside, I thrust wildly, but my cock found its target and I sunk into her effortlessly. She gasped and threw her head back. I rammed into her as fast and as hard as I could.

She was moaning loudly. The bed creaked. Her cunt was drenched, furnace hot. Her eyes were closed. I knew she was thinking about him, thinking about that tattooed musclehead taking her, hammering her hard, like a rusty nail. I gasped and it felt like my entire body tensed. And then I came hard, spurting deep inside my wife. I collapsed onto her, both of us breathing hard.

“I told you I’d be quick,” I sighed softly.

Rachel was too mortified to come back downstairs immediately, so I left her to shower, got dressed, and went down to the kitchen. The plumber gave me sneer. I laughed to myself. I wasn’t about to apologize for not

letting him have a free run at my wife. I had a little time before lunch anyway and I wanted to make sure he was done and gone before I left.

The problem was, then what? What would stop him from just coming back later that afternoon or the next day. *Sorry miss, I think I left my wrench here by mistake.* Maybe because I'd interrupted it, she'd resist *his* advances. But was that going to be my life from here on out? Always suspicious, always on edge?

Those minutes in the bedroom had been the hottest sex we'd had since that evening in the kitchen months earlier. But in both cases we were pretending, or at least she was. When she let me bend her over the counter, I was consummating her encounters with Jack. Just now, I'd played the role of the plumber. I didn't actually mind that she was thinking about another man while we did it. It was, in a weird way, sort of hot, if it stopped at that. But I knew it wouldn't.

When she first told me about Jack I was hurt, but willing in my mind to write it off as an aberration. But now, after hearing more about her past, seeing her just now in the kitchen, it seemed clear to me that her ability to resist her fantasies had been seriously frayed. The thing with Jack had, somehow, torn down her defenses, and it was just now a matter of time. Unless I did something about it.

I paid the plumber and he left, looking longingly up the stairs. Maybe I was wrong about Rachel. Maybe I was just projecting my own fears, my own inadequacies, my own resentments onto her, but he'd seen something too. Just like the ex-con by the pool and just like the tall, rough stranger in the bar those many years ago who had lined up three shots as an opening line, the plumber had gotten a quick impression of my wife. The vibe of an easy mark.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

I had trouble staying focused during my lunch meeting. Both the sex and my ambivalence over the circumstances distracted me from the task of trying to convince two new Silicon Valley millionaires to invest their IPO money with my firm.

The meeting had begun as a long shot. These guys were mid-twenties, wearing jeans and tee shirts, and looked on us VCs as sharks. By the time we were halfway through our entrees, I'd given up on making a pitch, and we spent the rest of time debating ski resorts. It was, all in all, a more fun way to spend the hour.

It also allowed me to let my mind wander. I thought back to Rachel's description of her sex life before she met me. I'd been focusing so much on my impression that her desires tended to grow, until the impulse to act became irresistible. But I hadn't much focused on what happened after.

As she explained it, her inappropriate affairs didn't trigger a downward spiral. She wasn't always looking for a new thrill. Once she scratched her itch, her sense of propriety returned. The fever broke and she could go back to normal.

I wondered if I could live with that. The constant dread that she might cheat would be unbearable. But what of the idea of giving her a free pass? A weekend vacation from our marriage, or maybe a week? Either way, an understanding that she was periodically free to sow some wild oats.

I thought about the logistics. It couldn't be anyone we knew. And I wouldn't want her to rub it in my face. But what about a discrete fling, maybe at a resort in the Caribbean or something. Out of sight, time-limited,

but an opportunity to quench her desire for some “rough trade,” as she’d put it.

“You okay, Max?”

I looked over at Jason and nodded.

“We thought we’d lost you there for a minute.”

I forced a smile and tried to reconstruct the last few minutes of conversation from the snippets I’d followed. “What about Jackson Hole? You guys been there?”

“Not yet,” replied Todd.

Despite their Anglo names, they were both of Chinese descent. Wiry and brainy, they’d been nerds all their lives. Now they probably had models throwing themselves in their direction. Amazing how fast someone’s life can change. Their interest in Jackson Hole gave me an idea to salvage the lunch.

“One of my partners has a house out there. I’m sure you could use it. Right on the slopes. Big hot tub overlooking the mountain.”

“Yeah?” Jason said.

I nodded. “No prob. Tell you what, tell me when you want to go. I’ll book the jet to fly you guys out there. Plane seats six, so bring some friends.”

They looked at each other and grinned. I could only imagine what kind of friends they’d invite.

They pulled out their phones and began checking their calendars, sending texts to their friends. I sipped my wine. I seemed to have made progress on that front.

Back in the office, I crunched through the afternoon to finish up some personalized proposals I’d put together for them based on our lunch conversation. I didn’t have time to think much about Rachel, except for a

brief bout of panic when I thought again about the possibility that the plumber had returned while I was away. A quick look at the clock allayed my fears. It was after 3:00, so the kids would be home, and irresistible impulse or not, I knew Rachel would never do anything in front of the kids.

Driving home, though, Rachel was again all I could think about. The challenge of managing her desires was becoming all-consuming, to me at least. She, by contrast, seemed to feel her actions with Jack had been a fluke. All of our previous discussions had quickly broken down into apologies and promises that it wouldn't happen again.

Was she deflecting on purpose? Was she somehow unaware of her own longings? Could she have been the only person in the kitchen in the morning who didn't see what was about to happen? Would she have been shocked at the plumber's approach? Surprised when her body responded to his touch?

I shuddered at that thought. She was a smart, together person, and able to recognize her behavior in retrospect. But was her denial strong enough to prevent her from recognizing danger when it reared its head? Strong enough to prevent her from seeing the trap until after it had been triggered?

I didn't have any answers as I pulled into the driveway. And I didn't have an opportunity to raise the issue at first because the kids demanded all my attention until we finally got them off to sleep.

With the kids in bed, I cornered Rachel in the laundry room, folding clothes. I took up position beside her and began sorting socks.

"So, how was your day?" I asked.

She raised an eyebrow. "Before or after you ravaged me?"

"You seemed to enjoy it."

“I did. I’m just wondering if you’re planning to make midday quickies part of our routine.”

I shrugged. “I think it would raise questions at the office if I made a habit of leaving in the middle of the day. But if I could...”

“Oh well, I guess we’ll just have to keep squeezing it in after the kids are down.”

It was a thin opening, but I didn’t see a better opportunity coming up.

“Do you think we don’t have enough sex?” I asked.

“No... what? I didn’t say that, did I?”

“Squeezing in... makes it sounds like, I dunno.”

“I didn’t mean that.”

She’d stopped folding and was now looking at me instead. “What’s going on with you today?”

“I... I...” I sighed. This was supposed to be about her, not me.

“You were hot as a firecracker today,” I offered.

She shook her head. “I was just picking out a suit for you. And then you were all over me. Would it have been better if I’d shooed you away?”

I suppressed a groan. My approach had been too clumsy. What was I expecting? A tearful admission that she’d been fantasizing about fucking the plumber? That I had saved her from her uncontrollable passions?

To deal with our problem we needed to have a conversation about it. To have a conversation, we both needed to be honest. But how could I expect her to be forthcoming, when I was having so much trouble being candid myself.

“You’re right. Sometimes I just can’t help myself,” I replied.

She grinned. “Well, I am a hot momma after all.”

“That you are. That you are.”

That evening, after Rachel went to bed, I unburdened myself to Tommy in a long emotional email. He was, after all, just an email address, so it seemed safe. And unlike Michelle, he wasn't bound by professional ethics or tasked with getting Rach and I back together. I didn't really know who he was, but for now, it was enough to have a lifeline of sorts.

I gave him a little more background about our lives and then told him about Rachel's affair, or near-affair, or whatever the fuck it was. I told him a little about what I'd learned about Rachel's sexual past. I told him about the plumber.

—That's some heavy shit. He replied. You guys should probably be in counseling.

—Yeah. We are. The thing is, all we talk about is talking. Communication being the key. But I sort of feel like that's not the problem. I think I know what Rachel wants. I just don't quite know how to give it to her. I can't count on always been there in time to consummate her attractions, to redirect her uncontrollable impulses.

—Uncontrollable is a loaded word. You really think she can't control herself?

I had to think about that for a while. Was that really what I believed?

—It is deep-seated. She's been dealing with this for a long time. Her attractions... they've always been a source of shame, and yet she's gone there again and again. I don't know if she can't control herself, or just doesn't want to, or what. What I do know is that she has a pattern of sabotaging her relationships, throwing herself

into the arms of a bad boy, then regrets, a recommitment to an appropriate relationship. Rinse and repeat.

*—Except it wasn't. You two have been together for ten years. Why now?
Or do you think she's gotten away with it before?*

I shuddered as I read the email. I'd been in denial about that possibility. I had trusted her assertions that Jack was the only time she'd strayed. But was that true? And if it was, then Tommy's other question was right on the mark. What had happened to suddenly unleash her demons?

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

In one sense, Rachel and I were back on track. There was humor in our relationship and some passion. And, of course, we'd never lost our bond as parents. Still, I couldn't help but feel that this was all a sham. We hadn't resolved anything. Not really.

The tight skirts had disappeared back into the recesses of her closet. But the episode with the plumber had reinforced the fact that there was still something lurking inside her, something that I couldn't reach myself, even if I could sometimes benefit from it.

I wanted her to respond to me as she had to Jack and the plumber. But instead, when I'd tried to order her to suck my cock, she'd been amused. When I brought out the cuffs, she went along, humoring me. But that's not what I wanted. I wanted what I had seen in our kitchen, our bedroom, my wife as a hot, aroused, slut.

Part of it was that I didn't want her seeking those thrills, that excitement, elsewhere, behind my back. Part of it was that I wanted to experience it for myself.

I reflected again on the idea of giving her a free pass. That might work. She'd get it out of her system. But I didn't know if I could deal with it.

The idea itself was painful. Her in a bikini at a resort, fielding endless offers until she found a man sufficiently "inappropriate" to ring her bell. Who would that be? Another guest? A vacationing lothario? A hunky barkeep? A muscular beach attendant? Would she get off on seducing a staff member, knowing he'd probably let everyone know he'd bagged her? That the hot married slut in the pink bikini had sucked him off behind the equipment shack?

When I closed my eyes I could picture it clearly. Rachel on her knees, her bikini top pushed up to expose her pert breasts and hard nips. I could see him, a barrel-chested Latino, his brown skin contrasting with his white uniform. She'd be slobbering on his fat tool, bobbing up and down as he smirked at her and planned what he'd do to her next.

Is that what she wanted? Really?

Well, it didn't really matter. I didn't think I was strong enough to let her go off like that. I wouldn't be able to put it out of my head. Whatever she did, I'd multiply ten times in my imagination, and that would feed my resentment hundred-fold.

I was tired of going around in circles. I wished I could just put it all behind me. But I couldn't. I needed to communicate better with Rachel, but I couldn't bring myself to confront her. I wanted her to confess and explain, but she wouldn't.

We'd just finished off another fruitless counseling session with Michelle, an hour spent talking about the future. As if that were the problem. I already knew we were compatible on that front. Over the years we'd harmonized on so many things: how to raise the kids, where to vacation, how much to save for retirement. Reiterating that we didn't have any major conflicts of expectations on any of that only seemed to highlight the problem we were having.

Rachel had gone off to pick up the kids from school. I was sitting in my study, supposedly checking work email, but really just staring out the window.

My wife gets off on the idea of inappropriate sex. And I, unfortunately, am perfectly, obviously, unassailably appropriate.

That was the problem. But as long as Rachel wasn't willing to admit it or even acknowledge it, I didn't feel comfortable enough to express it. That's the problem with "communication" as a cure all. The reality is that we all keep things inside us. Sometimes it is because the truth is too painful to speak aloud. Just as often it is because we know that being completely honest will bring offense and tension. If I stated my conclusion, Rachel would be hurt and mortified. She'd get defensive. She'd accuse me of paranoia, or worse, of seeking to torment her. I wouldn't be a brave man speaking painful truths, I'd be a passive-aggressive douchebag using guilt to get revenge for being wronged.

The problem was, that alternative spin wasn't that far off from the truth either. Maybe Rachel was right. Maybe I was holding on to my resentments and making something out of nothing. Maybe this was more about my needs and wants rather than hers.

That didn't feel right to me. Whatever weird emotions were conjured up by her admissions about her sexual past, and whatever projections were responsible for my interpretation of the scene with the plumber, regardless of all of that, this had all begun when Rachel had driven through the night and tearfully confessed to me that she'd just taken her boss' cock in her mouth. And that that had been merely the culmination of weeks of teasing, exhibitionism, and mutual masturbation.

I sighed. So was that how this all ended? Was I just working myself up to the moment when I could take the blame on myself? That's where we were headed.

Tommy and I kept exchanging emails, but while he was perceptive and sympathetic, he wasn't giving me any real advice. I felt like I had just

gotten into another counseling session. Every time I tried to get some concrete advice, he'd turn it around and ask me what I thought I should do.

–Come on man, give me some real suggestions. How do I get her to think of me the way she thinks of those other guys? Or am I just wasting my time? Should I just give up? Hope for the best, while waiting for the other shoe to drop?

–Look, it's not that simple. And don't let anyone tell you otherwise. I wish there were a simple list of tips and tricks. But anyone who tells you there is is full of shit. You need to learn to read her. To push her buttons. To keep her off-balance enough that she gets out of her comfort zone, but not so much that she balks.

–So what do I do now? I feel helpless.

–Look, the best I can offer is to come over. You know, work with you and her.

I sighed. Had all of this just been a long seduction? Just talk building to the point where he invited himself over for a threesome. I took a deep breath. Maybe I was misreading him.

–What, you mean like a marriage counselor? 'Cause we're already doing that.

–No, it would be something more hands-on, I guess. I'm really good with women, and with this fantasy in particular. You might learn a lot from seeing how she reacts to me.

Fucking bastard. He'd just been running a game on me. I felt worse than ever. Not only was my wife thinking of other men, but now I'd naively

been sharing my deepest fears and emotions with a guy who was just thinking of bagging her.

–Is this how you get your kicks, you sick fuck? Search out vulnerable people on message boards and then befriend them. What do you get out of it? You like humiliating people? Or is this just a way to get your dick wet?

He didn't reply right away. Actually he didn't reply that night at all. I was looking for catharsis. I needed him to reply so I could end our conversation once and for all. I checked my email obsessively all evening, even waking up in the middle of the night to check the account. But no email from Tommy.

It was the following evening before he replied.

–I hope you've cooled down. All you had to say was, no. But look, I wasn't playing you. I've never asked you for pics of your wife. I've never even asked about her looks. You asked for help. I can help. But there is nothing I can do by email other than provide a sympathetic ear. In person though? Who knows. If I can't make a connection, then no harm no foul. Nothing happens and you at least get confirmation from someone who's been around the block a few times that she's a particularly tough case. But if I can read her, then maybe I can give you that key insight you've been missing. And maybe I can do more. Maybe I can make her see you in a different light. But that won't happen with just talk. You're right about that. You've been doing the talk therapy stuff for months. You need to take it further if you want a breakthrough.

I wanted to delete the email thread, just forget all about him. But in a weird way, it all made sense. I'd been toying with the idea of giving her a free pass, either explicitly by encouraging her to take some time off periodically to scratch her itch, or implicitly by just pretending everything was alright even though I knew that it was only a matter of time before she ended up seduced by an "inappropriate" man. Neither of those options appealed to me.

But this... this was, oddly enough, a middle ground. It was still my play. I would be setting it up. Tommy was my contact, my friend even, I guess. In a strange way, I could still feel in control. I wrote him back.

–What even makes you think she'd be into you?

–I don't. Not for sure. It would work best if you put me in touch with her. Let her email with me for a while so I can get a sense about her.

I read his email and thought about it. Certainly an email exchange couldn't hurt. But it was hard to imagine how I'd propose this to Rachel.

–How would I even explain that to her? Hey, honey, would you mind emailing with this guy I met online through a BDSM website?

–See, man, that's your problem. You are going into this with a completely negative vibe. You're assuming you're going to get shot down before you even try. That's why she gets amused instead of turned on when you try to push the envelope. You're not committed to it yourself. All you need to tell her is that you're still upset about her affair. Tell her you're having trouble expressing yourself and that you'd like to bring another perspective into the mix. If she wants to

*know more about me, just tell her, “It’s complicated, but I trust him.”
But that’s the thing. You need to trust me. Do you trust me?*

Did I trust him? It seems like a crazy question. How can anyone trust a stranger they meet online? And not just online, but online on a BDSM message board populated by, for the most part, frankly, crazy people. But there was nothing rational in any of this. Nothing rational about Rachel’s affair, about my inability to get it out of my head, about any of it. I was out of my depth. I needed help. And I needed more than conventional marriage counseling could provide.

–Okay. But one condition, you don’t try to get her to meet up with you behind my back.

–I would never do that. Not now and not ever. If it ever gets to the point where we meet, it will be the three of us. But I also have a condition. If she agrees to talk to me, you have to respect her privacy. She’s going to need to feel like she can confide in me, and that can’t happen if she thinks everything she says will get back to you.

I thought about it. His point seemed reasonable, and yet it set off alarm bells. Was I really going to put my wife in touch with a man who knew her fantasies (or at least my perception of them) and who considered himself an expert in that sort of fetish? And not only put them in touch, but commit myself to allowing them a private, confidential channel?

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

I lay beside Rachel. She was asleep, breathing softly, peacefully. I couldn't sleep. We'd had a normal day. I'd come home from work. Rachel was cheerful. The kids babbled on about school. Rachel told me about how she'd reorganized the garage. We talked about vacation plans.

All this normalcy felt oppressive to me. I'd never really understood the term "getting closure" before. It seemed like psychobabble to me. Either you get over something, or you don't. Either you stay angry or you don't. Right? But in our case, we had, I guess, "gotten over it." Rachel and I were getting along fine. We were back to normal, at least ostensibly. But we, or at least I, had never gotten closure.

As long as things were raw, I was able to deal with it. My inner turmoil was mirrored in our tense relationship. But now that things were better, I was coming to realize, or at least fear, that there would never be a moment of release, of catharsis, of, fuck, whatever. I didn't know what I really wanted.

Well, that's not true. What I wanted was to turn back time to a moment before Jack, before therapy, before my thoughts were constantly haunted by the fear that Rachel was going to cheat on me.

But that wasn't true either, because I also, in a weird way, wanted to experience and enjoy that dirty girl I'd discovered inside my wife. The kind of woman I could imagine tying up and teasing. The kind of woman who I could bend over a kitchen counter or throw onto the bed and ravage in the middle of the day.

Jesus, I felt like I had the winning numbers for the lottery, but had forgotten to play for the week. Or something like that. I was so close. I had

a beautiful, smart, funny wife. Bonus, she had a wild, kinky side. Problem was, that part of her was only available to “inappropriate” men, and my efforts to bring it out had only resulted in slapstick.

I cringed as the image, in slow motion, of Rachel pivoting on the door played in my mind. I looked up. It had really happened. The shattered doorframe, the door leaned up to provide a modicum of privacy, a testament to the reality of it.

Calling a handyman to fix the door was on my to-do list. But what we really needed was a handyman for our marriage. I chuckled softly to myself. That’s what Tommy was offering to be. I kept coming around to the same place. He was the only person who seemed to understand what I was going through.

Rachel would, of course, never agree to see Tommy. Which was fine with me. But maybe he could say things to her that I couldn’t, give her, for lack of a better term, a man’s perspective. Maybe that’s really what the problem was and why Michelle’s sessions just weren’t working.

I reflected on that. At the risk of generalizing, I think women react to affairs differently. They focus on the betrayal of trust, on the loss of emotional connection. Men, I think, although also feeling betrayal, tend to focus more on the, I guess, theft of physical exclusivity. Women are often deeply wounded by an emotional affair, regardless of whether it is ever consummated. For me, the most difficult thing was that she was giving another man experiences I would have loved to have. That was the thing. I could have forgiven her for cheating if Jack would do things I wouldn’t.

You really want a blowjob. You fantasize about it. It haunts your dreams. Your wife won’t do it. That’s why men have frequented prostitutes since time immemorial, to experience things their wives are too proud or repressed to offer. But that wasn’t me. Short of scat or bestiality, I would be

willing to humor any of Rachel's needs. Fuck, I'd enjoy it. She was going elsewhere, not because she had to, but because she wouldn't give me a chance.

Now, I realized it wasn't quite that simple. I didn't really know how to give her what she wanted. And asking her wouldn't work. That would, obviously, kill the fantasy. *Tell me how to dominate you.* See, that doesn't work.

I shook Rachel awake. It was an impulsive act. I realized as she looked at me groggily that I wasn't sure what to say next.

"What's the matter? Are you okay?" She asked sleepily.

I tried to formulate my response.

"No, I'm not," I said.

Oh, my God. The words were tumbling from me faster than I could process them. I felt like I was a spectator at a play. Or worse, like a helpless observer watching a man heedlessly approaching a precipice.

"I'm angry and I'm frustrated. And I know I said I've forgiven you, but I haven't."

Tears welled in her eyes. "Oh God, Max. All I can say again is how sorry I am."

"Rachel, stop it. Stop with the tears and stop with the apologies. Every time you do that, it feels like you are trying to shut me down. Like if I express myself I'm tormenting you. Like I'm the bad guy."

She shook her head. "That's not how I mean it. I'm being honest. I regret it."

I laughed.

"What?" she asked, her tone becoming more aggressive.

"That's why you do it. You like that feeling of guilt. You knew you'd regret it. That's what made it hot. You knew you'd regret sucking Jack's

cock. And it was that knowledge that you'd regret it that got you so horned up with the plumber."

"I don't know what you're talking about."

"Yes you do. When I threw you on the bed, you were already all fired up. And it wasn't from looking in my closet and picking out a suit. What were you thinking about? Thinking about seducing him? Thinking about him forcing himself on you? You knew I was at work, but were you secretly imagining me walking in on you? Or your tearful confession later on?"

She sat up, angry. "Yeah, Max, you know all about me. Know what makes me tick, right? No way this is just about punishing me. About dredging up everything you can to make me look and feel like a piece of shit."

"Well, what do you expect? You've never let me in. You apologize, but you never explain anything. Maybe I'm wrong. I don't know. I don't know anything. All I know is that whatever you saw in Jack, you don't see in me. You'd never let me do what he did to you."

"Is that it? That's what you want? Want me to be your private little porn star? Want me to get on my knees and let you blow a load all over my face? And why? Because you'd enjoy it? Or because you just like the idea of putting me in my place?"

I shook my head. "Your place? What the fuck is that? When have I ever acted like I wanted to put you down? And fuck it, Rachel, why is this about me again. I'm not the one who..."

I trailed off. I didn't even know where we were going anymore in this conversation.

"Who what? Say it Max. Say what you're thinking."

She was furious now. We were at the precipice. We could back away. We could fall. Or we could try to cross. I took a deep breath and forced

myself to be calm, which wasn't easy since my heart was beating like a hummingbird's.

"Rachel, I'm sorry. I'm not actually sure what I am sorry about. But I don't want to hurt you. And I want us to get better. But therapy isn't working."

"So, what? You want a separation?"

"What? No! Do you?"

She hesitated. "I know it is my fault..."

I opened my mouth, but she put up her hand to cut me off.

"...I'm not saying that to put you on the defensive. But it is what it is. And the truth is, if you can't get past this, then we don't have a future. So, what is it going to be?"

I shook my head again. "It doesn't have to be all or nothing. Look, therapy with Michelle isn't working, or at least isn't enough. But that doesn't mean we can't get past this. But you need to be part of it."

"What do you want me to do?"

"I..." I hesitated again. God, what was I doing?

"I have a friend. I met him online. He's... we'll he's gone through something similar."

"Wait, wait, wait... you told some stranger online about our problems? About me?"

"No. I mean, yes. But it's not like that. He knows our first names. And that we live in the Bay Area. But that's it."

"Oh God, what if he tracks us down..."

"Rachel, stop it. If he does, he does. Whatever. The point is, he's got a lot of insights into this and I just think he can help us."

"I don't get it."

“I don’t know that I get it either. But I just want you to speak to him. You know. Confide in him. I think he might be able to help us work things out.”

She shook her head. “I don’t know, Max. I don’t know if I can do that. What do we know about this guy?”

“Not much. But that’s the point in a way. He’s just a voice in the ether. But.... It’s hard to explain.... Look, just talk to him, okay? I promised him it would be confidential. I won’t ask him what you said to him. You have a conversation with him. I have one with him as well. And maybe he can bridge the gap.”

“I dunno. It’s weird.”

I laughed. “Yeah, it is.”

I got serious again. “How long have you been thinking about us separating?”

She looked away and seemed to contemplate her answer. “It’s been so tense between us. It feels like we’re back to normal, and then it isn’t. I don’t want that, but I have thought that maybe that was where we were headed.”

I nodded. “Well, me too. But I don’t want that either. But not wanting it isn’t enough. So will you do this? Will you talk to Tommy?”

“Tommy? That’s his name?”

“As far as I know.”

She hesitated. “Okay Max. If that’s what you want, I’ll do it.”

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

I connected them by email. Tommy assured me again that despite the agreement about confidentiality, he'd do nothing behind my back. They wouldn't meet, at the very least, without me knowing about it and being involved. But that concern was a long ways off. Rachel was obviously just doing it to placate me. I couldn't really imagine her confiding in him, much less ever getting comfortable enough to invite him into our real, rather than virtual, lives.

Still, for the first time in a while, I felt that at least I wasn't alone in this.

Although she'd quit her job, Rachel still kept a toe in the professional world by doing some freelance projects online. It was low paying and the work didn't take advantage of her real skills, but every evening she'd taken to doing an hour or two of bookkeeping or data entry or whatever came across the transom.

Tommy had let me know that she'd responded to his initial email. I knew that Rachel had initially agreed to communicate with Tommy to humor me. But I had no real way to find out how often they were emailing. From my own experience, I knew that when he was by the computer, he was so responsive that it was almost like texting.

It was very weird being in the dark, knowing that my wife was communicating with another man and maybe even confiding in him things about our marriage. Wallowing in uncertainty, I imagined wildly different outcomes. Was she just indulging me, responding to Tommy in the written equivalent of monosyllabic grunts? Or was she engaged in a deep, revealing

conversation? I didn't know. I wasn't about to invade her privacy. All I knew was that she was spending a lot of time on the computer.

The kids were asleep. I was playing Madden on the Xbox, online. I heard Rachel clear her throat. I looked up and gasped.

“Does my big football player need his own personal cheerleader?”

She was wearing a Florida Gators cheerleader outfit, but sluttier. Bright orange, it was comprised of a mini skirt, barely more than a belt, and a cropped top, barely more than a bra. She had blue pom poms and knee high, white, heeled boots.

The whistle blew on screen. I had just gotten sacked while admiring her costume.

“Tsk tsk, you need to focus on the game,” she said.

“I could turn it off.”

She shook her head. “No, that won't do. You can't expect me to date a quitter...”

Another whistle. Delay of game.

“Or a loser.”

“What do you mean?”

“Well, you can't expect me to put out for just anyone.”

I looked back at the screen. Got a play called just in time. Quick slants. Picked up a few yards.

“That's better,” she giggled. “Now, I'll just help you relax a little. But this is all you get unless you win.”

She squatted down in front of me, giving me a quick flash of her tiny white panties. She edged off my sweatpants and pulled down my boxers. I gasped as she seized my hard cock and gave it a firm squeeze.

I called a pass play, saw my tight end come open, but I threw the pass a millisecond too late. Incomplete. I was lucky not to get picked off. Still, I needed to punt.

“Who are you playing?” she asked.

I shrugged. “I dunno. Some kid probably.”

“Is he good?”

“Yeah. Very quick on D.”

“Think he’s got a girl sucking him?”

She leaned down and circled my cock head with her tongue, making me shiver.

“Probably not.”

“Well, then you’ll win easily. You have more motivation.”

“It’s not that easy --”

I gasped as she swallowed me deep into her mouth.

I mistimed the punt and shanked it. He had great field position. We were tied at 7-7, but he was already in field goal range. I needed to hold him. He was too good on defense for me to count on a touchdown. I called a zone, cheated in with my linebacker.

Rachel’s tongue circled the head of my cock, her hands squeezing my balls. I hesitated a half second. His slot receiver broke past my linebacker. I tried to blitz, but got there a millisecond too late. He juke out of a tackle inside the ten and scored.

Rachel looked up with a grin.

“Do you know where he lives?” she asked.

“No, why?” I asked, perhaps more annoyed than I’ve ever been at a woman sucking my cock.

“Well, if I am going to screw the winner, it’d be better if he were local.”

“You want me to tell him what he’s got coming?”

She licked my shaft up and down. “Sounds like a good idea.”

I shook my head. “I’m pretty sure telling him that my wife will fuck him if he wins would violate the Xbox terms of service... not to mention getting us both thrown in jail if he’s thirteen.”

“Well, then you better buckle down, or we’re both going to bed frustrated tonight.”

“I could always jerk off.”

“And I could always go out and find someone else to... um... satisfy me.”

I looked down at her, so sexy, stroking my wet cock up and down. Luckily his kickoff bounced into the endzone. Okay, I could play this game.

“Alright, my slutty cheerleader. If I win, you do whatever I want. If he wins, you go out and find a stud to bone you silly.”

“That’s the plan,” she replied lewdly.

I had the ball at the twenty and a lot of time on the clock, but I didn’t want to end the game trying to hold him. With Rachel distracting me, I couldn’t possibly react fast enough on defense. But I could outthink this fucking kid on offense.

I worked him slowly, quick slants, and dives, just eating up yards and time. I could see him getting frustrated, calling bigger blitzes, lining up more men in the box. I saw my receivers lined up one-on-one. But I couldn’t risk it. A long score would give him the ball back with time on his side, an incomplete pass would force me to give up my four yards at a time game plan.

I crossed the fifty despite Rachel’s distractions. I don’t think she’d ever slobbered so enthusiastically on my balls or stroked my cock so hard. She noticed my progress and then stood and quickly stepped out of her tiny

panties, flashing me a shaved, bare twat. She hadn't worn it like that in years. She dropped the panties on the table

"It'll probably be easier for me to get laid without those," she cooed.

I wanted nothing more than to bury my face in her gorgeous, newly shaved snatch.

I looked her up and down. In that outfit she'd be liable to be arrested with or without panties. The whistle blew. Fuck, delay of game. I had to refocus.

Rachel smirked at me and then stalked over to the television. Standing just off to the side, she turned around and slowly, slowly bent at that waist, those high, white boots, maddeningly erotic. I called an out, a super dangerous play, and nailed the pass just before my opponent was able to jump the pass. First down.

"Oooh, you are good," she sighed, lifting her tiny skirt to expose her ass, her beautiful pussy. She reached between her legs, slid a finger up and down the length of her slit.

Three minutes left. I ran off-tackles, left, then right. Third and two. A dive and a first down. I was inside the thirty. My opponent called a time out, now worried about the clock. He put his defense into a prevent, basically offering me the score if I was willing to two or three putt. But that would leave too much time on the clock. I kept the ball on the ground.

Rachel was now fingering herself, her long, slender finger slowly, slowly sliding into her wet cunt. She pulled it out and licked it clean.

"You're running out of time," she sighed. "And I am soooo ready. Somebody at the Redwood is going to get lucky."

The Redwood was our local bar and grill, not exactly a hot spot, but between the bartenders and regulars, she would definitely have no trouble finding a cock.

Under two minutes. He was out of timeouts. I was inside the ten. Rachel had come back over to me and was trying a devilish new trick. She'd finger herself and then trace her moist digit along my cock and then follow her finger with her tongue. My vision actually seemed to blur with excitement.

My concentration waned for a second. I missed the hole with my running back and took a loss. I had to take a timeout now. Twenty seconds. Two plays left, three if I were lucky, from the twelve.

"Remember, the man who wins me gets anything he wants," she moaned. "For as long as he wants."

"Maybe I should lose on purpose, just for the fun of seeing you go through with it."

That seemed to shock her, an anxious look crossed her face. Was she imagining me driving her to the Redwood, making sure she delivering on her teasing? I grinned.

Tight end cross. Slow developing, I knew I'd need to avoid his blitz. I saw him take control of his left linebacker. I took the snap and moved my left, away from him. As he crossed the line of scrimmage, I released the pass, too soon for the pattern, but perfectly timed given his own actions. Touchdown.

I looked down at Rachel.

"You're still down," she teased.

"Not for long," I replied. "Get on your hands and knees."

She obeyed and I slid behind her, my cock jutting out, aimed between her legs.

"Not unless you win," she insisted.

I laughed. From the two, he stacked everything on the line. I called a quick slant. Snap, immediate throw, he tackled my receiver after just two

yards, but it was enough. I dropped the controller and thrust into Rachel hard. I squeezed her ass and fucked her almost violently.

She was incredibly hot and wet. I spread her ass cheeks and admired her tiny, little rosebud clenching with each stroke. *Anything*, she'd said. *Anything*. But all I wanted was her pussy. I rammed her hard, then reached under the tiny top and groped at her breasts, pinching her rock hard nipples.

It was too much for either of us. I felt her cunt clench on my cock just as my balls tightened to prepare my own release. We came together and collapsed onto the floor.

We lay in bed, sweating and very satisfied. The session in front of the TV had transitioned into one in the bedroom. At some point she'd lost her boots, top, and pom poms, but she was still wearing the belt-sized skirt.

"That was fun," she said.

I laughed. "I'll say. Would you really have gone through with going out to the Redwood?"

She hesitated. "Maybe I'd have gone, but..."

She reached out and ran her hand over my cock checking for a sign of life.

"If you want more, you will need to visit the Redwood," I said. I was feeling completely drained.

"That was fun," she said again, but this time her tone was different, the stress on the word "was" rather than "fun." There was also a "but" coming.

I provided it, "but?"

"But, well Max, this was fun..."

"You already said that."

“But, well, I wish you could just share your fantasies with me yourself and not do this whole Tommy thing.”

“This was Tommy’s idea? The cheerleader outfit?”

“Oh, come on, Max. I know you’re Tommy.”

“I’m Tommy?”

“Max, this is only making things worse. Inventing imaginary third parties is not a healthy way to communicate. Tonight was fun. I admit, if you’d suggested it outright, it might have been weird, but...”

“Would you have done it?”

She laughed. “I don’t know. To tell you the truth, I don’t know. I’d like to say yes, to say I’m game and giving, but it is weird to have your husband suggest you dress up as a slutty cheerleader and then,” she giggled, “and then offer to screw the winning quarterback.”

“I’m not Tommy.”

“Look, I promise to try harder, but just talk to me —“

“Seriously, Rach, I am not Tommy. He’s a real person.”

She sat up and the sheet fell off her. My eyes drifted down to her bare chest. I’m thirty-seven, but I still can’t keep my eyes off a pair of naked tits.

“No, Max, no. You’re Tommy.”

I shook my head.

She put her hand to her mouth. “Oh my God!”

“What?”

“Please Max, please tell me this is some sort of game.”

“What is the big deal?”

“The big deal, Max, is that I’ve told him everything. I told him about Jack, about Tony, about the Cellars. I told him about Cancun...” she hadn’t told *me* about Cancun, I could only wonder what that was about. “I’ve been

spilling my guts out to *you*, trying to make things right with *you*, and now you tell me it was another man?”

“Rachel, I’m not upset. I think –“

“You think? I sent him a naked picture of myself. I thought I was sending it to you. I thought it was all a game.”

I sighed. “I never –“

“No, God, Max, no you never pretended otherwise. Oh God,” she sighed. “Fuck, I really am just a stupid, stupid whore. Well, good job, you proved that once and for all.”

I sat up as well. “Rachel, I get that you’re upset, but why? So you gave another man some personal details, and you and I then had some totally hot, totally fun sex. So what if he has a naked picture of you?”

“I wouldn’t have done it if I’d known.”

I shrugged. “Okay. But so what? Who’s been hurt by it? And who’s to say this isn’t, exactly, what we need.”

“What’s the end game here? He suggests fantasies and we role play them?”

“Maybe. I don’t really know.”

She looked at me skeptically. “You’re holding out on me.”

I sighed. “Okay, Rachel, but just know I never agreed to anything.”

“Oh God, Max, what?”

“He wants to meet us. He thinks, I guess, that he can work with us, help us, I dunno, get in touch with our real needs and desires.”

“And what are those?”

“See, Rach, that’s the point. What are those?”

We both looked at each other, but neither one of us seemed able to speak. In a weird way, our silence spoke louder than words.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Instead of communicating more, we retreated, both of us to our computers, both of us communing with our virtual therapist. During the day, we were a portrait of normalcy, keeping up the house, being extra attentive parents. In fact, Brent and Allison, in contrast to other six year olds, almost seemed annoyed by engagement.

“Mom, can we just watch SpongeBob?” They chimed in unison at her latest effort to induce them into playing a board game.

I laughed. Rachel looked over at me, initially annoyed, then rueful.

She walked over to me, leaving the kids gratefully alone with their favorite talking kitchen implement. It was time to broach it.

“So, have you been talking to him?” I asked.

“I thought that was confidential?” she replied.

I nodded, but she replied anyway. “Yeah.”

“Still sharing with him?”

She nodded. “I shouldn’t, right?”

“Why not?”

“Because Max, we can both see where this is going. He’s worming his way into our lives. He already knows more about me than any man.”

I nodded “Me too. But somehow, I trust him.”

She sighed. “I do too. And that’s the problem. We shouldn’t.”

“Why not?”

“He doesn’t have our best interests at heart.”

“How do you know?” I asked.

“Why would he?”

“Why wouldn’t he?”

“Max...”

I put my hand on her forearm. “What’s the worst case?”

“The worst case? He’s a psycho killer.”

“Do you believe that?”

She laughed. “They say Ted Bundy was charming.”

“That’s not your real worry.”

“He doesn’t just want to talk.”

“No, he wants to work with us.”

“He wants to fuck me,” she replied.

We both instinctively looked over at the kids to see if they had heard. They hadn’t. Mom and Dad cursing was still much less interesting than cartoons.

“Has he told you that?”

“Yes. And more.”

I knew better than to ask for additional details. I was already skirting the edges of my promise about confidentiality.

“And you’re upset because you don’t want to? Or because you do?”

“Max, don’t...”

“Don’t what, Rach?”

“Just, don’t...”

I shook my head. “I can’t Rach. I want to make you feel like Tony and Jack and your fantasy about the plumber, and I just don’t know how. If he can do that to you, bring that out, and if I can learn...”

“Max, this is crazy. I am perfectly satisfied with –“

“Exactly. Satisfied. Not fulfilled. Not completed. Not overwhelmed. I satisfy you. And you know what? Maybe that’s enough for you. Maybe it really is. But it isn’t for me. I don’t want to be the kind of husband who does just the minimum to keep you happy.”

“You’re not, Max, I swear you’re not.”

“Not in all ways... but in some. You don’t need to say it. I appreciate your not being willing to.”

She sighed and shook her head. “This is crazy. So, what, we invite another man into our lives. And then what?”

“He either makes us or breaks us,” I replied with more equanimity than I actually felt.

“That’s a hell of a risk.”

“I don’t think we have a choice... and neither do you.”

She didn’t reply immediately. Instead she just stared at the kids watching the TV. Then without a word she gave me a quick, firm nod.

We invited him over in a joint email. No more secrets at this point. He replied promptly.

–Okay, but there are three rules, one for each of us.

Rachel: You have to promise to obey me without question.

Max: You have to promise to not interfere.

Me: I promise that if either of you says the word “Aardvark,” I will immediately stop what I am doing and leave.

We confirmed our agreement and set a date. The kids would be at my parents’ house for the weekend. It would just be the three of us.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

We were both extremely nervous as it got closer to Tommy's arrival. I think we each sort of hoped the other would pull the plug on it. But for me, this seemed to be my only chance to move forward. And for Rachel, well, I guess Tommy had done a good job piquing her interest.

She had dressed casually, but with obvious care. She was wearing her best jeans, the ones that most flattered her gorgeous ass, and a blue, ribbed tee that brought out the color of her eyes. She had slipped into a pair of open-toed sandals, with a low heel, and I noticed she'd recently redone her finger and toenails in a rich, glossy red.

The doorbell rang. I looked over at my wife. She was blushing and twisting her hands nervously. She gave me a small nod signaling she still wanted to go through with it.

I opened the door. He was shorter than I had expected. Maybe five-foot-eight and a little older than I'd thought, in his early fifties. He was wearing tan slacks and a white, button-down, short-sleeve, un-tucked shirt. His chest hair peeked out, thick and salt and pepper, matching the hair on his head. He and Rachel had the same eyes, blue-grey. He had thick arms, an anchor tattooed on his forearm. He gave me a confident smile and a firm handshake.

"Hi Max, nice to meet you."

"Um, yeah, come on in."

He clapped me on the shoulder and leaned in close. "You still okay with this?"

I nodded.

"Remember the safe word?"

I nodded again.

“Okay, let’s go meet Rachel.”

She hadn’t moved. She was still rooted to the same spot in the kitchen, still wringing her hands. When she saw Tommy, she gave him a small smile that did little to counter the anxious look in her eyes. She followed with an awkward little wave.

He approached her directly, looking her up and down as he approached. She stuck out her hand, but he ignored the proffer, and instead took her by the back of the neck and pulled her into a quick, but charged kiss on the lips. As they broke the embrace, she looked from him to me with a look of near panic on her face.

He ran his hand over her shoulder and down her arm, taking her wrist in a firm grip.

“Look at me,” he said tersely.

She returned her gaze to him.

“You’re a pretty girl,” he said, appraising her again, “but I would have liked you to dress sexier for me.”

She hesitated and looked over at me again. He squeezed her wrist tighter and she again focused on him again.

“Should... should I change?” she asked tentatively.

“Yes... but first, I think you should get on your knees and give me a proper welcome.”

“What? You don’t mean...”

“Now, hold on,” I interjected.

This was moving too far too fast.

He chuckled mirthlessly, never taking his eyes off her, and she in turn now seemed incapable of looking away from him.

Without looking at me, he spoke to both of us. “I gave you each a single rule to follow. I’ve been here less than two minutes and you’ve both already broken your commitments. Now, you know how to end this. But until you do that, I expect you both to keep your promises.”

I sighed. Another fucking disaster. But as the seconds ticked by I realized that Rachel hadn’t spoken the safe word. And even though “aardvark” was on the tip of my tongue, I hadn’t said it either.

“Rachel,” he said simply, though there was a weird force behind it.

She gave him a small nod, and then to my shock, slowly dropped down to her knees before him.

“That’s a good girl,” he said in a tone that was just barely removed from the way one might praise a dog. “You know what to do.”

Another small nod and she reached out and began to unbuckle his belt. He didn’t help. He obviously wanted to make it clear that she was freely carrying out his instructions. She unzipped his pants and yanked them down to mid-thigh. She reached out and began to fondle his package through his striped boxers.

She was staring straight ahead. Was she enthralled with her task? Was she merely trying to avoid making eye contact with either of us? I noticed she was breathing heavily, her cheeks pink with excitement, her lips pursed slightly. Unlike my past efforts, she’s wasn’t just amusing me this time. She was getting into it for real.

She snaked her hand into the front of his shorts. She began pumping her hand up and down. She looked up at him. They made eye contact. Something passed between them, and he gave her a quick smile and a nod. She blushed more deeply and looked away, still avoiding me, though I could see a grin on her face as well.

What was it? A private joke? They'd been emailing back and forth for a month, each only sharing with me snippets of their conversation. It had culminated in this. Supposedly this was all for me. Tommy was working for me, and Rachel was doing it at my behest. So why was I suddenly feeling like such a mark?

"Go ahead," he said softly yet firmly.

She didn't hesitate this time. Instead she deftly maneuvered his cock through the opening in his boxers and resumed stroking him firmly. Fuck he was big. Nothing freakish, but very thick, with a prominent head. She licked her lips and looked up at him again. He gave her another small smile. This time there was nothing mysterious about their communication this time. *Nice Cock! Thanks.*

"Suck it," he ordered.

It felt like he'd said it more for me than for her. She was already leaning forward, gripping his shaft with both hands, her lips pursed to kiss his spongy head. As her lips touched the tip of his prick, her tongue suddenly shot out and encircled the head. He ran his fingers through her hair, brushing the strands from her face, giving him a clearer view. She opened her mouth wide, took the head of his cock inside her. I knew from experience what she was doing now, vigorously swirling her tongue around his glans.

"That's good," he moaned contentedly.

Jesus. I couldn't believe what I was seeing. The whole fucking process of exploration and discovery that we'd gone through from the time she confessed her affair had been supposed to prevent her from cheating on me, supposed to give me the confidence to trust her. And yet, it had all led to this point, with her on her knees sucking another man's cock.

Aardvark! Aardvark! Aardvark!

The word was trying to force its way out. I could end it. I should end it. And yet, in a weird way, I knew somehow that if I did that, I'd be forced to give up on the marriage. This was the only way forward. This was the only way I could learn to give her what she wanted, or at least to understand it enough to come to terms with it.

Rachel, for her part, didn't seem as conflicted, or actually, at all conflicted. She was sucking on Tommy's big tool like it was the most natural thing in the world. She was taking him deeper now, bobbing up and down on him more rapidly, the room filling with wet slurping sounds from her efforts.

"You're good at that, aren't you? Had lots of practice, lots of practice sucking cock," he taunted.

She didn't answer or pause. She just continued to slaver over his erection.

He suddenly closed his fist on a mass of her hair, freezing her in place. She looked up at him, her expression seeming to betray a fear that she had displeased him somehow. He chuckled.

"You're doing fine. I just wanted to look at you. There's nothing sexier than a pretty girl with a mouthful of cock."

I nodded despite myself. He was right though. She did look insanely hot like that, on her knees, her hands encircling his shaft, her lips stretched around his fat cock.

He reached down into his pocket and pulled out his cell phone.

"Wai..." I began to protest, but then stopped. It was all or nothing, and I wasn't ready for nothing.

He looked over at me, as if inviting me to end it. At the very least, he was giving me every opportunity to pull the plug, as he had from the very beginning. It was that consideration that had gotten us this far. Again I

wondered whether he was genuinely trying to help or whether he was a master con man who'd been playing me perfectly.

He snapped a picture and then another and another.

“What do you think, baby? Should we send this to your contacts list? Post them up on your Facebook page? You don't mind letting your husband see you suck cock, how about your friends and family. Think they'd be surprised? Or do you think they already suspect you're a secret little whore?”

She didn't answer verbally. She couldn't, not with her mouth full of cock. But she did answer in her own way, shaking off his hand and taking him even deeper into her mouth. Over and over she swallowed his big prick. His shaft glistened with her spit. She pumped him up and down roughly with her fist.

“You want my come, don't you?” he asked.

Her eyes flashed and she swallowed him deeper still. She released his shaft and reached around to grab his ass. He began thrusting into her mouth. She met his strokes enthusiastically, urging him on with small, submissive moans.

Their eyes were locked as he began to groan. “Oh fuck yeah.”

She flinched momentarily as his hot seed flooded her mouth, but she quickly adjusted, gulping down each spurt. When he was done coming, she continued to bathe his cock with her tongue, lapping up every drop of his jism. Then, when she'd milked him dry, she gently eased his cock back into his shorts. She pulled up his pants and zipped them up, finally, re-buckling his belt.

“You can go change now,” he said dismissively.

She nodded submissively.

“And no underwear,” he added.

She walked quickly out of the room, not making eye contact with me. I heard her going up the stairs and walking into the bedroom.

“I said... are you okay?”

I turned toward Tommy giving me a concerned look.

I hesitated. “I don’t know.”

“I warned you, right?”

I nodded. “I just don’t see how this is going to help.”

Before he could answer, we heard Rachel coming back down the stairs. She’d quickly changed into a sheer, black and white gingham pattern, Skater skirt, and a black silk blouse. The skirt ended an inch above her knee, flashing a hint of thigh as she walked. It was, it occurred to me, the skirt she’s been wearing when Jack had first insisted on seeing her panties. Her blouse was thin enough that her nipples jutted out prominently. Her face was still flushed and she kept her eyes averted from me.

“Is this better?” she asked Tommy.

He approached her and slid the back of his hand across her chest, trailing his fingertips over her nipples.

“Much better,” he replied.

He ran his hand up her neck and cupped her cheek. His thumb traced her lips. They locked eyes.

“Here, put your hands on that table,” he said after a moment.

She seemed puzzled for a moment, but he pushed her toward the kitchen table. She placed her palms on the surface. He pressed down on her lower back, making her slide her hands forward and bending her at the waist. She looked away from him, now staring straight ahead. She flinched slightly as he lifted up her skirt, exposing her bare bottom.

“Mmmm, now this is a gorgeous ass,” he said admiringly as he cupped first one cheek than the other.

He looked over at me and beckoned me over with a tilt of his head. I approached and stood beside him, watching him knead my wife's butt.

"Check the oil," he said.

I looked over at him. He gave me a quick encouraging nod. It felt weird approaching my wife, bent over a table, another man holding up her skirt to expose her naked ass. But everything had been weird since Rachel had first admitted her indiscretion.

I reached out and ran my hand up her inner thigh. She shivered slightly at my touch, but didn't object otherwise. Higher and higher I went, my fingertips trailing across her soft, warm skin. I could feel the heat, and then a surprising dampness on her thigh. When I reached her pussy I groaned in surprise. She was as wet as I'd ever felt her. My fingers slid easily between her slippery, puffy lips. She let out a soft sigh. Encouraged, I pressed my middle finger into her. She and I both gasped.

I lifted my eyes from her bottom and saw that she was looking at me, over her shoulder. She was even more flush, her eyes glassy. I easily pressed a second finger into her. Her eyelids fluttered before again locking her gaze on mine. I slowly pumped my fingers in and out of her drenched snatch, relishing the feel of her, lost in the enjoyment of her obvious excitement.

Tommy cleared his throat. I startled. I had almost forgotten about him being there. I looked over and he gave me a grin.

"Told you she'd like it," he said confidently.

I withdrew my hand, and absentmindedly rubbed my fingers together.

He released her skirt. She stood up and turned to face us, obviously a little shaky. She looked from Tommy to me and back again. She was obviously completely at our, well his, disposal. There was something unexplainably exciting about it. He'd primed her well, and then upon arrival

immediately asserted his control. And now she was a different woman, not my usual sarcastic, skeptical, independent wife, but rather a submissive little slut, ready and willing to please at his command.

The transformation was weird, disconcerting. It was like he'd hypnotized her somehow. And maybe he had, though I'd never heard of anyone doing such a thing via email. I still didn't have a clue how this would help me, however. But there was no denying that Rachel was enjoying, at some deep and primal level, surrendering to him. Was this how she'd been with Jack? With those other "inappropriate" men?

For a few moments, though it seemed longer, she just stared at him and I just stared at her. Then he laughed.

"God, you two are so serious."

She took a moment to process his statement, then broke into a smile of her own. I followed suit. The tension drained from the room. Not all of it. But enough to allow us to breath and speak. I smelled the chicken roasting in the oven.

"Would you like a drink before dinner?" I asked.

Tommy nodded, but answered at Rachel. "A beer?"

She nodded. "Um, sure."

He shot me a quick look. I got the message.

"Me too honey. And use the frosty mugs."

In normal circumstances she might have said, "get it yourself," but this time she merely spun on her heels and poured us each a beer, getting a glass of chardonnay for herself.

We moved into the living room. Tommy positioned himself on the sofa, leaving me the recliner. So when Rachel followed us in, she had no choice but to sit beside him. She was a little stiff, feeling awkward I guess. We both were. Only Tommy seemed comfortable, sitting back, with a big

grin. Of course, he'd just gotten his dick sucked, which tends to put guys in a good mood.

"Smells great," Tommy said. "What's for dinner?"

"Chicken," Rachel replied simply.

"Do you do all the cooking?"

"Yeah, pretty much. When we were both working..."

She trailed off as he put his hand on her knee. She took a breath and continued.

"...when we were both working, Max used to cook sometimes. You still like to cook, right honey?"

"I'm more into grilling," I replied.

Tommy was slowly caressing her knee, moving his hand under her skirt, his fingers trailing up her inner thigh.

"Man, I love to grill. Got myself a Traeger Smoker. You ever had a whole Tri-Tip, slow cooked?"

I wanted to reply. But it was incredibly hard to focus on the conversation. His fingers sliding higher up her thigh, taking her skirt up as well. Watching another man fondle my wife, knowing how excited she was already.

"I think he's having trouble concentrating," Rachel said with a grin. "I know I am."

"You guys never heard of multitasking?"

He pressed her skirt up even further and gently pulled her knee toward him, spreading her legs, exposing her. I could see her excitement, see her swollen, glistening pussy. His fingertips circling the perimeter of her labia.

"What are you going to do to me?" she said through deep breaths.

What do you want us to do to you? I thought.

“I haven’t decided yet,” was his, better, response. It wasn’t up to her. Not in this scenario.

“But I have some ideas,” he continued, stroking her thigh.

There was a beeping from the kitchen. Rachel was too distracted to react, which seemed to amuse Tommy.

“Should you be doing something about that?”

“Huh? What? Oh, yeah...”

She got up a little shakily and hurried into the kitchen.

I didn’t quite know what to say. Tommy started sharing some more grilling tips. I couldn’t tell if he was really that casual or just a master at feigning it. Either way, it was definitely disconcerting how easily this man had ingratiated himself into our lives, and even more so into our home.

“You haven’t heard a word I’ve said.”

“I’m sorry.”

He put his hand up. “No. Don’t. Don’t do that. Don’t fucking apologize to me. This is your fucking house. She’s your fucking wife. Never forget it. I’m your guest.”

I laughed. “Most of my guests don’t blow a load in my wife’s mouth... at least not within ten minutes of walking in.”

He chuckled, and then got serious again. “I’m not here to Dom you, Max. Keep that in mind. You’re the boss. You brought me here.”

“I know,” I replied, trying to project confidence.

“You’ll get it,” he replied reassuringly.

But I didn’t feel like the boss, like the master of my house. I had the safe word, but how did I know he’d obey it? Rachel and I had already shown that the rules were easily violated. And what if I used the safe word and he didn’t leave? Would Rachel side with me, or with him? I didn’t want to pursue that thought. I already knew. The girl who’d swallowing his load,

changed for him, and meekly proffered him drinks would not turn on him just because I'd named some absurd, what, desert animal?

Rachel summoned us to the table. She's not a great cook, but she plays to her strengths. Roasted chicken, garlic-fried potatoes, and mixed greens with a balsamic vinaigrette, a meal anyone can make, but that never fails to please. She'd picked out a bottle of Pinot Noir that went perfectly. Was it weird that I imagined her at the wine store asking the clerk to recommend a good bottle to entertain her husband and her new lover?

Tommy controlled the conversation, threading an impressive balance between banal, get-to-know-you topics, and periodic hints at the sexual nature of our weird relationship. Actually, his conversational skills were not that accomplished, but what was impressive was his casual confidence. I really still knew nothing about him, but I wished I did. Where did he come from? Who was he?

We finished dinner and Rachel served dessert, a cherry pie and port. As I finished my glass, Tommy looked over at me, eyebrows raised. *Still in?* I nodded before I even consciously processed his question. He didn't hesitate.

"That was a lovely meal, Rachel. You're almost as good a cook as you are a cocksucker."

She seemed a bit shocked, but only managed a quiet "thank you" in response.

He chuckled. "You haven't forgotten why we're here, have you?"

A flash of anger at his patronizing tone crossed her face. He regarded her placidly, and she backed down.

"No."

"No, what, Rachel, use your words."

Oh Jeez, he's pushing too hard. But he wasn't.

"You're here to make love to me."

He laughed. "I'm here to fuck."

She blushed and looked away.

"But first," he continued, "your husband has been amazingly patient. Why don't you go ahead and suck his cock."

She seemed rooted to the spot. I looked at Rachel, my face twisting into an apologetic and awkward grin.

He slapped his hand on the table, not violently, but enough to make a point. "That's twice, Rachel, you've disobeyed me."

She startled. "I'm sorry."

"You should be," he snapped. And then after another moment, "Don't make me tell you again."

She nodded and scuttled under the table. I fought the instinct to push her away, to hold her close, to tell her it was okay, that she didn't need to obey this foul invader into our home. But then she was on her knees, her hands fumbling with my zipper, and all I could think was getting my cock into her mouth.

I was rock hard, and it occurred to me that I'd been sporting at least a partial woody since Tommy rang the doorbell. My balls ached. What the fuck was wrong with me? She unzipped me, and I lifted myself off my seat to allow her to yank down my pants. She didn't hesitate. She swallowed me deep into her mouth.

"Oh God," I sighed.

Rachel sucked me hard. There was no teasing, no subtlety. She was like a junkie looking for her fix, eager to milk me as quickly as possible. I was already primed. Her deep, sloppy sucking feeding my excitement. I gasped, torn between the desire to slow her and make it last and my need to finish. My hunger won out. I thrust my hips, once, twice, and then came so hard that it almost hurt. She slurped on me wetly, swallowing my come,

sucking out every drop of my jism. It wasn't until I was completely drained that it occurred to me that her eagerness was less about pleasing me as it was about clearing the way for her next encounter with Tommy.

Rachel crawled up from under the table, a sheepish look on her face. Tommy smiled at her.

"Quite impressive, Rachel. I'd compliment you on your first experience with two cocks in one night, but I know it's not your first."

I saw her eyes widen and she shook her head slightly.

"Do you have something to say?"

She was pleading with him silently. But he just smiled.

"No," she replied.

"No, you have nothing to say? Or no, you've never had two cocks in one night."

"You know the answer," she snapped.

I gasped at the challenge. He seemed to brush it off, but somehow I knew she wasn't going to get away with not answering him directly.

He smiled sweetly. "Oh, yes, I almost forgot, what with the lovely dinner, and your impressive demonstration just now, but we need to deal with your violation of the rules."

She looked at him quizzically.

"There have to be consequences." He said simply. Then, "Put your hands on the table."

She hesitated.

"You're too smart to not understand the rules," he said.

She nodded and placed her palms on the table, as she had before, when he'd encouraged me to molest her. Again he pressed down on her lower back, flattening her across the surface. He again lifted her skirt, exposing her hard, little ass.

“It would be a shame to bruise this,” he said, trailing her fingertips across her bottom.

She shuddered at both his touch and the implicit threat.

“But we don’t have to,” he said.

She seemed to relax as he stepped away from her. He walked to the counter, opened some drawers. I could see her tempted to look back, resisting the urge. As he approached the stove, he grinned. He reached out and grabbed a long handled, well-worn wooden spoon. He held it low, down against his leg. He approached Rachel again. She seemed to shiver in anticipation of his touch.

“Tell Max about Cancun,” he said simply.

She looked back over her shoulder, first at him, then at me, but she didn’t speak.

WHACK!

He brought the spoon down on her right butt cheek.

“Ow!” she hissed.

WHACK!

Again, on precisely the same spot.

She gasped and reached back to protect herself, but he pressed down hard on her lower back forcing her hands back onto the table.

“Rachel, sweetie, you’re a delightful little cocksucker, but there is more in life than swallowing come.”

She glared back over her shoulder.

WHACK!

“Fuck!” she cried out, but turned away, seeming to realize that scowling at him would only bring more punishment.

He reached down and rubbed the spot he’d struck. She flinched and then relaxed as she realized he wasn’t going to strike her again, at least not

right away. It was mesmerizing to see him, this virtual stranger, massaging my wife's ass.

"If you do it right," he began, leaving no doubt he was doing it right, "it won't leave a bruise. But, every whack stimulates the nerve endings and makes every succeeding blow more painful. You may have noticed that already?"

When she didn't answer immediately, he struck her again.

WHACK!

"Yes, fuck, yes," she hissed.

"And yet, you continue to want to earn more?"

She looked back, confused.

"I told you to tell Max about Cancun."

She nodded. "Okay, okay, but no more."

WHACK!

"I'm not negotiating. Anyway, you've already failed to obey me three times. Five spanks each, and I've only given you six."

"Five," I corrected.

She glared back at me. He laughed.

WHACK!

"The other beauty of the spoon," he said, "is that it doesn't hurt me at all. I can go all night."

WHACK!

"Count them out," he ordered.

"Seven," she groaned.

"Very good, now, about Cancun."

She hesitated half a second too long.

WHACK!

"Eight! Okay, okay. I went on spring break."

WHACK!

“Nine! What?”

He laughed. “Don’t skimp on the details. You know what I want.”

She groaned

“Oh, God, it was junior year. I was seeing this guy, Danny, Danny Green.”

“Danny Danny Green is a funny name,” Tommy said.

“What? No, he was just Danny Green.”

WHACK!

“I know. I was making a joke,” he replied. Then after a moment. “And that one doesn’t count since you didn’t count it out.”

WHACK!

“Nine,” she groaned. “No, Ten,” she quickly corrected herself.

“Yes, ten, now please continue telling us your tale about Danny Danny Green.”

“We were dating. I’d met his folks over Christmas. He got upset when I told him I was going to Spring Break with my girlfriends.”

“Sounds like a smart young man not to trust you given what happened,” Tommy teased.

She didn’t answer right away.

“WHACK!”

“Eleven. No, yes, I don’t know. It annoyed me.”

“But you changed your plans anyway?”

She nodded. I awaited the blow, but apparently he accepted that as a response.

She continued, “He didn’t want to have any fun. He was a redhead, worried about being in the sun.”

“There was your first mistake,” I said interjected.

“He didn’t want to go out. He didn’t like it when guys looked at me. It was like being on vacation with my mom.”

She paused.

WHACK!

“Twelve,” she groaned.

Tommy caught me staring at her ass. He ran his fingertips over the spot he’d been targeting. It was a little red around the edges, but the skin in the middle was actually whiter than usual, and maybe slightly raised. He pressed down on it, like a button, and she winced. It was a neat little trick.

“Please continue.”

Another hesitation.

WHACK!

“Thir... thirteen.”

“I finally talked him into going to a club. It was loud, cramped. He kept whining that he wanted to go, he barely danced with me. Guys were sending drinks over to me, and he kept giving me the evil eye even though I was just sitting there. Finally, his complaining got to me, and I agreed to leave.

“We got out front and there was this long line for cabs. People were pairing up, sharing rides. He kept saying no, but when the next cab arrived, these two guys behind us didn’t take no for an answer. One guy climbed in the back and pulled me in after him, then his buddy crowded in too.

“The driver was impatient to get going, he waved Danny into the front seat, putting the cab in gear and threatening to roll whether he got in or not. He hopped in as the taxi drove off. He looked back, all angry, even more red-faced than usual.”

“The guys were laughing. ‘What’s the matter, don’t trust us with your girl?’ They were drunk and goofy, not at all threatening, but Danny was

playing Mr. Tough Guy, ‘You guys try anything...’ The driver drowned him out by turning up the radio. A sharp turn got Danny’s attention and he reached down and put on his seat belt in a panic. The guys next to me cracked up.”

“And you, sweet little Rachel? Did you defend your man?” Tommy asked.

Hesitation.

WHACK!

“No,” she said softly.

WHACK!

“What?”

WHACK!

“Oh, fuck, fifteen.”

Tommy laughed. “No, fourteen. But keep going.”

“No, I thought it was funny too. They asked me if he was always a baby. I said he was. I thought I was kidding around, but I was so pissed off at him that I wasn’t thinking. He got angry too. Not quite wheeling around he snapped at me, ‘You’re such a whore sometimes Rachel!’”

“It set me off even more. The guy on my left cracks, ‘Ooh, good, a whore, how much for a hummer?’”

I could see where the story was going, but it was still shocking to hear it. I could just picture her in a little sun dress, in the back of a swaying, rundown Mexican taxi, wedged in between two frat boy doofuses, all of them sweating from the club.

WHACK!

“Fifteen,” she moaned. “I said, ‘I’ll do it for free.’ I thought it was like a joke or something, but it went all quiet. Then Danny goes, ‘I bet you would, you bitch.’ I swear, I wouldn’t have done it if he hadn’t said that.”

Tommy laughed. "You sure about that, Rachel? Really sure?"

"I dunno," she admitted.

WHACK!

"Owww! Sixteen. I thought we were done with those."

"You earned fifteen... and Max earned another five for you. So you still have a few to go. Any protests?"

"No... sir," she replied.

WHACK!

"Seventeen," she hissed.

"I don't know if you were trying to mock me just then, but don't call me sir. I work for a living."

"Sorry," she answered in a small voice.

He raised the spoon but stayed his blow as she resumed her story.

"I sucked them off. Both of them. First the one on my left, then the one on my right."

WHACK!

"Eighteen."

"Details please."

"God, I don't know. It was quick. They were horny young guys. They whipped 'em out, I took it in my mouth, jerked him with my thumb and index finger, and then took care of the other one."

"Did they feel you up?"

"No. I did all the work."

Tommy laughed. "You blew two guys and didn't even get finger-banged for the effort."

She chuckled. "Yeah."

"What else?"

She shook her head. "I don't..."

WHACK!

“Nineteen,” she sighed.

“Okay, okay, the main thing I remember is Danny in the front seat going, ‘Oh, my God, oh my God,’ over and over and the driver laughing like a lunatic. And then, oh yeah, Danny had to pay the fare.”

“I’m guessing things were tense with you two after?” Tommy asked.

“We didn’t talk. I went to the room and got my shit. I had some other friends in town, so I crashed with them in their moldy room.”

“You must have gotten quite the reputation.”

“No. I didn’t tell anyone, and neither did Danny. We just, um, broke up.”

“So I guess, he was right about you after all?”

“What?”

“You were a whore.”

No response.

WHACK!

“Twenty! Yes. Yes, I was a whore.”

“Was? Or are?”

“I don’t know. Both?”

He laughed and waved me over. He gestured toward her ass and I ran my hand over her butt. She was trembling as if from cold, but when I slid my hand down between her legs, I could feel her heat and wetness. I slipped a finger inside her. She was soaked. Was it from being exposed? From remembering the story? From telling it? Did she get off on being beaten?

I cupped her ass with my other hand, feeling the spot that he’d struck. It was swollen and hot to the touch. As I gave the spot a little pressure, she flinched and her pussy clenched around my finger. I couldn’t help myself, I

gave another quick push on the spot and got another firm squeeze on my digit.

“Fun, isn’t it?” Tommy interrupted.

I nodded, unable to take my eyes off my heaving, exposed wife.

“But now, I need to some relief of my own,” Tommy said. “This isn’t just exciting for the two of you.”

He reached down and took Rachel’s hand and stood her up. She was red faced and trembling, strands of hair matted to her forehead with sweat. She already looked well-fucked

“You’re welcome to watch if you’d like,” he said to me. “But give us a few minutes to get started.”

I looked for a tell. Was I supposed to tell him off? Was that the game? Getting me to assert myself. I couldn’t be sure. Somehow that didn’t feel right. I thought back to that old movie I’d seen in Germany. The game there seemed to be to hand the woman off to another man, that if she was willing to accept being given to another man, she was actually surrendering herself even more completely.

I wished Tommy had filled me in, but I also thought back to his statement that there were no rules, no simple answers, that it was about being able to read the situation.

I stepped back. “Have fun.”

Rachel’s eyes went wide and Tommy nodded. Had I made the right choice? I didn’t know. All I knew was that Tommy, this stranger I’d met on the Internet, was right now taking my wife upstairs to our bedroom.

He’d asked for a couple of minutes. Was that two? More? Was it just a nice way to tell me to butt out? I chuckled to myself. I kept complaining about lack of guidance and then when he gave some, I couldn’t figure out whether to follow it.

And then I thought about Rachel. It was embarrassing to realize how little I'd really thought about *her*, and her feelings, this whole evening. Was she angry at me about inviting in Tommy? Was she just going upstairs to spite me as she had Danny Danny Green? No. She had the safe word too. She was a willing participant. And I realized, perhaps more clearly than she did, that she'd been a willing participant in the cab. She wasn't angry at Danny Danny. She was probably grateful he'd given her the excuse to cut loose. If those guys had bothered to finger her, they'd have found her as wet as I just had. And so we were back to square one. Being treated like a whore got Rachel hot and bothered, but I still didn't know how to do it. I didn't have Tommy's instincts. If it were up to me, I'd still be hesitating over the whack, debating whether it should be hard or soft, whether her shuddering meant it had been too much or too little.

I glanced at the stairs. It had been at least two minutes. I decided to check it out. I climbed to the landing. The bedroom door was open, the lights on, Rachel was grunting and groaning, Tommy muttering encouragement.

I wasn't shocked by what I saw, it was what I expected, but I was surprised by how erotic I found it. He was lying back on the bed, and she was riding him, reverse cowgirl. She was on her knees, her perfect ass rising and falling rhythmically on his fat prick. He was massaging her ass gently, his thumb resting on her pale welt, pressing on it periodically in a way that made her shudder and drop down on him raggedly.

He had his phone out, periodically documenting the encounter.

She was obviously very, very excited. His cock glistened with her wetness, each thrust squishing wetly. She was also louder than usual, moaning and gasping in a way made it seem as if she were just transitioning from one orgasm to the next.

Tommy noticed me standing in the doorway. Without acknowledging me directly, he began thrusting upward into my wife, who reacted with undisguised pleasure.

“Oh God,” she sighed. “Oh God.”

“Give me a show,” he ordered. “Spread your ass.”

She hesitated and he gave her a quick spank on her sore spot. She whined, but obeyed him, reaching back with both hands, pulling her cheeks apart giving a perfect view of his cock churning into her hot, wet box, her tiny asshole puckering with each thrust.

“That’s it Rachel, now finger your ass.”

Another hesitation, another spank.

“Owwww!” she whined.

Spank!

“Okay, okay,” she moaned, now releasing one hard little cheek and bringing her finger to her mouth.

“Do it,” he hissed.

She obeyed, sliding her manicured finger down her crack, tickling her anus. With a gasp she pushed it in, throwing her head back as she did, settling down onto his prick.

Spank!

“Don’t stop moving.”

She nodded and resuming riding him, now more erratically, less controlled.

“That’s it doll, here it comes,”

He grabbed her hips and thrust upward powerfully. She gasped and whined and when she felt him come inside her, she sighed with satisfaction. He thrust a few more times as she relaxed, first slowing her movements, then falling forward face-down onto the bed. As his cock popped out I was

treated to the sight of my wife's pussy, red, and swollen, gaping open until it closed with a series of pulses.

The moment they finished I began to feel like an intruder on the scene. I ducked away, slipping back downstairs, unsure what to do next. Was I supposed to join them? Take my turn with her? None of this made sense. But there was one thing I had to admit. Rachel had well and truly enjoyed herself.

Tommy joined me downstairs a few minutes later.

"You okay bud?"

"I guess. I don't know. What was I supposed to do?"

"What do you think you were supposed to do?"

I shook my head. "Fuck Tommy, I don't know."

He laughed. "Relax. You did great."

"So what happens now? You keep coming by and fucking my wife?"

"There are worse scenarios."

I nodded. He was right. If she did have a periodic craving for some rough trade, maybe this was the best option, at least this was in my control. Sort of.

He rolled his eyes.

"Yes, Max, I will probably have sex with your wife again. No, this isn't a new lifestyle. Do you trust me?"

"Yes," I replied, though I was feeling much less certain than my words.

"I wish I just understood the plan better."

"You will," he replied. "You will."

CHAPTER NINETEEN

After Tommy left, I climbed the stairs with trepidation. I wasn't sure what to expect. I considered a whole range of potential responses from Rachel. Would she be angry that I put her into this situation? Ashamed at her conduct? Grateful that I'd let her get properly fucked? Horny and wanting more? Contemptuous that I had let another man into our house and our bedroom?

Not only did I not know how she would respond, I didn't know how I wanted her to respond. In the time I walked up the stairs, my opinions changed. Would it be good if she'd enjoyed her time with Tommy? Or bad? Was this supposed to be aversion therapy or desensitization? And why was Tommy keeping me in the dark?

The unpleasant thought returned. I was just a sucker. Tommy was just an Internet huckster, an online predatory. I'd walked into his trap, given him everything he could have dreamed of. He even had pictures of Rachel naked and now sucking his cock, fucking him. He knew our address, our names. I sat down on the top step, my heart pounding a mile a minute. Her affair had thrown me so far off balance that I lost all common sense, all perspective. And now this man owned us. He could blackmail us into anything. Anything.

We'd need to move, change our names. Or maybe not. Maybe all he wanted was what he was already getting, a pliant and submissive Rachel to use for his amusement. Could I live with that? Did my opinion even matter?

She'd loved it. There was no denying it. Feeling her wetness after her beating, seeing her ride him so sensuously. Whatever Tommy was or wasn't, he had a way with women, or at least my wife. She'd probably

welcome being blackmailed, forced to engage in ever more tawdry and debased acts, excusing herself and blaming me all the while. Maybe she'd even set it up. Had she know Tommy from before? Was he one of her regular fucks?

No, I was losing it. Who wouldn't though? Just because my mental anguish was understandable, it didn't make my paranoid fears real. And yet.

"Are you okay?"

Rachel was standing above me, freshly showered and wrapped in her heavy, spa bathrobe. I laughed. It made her look like a yeti, but she loved the damn thing, so soft and warm. It had taken me forever to find it. I finally broke down and ordered it from the resort spa where we'd first seen it. \$250 for a bathrobe.

"Are you okay?" she repeated, a little more concern in her voice.

Damn, that was one thing that had to end. As painful as it was to watch her blow Tommy and to watch Tommy fuck her, I think the most annoying thing was how solicitous they both were of me.

"Are you?" I asked

She was a little taken aback. She seemed to have taken it for granted that she was all right, that I was the one who needed reassurance.

"Yeah?" she replied uncertainly. *I think I'm all right, should I not be?*

I laughed. She stared at me like I was crazy.

"A man came into our house. He ordered you to perform oral sex. He beat you with a wooden spoon while commanding you to share your deep, dark secrets. Then he screwed you in our marital bed while ordering you to finger your own ass. You can see why I might ask if you're okay, right?"

She sat down beside me.

"A man came into our house. He ordered your wife to perform oral sex. He beat her with a wooden spoon while forcing her to divulge deep,

dark, *embarrassing* secrets. Then he took her upstairs and had sex with her in your bed. You can see why I might ask if you're okay, right?"

I laughed. "I'm okay. I don't understand any of it, but I'm okay."

She nodded. "Same here."

"What do you see in him?"

"What do you?" she replied.

"I think I may see something different than you do. But, okay, I'll go first. I like him. He's open, honest, direct, insightful. He makes me feel like I'm not alone in dealing with... whatever we're dealing with. You?"

She hesitated.

"Come on, Rach, this is one of those things we need to communicate about."

She nodded. "He scares me —"

Seeing the look of alarm on my face, she quickly continued, "but in a good way. He scares me because he seems to know me, even beyond what you may have told him. He sees through me, through the construct of Rachel, nice Jewish girl and mother, overeducated, underemployed quant. He sees me for the real me."

The real Rachel. A slut for inappropriate men. A whore who gets wet when ordered to blow a near stranger. A tramp who gets off on getting punished and spreading her ass cheeks so her man can watch his cock plowing into her wet hole.

"Do you really feel that way? That's the *real* you?"

She nodded. "You know it is. I'm sorry. But I'm a fraud."

Except, she wasn't. She was a nice Jewish girl, even if she hadn't seen the inside of a synagogue in twenty years. She was a wonderful, sometimes even over-attentive mother. She was talented enough to get into HBS, and smart enough to explain Black-Scholes to me.

“I could beat you with a spoon,” I said.

But we both laughed. That was the problem. Still the same fucking problem. I knew what she wanted, what she needed, but we’d both done such a good job compartmentalizing things that we couldn’t do it together.

I took her by the hand. “Come to bed, honey. We have the house to ourselves.”

“I need to change the sheets,” she said.

“No, we’re going to make love in your wet spot.”

She scrunched up her nose, but didn’t object as I led her to bed. And happily, there was no wet spot. The line had been pure bravado on my part.

We climbed into bed naked and lay side-by-side. We kissed, gently at first.

“Why don’t you hate me?” she asked.

“Because I love you. I love you when you’re happy and when you’re angry.”

We kissed again, more firmly. I let my hands roam over her lithe body, trailing my fingertips down between her breasts and over her belly. She ran her hands through my hair.

“I love you when you’re relaxed and when you’re stressed.”

I reached down and cupped her ass, circling the swollen mound where he’d beat her. She shivered in anticipation, but I didn’t press down.

“I love you when you’re sane and when you’re crazy. I seem to remember some vows to that effect.”

“Forsaking all others,” she breathed as we kissed wetly.

“I told you we needed to have our lawyers review the language. Should have had a precedence clause in the vows.”

She giggled.

I pulled her close. Her hand went between us to stroke my erection. My fingers edged between her legs from behind, feeling her heat and wetness. My digits sank into her easily. She gasped and threw her leg over me.

“Are you thinking of me or of him?” I asked, two fingers plunging inside her.

He’d come inside her. Was I feeling that or was it all her?

“Both,” she sighed.

“Same,” I replied. “It was hot watching him fuck you.”

“You watched?” she gasped.

It hadn’t occurred to me that she might not have realized. Her pussy seemed to get even more soaked.

“All of it?”

She began to thrust against me, seemingly trying to get my cock inside her.

“I saw you ride him. Saw you open yourself for him. Saw him come inside you.”

“Oh God,” she moaned.

She tried to roll on top of me, but it was important for some reason for me to be on top. We wrestled a little, and then she seemed to surrender. I spun her onto her back and settled between her legs. She pulled at my cock, pressing it against her hot, sticky snatch. I would have liked to tease her, but I couldn’t resist. I buried myself inside her.

“Mmmm, that’s nice,” I said, relishing the feel of her heat. She was still nice and tight, even though I’d seen how thoroughly stretched out she had been by his big cock. It is a feminine miracle that no matter how many men a woman’s had, it still feels perfect when you thrust inside.

She wrapped her legs around my waist, at once opening herself wide and at the same time pulling me close. I attacked her neck, sucking, licking. She gasped open mouthed. I nibbled on her ear lobe.

“He fucked you right here,” I breathed.

“I know.”

“Right in our bed. You had another man’s cock inside you.”

“Yesssss,” she hissed.

I felt her pussy spasm on my prick. As she crested, I felt her tense. I looked at her anxious expression.

“I love you,” I reassured her, ramming her hard, another form of reassurance.

“I love you,” she replied. “I love you, Max.”

“I love you,” I said again, hammering her hard, over and over until I felt my body tense and then euphoria as I came inside her.

I rolled off her, breathing hard. “Well, that’s a new one for you,” I said. “You’ve sucked off two guys in one night before, but this is the first time you’ve fucked two guys in the same night.”

She laughed. “You’re weird, Max.”

“See, we both have our flaws.”

CHAPTER TWENTY

We had both enjoyed the evening with Tommy. Rachel's guilt kept kicking in, and I kept reassuring her. I didn't know if that was the right approach. I didn't want to turn the illicit into the licit, lest it lose the thrill. But at the same time, I couldn't let her beat up on herself.

I asked Tommy for advice, but he was on radio silence all of a sudden. He was also not responding to Rachel. There was one absurd evening where the two of us sat together wondering if somehow we'd offended him. I was getting pissed off. What was wrong with the guy if he didn't want to stay in touch and maybe screw my wife again? Rachel was having similarly weird thoughts.

After four days he began returning emails.

—We're still good.

—Where've you been?

—You needed time to digest it. How did it go after I left?

—Great. We've been bonding over feeling dumped by you.

—I like you guys. I will definitely miss you both when it is time to move on.

I puzzled over that one. One of my worries had been that he wouldn't move on, that we were stuck with him. And yet, I didn't want to not be stuck with him. I liked having him in our lives, even the part where he came over and screwed my wife.

—Tell me the plan.

–That’s not how it works. I told you, there is no set of rules, no roadmap.

–But you said you would move on.

That’s not a plan. That’s an outcome. You don’t want me to be forever in your lives, do you?

I wrote back that I didn’t. I tried to get him to explain things, but he wouldn’t, not in any detail. So we kept writing, him even more with Rachel, though I kept my promise not to pry.

Rachel and I seesawed. Most days were good. Somehow that weird sense of having to act normal dissipated, dispersing that particular oppressiveness. I’m not sure we were at the point of letting our freak flags fly, but we weren’t desperately trying to hide them either.

At the same time, I didn’t feel like the passions of that evening with Tommy were still accessible. When we’d first climbed into bed after he left, it seemed oddly natural to invoke his presence to excite her. As every day passed, that seemed harder and harder to do, the passion more and more distant, the strangeness of it more and more palpable. After a couple of weeks, mentioning that Tommy had been in our bed seemed as alien as suddenly confessing a fetish for scat play.

It was almost a relief when, after three weeks, Tommy announced his interest in a new get-together. I didn’t know if he’d mentioned it to Rachel, so I didn’t dare raise it. She felt the same way, leading to a daylong Kabuki where we both traded hints hoping to elicit the other’s support.

I finally broke down, “So did Tommy mention next week?”

She sighed in relief, but answered, “We don’t have to.”

I laughed. Of course we didn't *have* to, but I wondered about the weird game we were playing where we pretended it might not happen, where we acted as if it were not a foregone conclusion we'd invite him to again join us. Not for the first time, I bemoaned our inability to be honest and communicate fully. In a strange way, that seemed more ominous to me than the fact that Rachel periodically wanted or needed to be fucked by a rough stranger. Good grief, what was wrong with me?

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

As before, we'd shipped off the kids to my folks. Rachel had learned from before and was wearing a short wrap-dress, high heels, and nothing else. We'd sat together and planned the outfit, and I watched as she draped it on, watching the fabric cling to her curves, knowing she was wearing nothing underneath. We joked about him using the spoon, though we actually hadn't seen it since his last visit.

But Tommy's arrival was anything but what we'd expected. He didn't come alone.

His partner was a woman, Donna, probably in her early thirties. He hadn't mentioned to me that he was bringing a guest, and from Rachel's reaction she was blindsided as well. But to me it was a pleasant surprise. Donna was a cutie, her straight blown hair in a bob with bangs, heavy mascara applied to bring out her big, blue eyes. She was wearing a black scoop neck tee, exposing her generous cleavage, and tight skinny jeans that left little to the imagination.

Knowing the nature of the relationship, I knew that before too long either I'd be fucking her, or Rachel would, or Tommy would. I was okay with all of those. Looking at Rachel, I could see her making the same analysis, but coming to the opposite conclusion.

Tommy introduced the two women, "How about a little kiss?"

Donna leaned in and tried to give my wife a kiss, but Rachel flinched and backed away at the last second. Donna grinned evilly.

"You're right, Donna," Tommy said reading her expression, "It looks like she'd rather feel the spoon than a pair of soft lips. Let's try that again," he insisted.

Donna again leaned in close and this time, Rachel successfully fought the urge to withdraw. The kiss itself was almost anticlimactic, just a little peck on the lips, but with the promise of more implicit in it.

As they broke contact, I noticed Rachel looking down. I realized this was not going as she'd planned or maybe hoped. She'd have been happier with a repeat of our last encounter, a little light domination, some sexy talk, a good fucking. Now she was uncertain, unsure where this might go.

"Would you like something to drink?" I offered.

As before, Tommy replied looking at Rachel. "Beer for me. Wine, white if you have it, for Donna."

He glanced over at me. "Uh, beer for me too."

Rachel nodded and poured the drinks as I led Donna over to the family room to sit. Our house is laid out with the back half open into a single great room comprising the kitchen, dining area, and family room, so we could all see and hear each other even though Tommy remained back in the kitchen with Rachel. Rachel brought us the drinks, giving me a hard glare. I raised my eyebrow questioningly. What was her problem? She could, like me, call an end to this whenever she wanted.

I looked over at Donna, smiling at me with disconcerting frankness. She, at least, knew what was up and was clearly game for anything. Knowing I would soon be seeing this strange, and very attractive, woman in a sexual situation made it hard for me to speak. I noticed her wedding band.

"Where is your husband?"

She laughed softly, "Back home where we left him, right Tommy?"

Tommy chuckled. "Unless he managed to untie himself."

I looked from one to the other. Were they joking? Is that what he had in mind for me? Was that where this was leading, Rachel inducted into

Tommy's harem, taken away from me periodically for fun games while I remained behind? I didn't like that idea. I felt myself flush with anger.

Over in the kitchen, Tommy was hovering close to my wife. "Oh, come on Rachel, you really expect me to believe you've never been with another woman."

She shook her head briskly.

"Not even a little kissy-kissy on the dance floor for attention."

"No. It's... not my scene."

He laughed. "No, I guess it isn't. No real ambiguity when you decide to play. You just walk up to a guy and breathe hard until he takes the hint."

She shook her head, but didn't respond. What was she going to say? That was basically how she'd described it herself. She glanced over at Donna, apparently embarrassed more than anything else that this stranger was hearing her predilections.

Donna was clearly amused by all of this. She drained her wine and then went into the kitchen for a refill, making sure to brush against Rachel as she did, who jolted as if scalded. I adjusted my pants. The thought of Donna and my wife, naked, making out or more was indeed scalding. But again, I had my doubts. How was this contributing to... to whatever the fuck we were doing?

We sat down to dinner, Tommy filling in Donna on his last visit. Rachel continued to blush red. When he got to the part where she'd fingered her own butt, Rachel finally broke down.

"Do we need to do this?" she said, rising and clearing away the dishes.

"You're not ashamed, are you?" he asked, amused.

"No. Just embarrassed to share it with... her. I didn't know we'd be having guests," she replied as she began to fill the dishwasher.

Donna put her hand to her heart and feigned taking offense.

“But Donna is central to our plans this evening.”

Rachel stood upright and shook her head. “I told you, I... that’s not my scene.”

“But you’ll do it if I tell you to, won’t you?”

“I don’t know,” my wife replied softly.

Donna’s eyes flashed with excitement.

Tommy stood and walked behind Rachel, resting his strong hands on her shoulders. “Rachel, Rachel, Rachel, how you disappoint me.”

He ran his hands down her sides and cupped her ass through her dress, his thumb rubbing the spot where he’d beaten her the last time. She flinched.

“Has it healed completely?”

She opened her mouth to answer, but he didn’t give her the chance.

“Let’s take a look,” he said as he firmly bent her over the table. He lifted up her dress and exposed her hard ass. His fingers found the right spot and pressed. She flinched, but didn’t gasp. “I think you need a reminder,” he said giving her ass a firm whack with his palm.

He looked over at Donna. “Hey, beautiful, why don’t you take Max back into the living room and keep him entertained while I, um, discuss things with Rachel.”

I looked down at my wife, bent over the table, her ass in the air. She was giving me a boner-shriveling glare.

Donna cleared her throat and when I looked over, she casually lifted off her tee shirt, exposing her big, firm boobs. She kicked off her pumps and as I watched, mesmerized, she shimmied out of her jeans, setting those heavy tits jiggling. Standing there in bare feet, naked, fully shaved, she was a small slice of heaven, a compact package, at most 5’2” and all tits and ass.

WHACK!

I looked behind me to see Tommy wielding the spoon against my wife's shapely bottom. Where had that fucking thing come from?

WHACK!

"Oww," she whined.

"You forgot to count."

WHACK!

"One," she hissed.

Donna seized my hand and with surprising strength she hauled me into the living room, not that I was planning to resist despite Rachel's angry stare.

Tommy continued to spank my wife's ass. She continued to scowl at me. But I was barely paying attention because Donna had wrenched down my pants, shoved me onto the sofa, and was presently bobbing up and down on my hard prick.

I tried to imagine the scene now. Was Tommy trying to show Rachel how much pain she'd caused me when she'd cheated? I couldn't imagine him pursuing such a prosaic and obvious approach.

He gave her another nine strokes. The last few sounded particularly hard, with the spoon whipping audibly through the air before exploding on my wife's ass. She cried out plaintively, and I had to remind myself that she could deploy the safe word whenever she wanted.

She was shaking and shivering when he finished. Donna had crawled up on the sofa beside me, and I was caressing her ass as she sucked me. My hand ran across the ornate compass rose she had tattooed above her crack. Tommy was mirroring my actions with my wife's ass.

"Do you like watching another girl blow your man?" Tommy taunted.

"No," Rachel replied curtly.

"Some would call you a selfish bitch."

She tried to rise. He shoved her back down onto the table. “I didn’t tell you to get up.”

WHACK!

“Eleven,” she whined.

“You could learn a thing or two from Donna,” he teased.

Donna looked up from sucking my cock and gave Rachel a sickly sweet smile. Rachel gave her the finger.

WHACK!

“Twelve,” Rachel cried out, but I could tell she’d considered that one well worth it.

“Give those titties a good squeeze,” Tommy suggested. “You probably haven’t gotten your hands on some hangers in a long time.”

I nodded, ignoring Rachel’s displeasure. I reached down and cupped Donna’s big tits, feeling her long nipple slipping through my fingers. She moaned around my cock and I squeezed her tits more roughly. Her hands began massaging my balls, her tongue swirling around my cock.

I realized too late how far along I was. “Oh God,” I groaned by way of warning. Donna sucked harder, giving me no choice. I came hard, filling her mouth with jism.

The moment I was done, she rose off me. I groaned in disappointment. I would have loved to get soft and then stiffen again in her mouth. But it was still a treat to see her bubble butt swaying seductively as she walked back toward the kitchen.

I saw Rachel’s eyes widen in sudden understanding.

“Time for another kiss,” Tommy ordered.

“No,” Rachel shook her head, “no.”

WHACK! WHACK! WHACK!

“Thirteen! Fourteen! Fifteen,” Rachel called out instinctively.

“I can do this all night,” Tommy warned.

Donna lowered her head toward my wife. Slowly, grudgingly Rachel turned her head to the side. The little brunette dipped lower, flashing me a shot of her swollen cunt. Their faces approached, slowly, slowly, and then suddenly Donna lunged out and seized the back of Rachel’s head and kissed her hard, her tongue forcing its way into my wife’s mouth, a mix of spit and cum dripping from their linked mouths.

Just as quickly, Donna broke the embrace and Rachel looked around, at Donna, at Tommy, and at me with a dazed look in her eyes. And then suddenly her eyes fluttered and I saw Tommy’s hand churning between her legs, plunging wetly into her soaked pussy.

He looked up at Donna. “Go get cleaned up,” he said as he continued to molest my wife’s twat. I watched the little brunette disappear up the stairs. I realized with an excited shudder that our evening had only just begun.

I had sort of expected Tommy to screw Rachel bent over the table. I’m not sure I could have resisted it, nor would I have begrudged him had he done it. But he didn’t. After another few minutes of churning his fingers into her wet pussy, he pulled away, eliciting a disappointed sigh from my wife. Was it weird that I found her disappointment at not getting fucked more difficult to handle than the reality of her being with another man? A weird psychological dynamic, but no less real for its unexpectedness.

Rachel pulled herself together, casting anxious glances upstairs at where the interloper had disappeared. We opened another bottle of wine and settled down in the living room. As before, Tommy positioned himself on the sofa, and Rachel sat next to him. And as before, his hand immediately

went to her knees and began to caress her thigh. Tommy managed the down time with easy, manly banter. This time he talked about a sailboat he was thinking about buying.

Donna wasn't gone long. But when she returned she was wrapped in Rachel's favorite bathrobe. *Oh, fuck, \$250 down the drain.* No way would Rachel ever wear that thing again. The annoyed look on Rachel's face seemed to confirm as much. I stopped thinking about it when Donna sat down in my lap on the recliner.

"Do you two ever fuck on this?" Donna asked matter-of-factly.

"No," I replied, realizing that was likely to change momentarily.

Tommy's easy fondling of my wife encouraged me to slip my hand inside the bathrobe. I'd done that many times, of course, with Rachel, but delighted in the sensation of another woman's body in there. Donna's body was so warm and inviting, soft and curvy. It occurred to me that I might be willing to share Rachel if it meant that I could have sex with Donna on a regular basis. So was *that* the game? Did Donna even have another husband tied up somewhere, or was she married to Tommy? Had we just been recruited into a swinger cult?

Tommy pulled Rachel's dress up further, until it bunched around her waist. She pressed her legs together modestly. He gave her a quick rap on a thigh, a reminder that the spoon was in easy reach if she continued to resist. She sighed and allowed him to spread her legs wide. After his fondling, I wasn't surprised to see that her pussy was puffy, spread, and very wet, but it was still a bewitching sight. Donna seemed to think so as well.

"That's a pretty pussy," she cooed.

Rachel seemed torn between embarrassment and pride. "Thank you," she said in a small voice.

"Do you want to eat it?" Tommy asked.

Donna nodded her head eagerly.

“No,” said Rachel, but without much conviction as the brunette approached on her hands and knees.

“Don’t worry, you’ll be busy,” Tommy reassured her as he pulled her head into his lap.

He’d unzipped his pants and his big cock stood up, hard and proud. Rachel seemed weirdly grateful for the distraction. She lowered her mouth onto his fat prick even as Donna spread her legs wider and pushed her face against my wife’s twat. Rachel gasped in pleasure around Tommy’s cock. He seized a thick handful of her hair and forced his tool deeper into her mouth. Donna lapped loudly at Rachel’s snatch. My wife jerked in passion.

Tommy looked over at me. “Jesus man, we’ve got two wet sluts here, and you’re jerking it?”

I looked down in my lap and noticed that I was, indeed, playing with my own cock.

Donna looked back over her shoulder, her face glazed with my wife’s juices. She flashed me a saucy smile and then lifted up my wife’s bathrobe, flipping it over her ass. I seized on the invitation eagerly, crawling up behind her and rubbing my cock against her wet gash. She moaned softly and I plunged my cock into her tight little hole.

“You can put it in her ass,” Tommy suggested.

I didn’t want to. What I was doing felt too good. But it also gave me a weird jolt. How long until he was telling another man to do that to my own wife? Right now, I was thinking with my dick, and right now, there was no place I’d rather be than plugging one hot slut as she ate out my wife who was, in turn, sucking another man’s cock. But this wasn’t occurring in a vacuum, and I didn’t know what came next.

As I played through my doubts, I must have slowed because suddenly I felt Donna thrusting back against me. God, she was a little minx, fucking back against me even as she ate my wife's pussy so effectively that Rachel's moans were audible even around Tommy's cock. I reached down and mauled Donna's fat tits, squeezing them harder than I would have dared Rachel's sensitive little nubs. Donna growled and hammered against me.

I came before I realized it, spurt after spurt disappearing inside the little brunette. When I was done, I fell backward first onto my heels, and then scrambled back into my recliner.

When he realized I was done, Tommy rearranged the girls. He put Donna on her back, naked and sprawled across Rachel's robe, then he maneuvered Rachel onto Donna's face facing her feet as she the brunette resumed her assault on my wife's snatch. Then finally he climbed between Donna's legs and hammered his cock into her sloppy cunt. Rachel was facing me as she sat on Donna's face. She was writhing in passion, her eyes closed, her hands roaming across her own body, caressing her tits, rubbing her belly.

Tommy was fucking Donna hard, his fat tool squishing into her wetly. He was giving it to her hard enough that she seemed to be losing focus on her other job. Rachel began to grind against her face more vigorously. Tommy sensed Rachel's mounting frustration, seemed to recognize her growing hunger.

He rose on his knees suddenly and withdrew his prick from Donna's grasping cunt. He pulled Rachel forward, so that she fell between Donna's legs, her face now inches from both his wet cock and the brunette's pulsing cunt. Rachel swallowing Tommy's prick into her mouth, a lifeline of sorts. She understood full well what was expected of her, but seemed to feel that if she only blew him eagerly enough, he'd give up on his other goal.

I let out a soft chuckle. Tommy gave me a knowing glance. *Don't worry, she won't get away with it.* Even Rachel seemed resigned as he slowly eased his cock from her hungry mouth. She looked up at Tommy, her eyes pleading with him. But he just edged back, pushing her head down between the brunette's legs.

Tentatively, Rachel reached out with her tongue and flicked at Donna's pussy. At the other end, I could hear Donna eagerly slurping my own wife's pussy. I knew the disparity in eagerness wouldn't hold. As Donna continued to service Rachel, my wife became increasingly enthusiastic in her own tongue lashing. Tommy was there to help, spreading Donna's labia wide so my wife could lick the other woman deep.

Rachel was moaning louder and louder. I was tempted to maneuver around to the other side to see Donna's tongue working my wife's snatch, but my angle was too erotic to quit. Once Tommy was sure that Rachel was committed, he got back into the game. A few quick thrusts into Donna's pussy, then a few into my wife's eager mouth, then back on his heels to watch Rachel eat out the other woman.

They got into an impressive rhythm, the three of them writhing together. Then suddenly Rachel let out a long, low gasp. Tommy, realizing what was happening, thrust hard into Donna who started bucking in passion. Then Tommy gasped and pulled out, firing several thick gobs of come all over my wife's face and Donna's twat. And then, as he sat back down on his ankles, Rachel again buried her face between Donna's legs licking up as much of Tommy's come as she could reach. Sitting back in the recliner, I felt a rush of heat in my lap and I came yet again, not even realizing I'd been touching myself.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Tommy and Donna left soon after. I was sort of disappointed. I'd have been interested in letting them spend the night, seeing what other combinations of bodies they might come up with. But Donna was insistent. They had to untie her husband, and she, as she hinted lewdly, needed to report back what she'd done.

Rachel and I showered and met back in bed. Much to my chagrin, but not my surprise, Rachel's fluffy bathrobe had been thrown aside, avoided like so much toxic waste.

"What are we doing?" she asked.

I shrugged. "I don't know. But it was fun."

"Are we swingers?"

"I don't know."

"Max, how much of this are you authoring?"

"Basically none. I'm just along for the ride, I guess."

"I don't want to be a swinger," she said.

And I don't want to be a cuckold. "We can stop it –"

"Yeah, aardvark. Why aren't you saying it?"

"Why aren't you?"

"Fuck Max, we keep going round and round. Is this how you see our lives?"

"Apparently you don't." She gave me a dangerous glare. "Okay, no I hadn't. I would never –"

She sighed. "We're grown-ups. We have choices. I made a mistake. Now it seems like a ratchet. Instead of getting back to where we were, we're spiraling into this... this abyss."

I wasn't sure I'd quite describe our evening as a visit to an abyss. And pressed on it, I doubted Rachel would either. But she was right. Things were out of control.

"Do you think Tommy is dangerous?"

She rolled her eyes. "Well, of course he is. I don't mean, like, bludgeon-us-to-death dangerous, but definitely dangerous to our relationship."

"How so?"

"Max, please."

"No, seriously. Because, I'm not sure we see the same dangers."

She sighed. "He makes me do things... feel like..."

"Like you feel when you're with an 'inappropriate man.' At once embarrassed and reckless and very turned on?"

"Something like that.... But Max, he doesn't feel that inappropriate. That's what scares me."

"Are you falling in love with him?"

"No," she replied too quickly. Then, "I don't know. But he's addictive."

I nodded. Was this how things had begun with him and Donna? Had he been *helping* them as well, only to see it turn into Tommy and Donna having adventures and then reporting back to her pathetic husband?

"What are you really afraid of?" I asked.

She bit her lip and looked away. "I don't want to hurt you."

I was suddenly tired of dancing around the truth. "Too late, Rach. Too late. And frankly... and frankly..." I stammered as I formulated my thoughts. "Frankly, I don't want to be a guy you settle for, who never really gets your heart rate up. And that's what you're telling me. We need to cut ties with Tommy because he's too fucking exciting."

“That’s not what I meant.”

“Yeah, Rachel, it is. And guess what? I get it. And what’s more, I know it’s a fucking first-world problem. But it is what it is. We’re in good health. We have a very nice roof over our heads. We have great cars, we go on great vacations. Our kids will never have student loans. We’ve solved most of the shit that most people have to fucking obsess about. We’re now looking for self-actualization, whatever the fuck that really means. But I know what it means to me. What it means to me is that I don’t want to be a prison that prevents you from being truly happy in *any* part of your life. Because here’s the reality. I’d rather give you the freedom to get fucked silly once in a while if I didn’t have to live with the guilt that I was keeping that from you.”

She shook her head. “No, Max, but that... that doesn’t work for me. What sort of monster do you imagine me to be? I couldn’t do that to you.”

“I could if things were reversed.”

She sighed sadly. “No, no you couldn’t.”

We didn’t make love that night. Both our physical exhaustion and our emotional discussion precluded it. But the playfulness returned over the next few nights.

We’d put the kids down and had cautiously initiated an intimate encounter, but once I was inside her, I couldn’t resist.

“I can’t believe you ate her out,” I whispered in her ear. I felt her pussy twitch excitedly in response.

“I can’t believe you fucked her,” she replied.

“Oh sure you can.”

She laughed. “You men are suckers for big tits aren’t you?”

“She was cute all around.”

“You like her better than me?” Rachel teased.

“No way.”

“She was a juicy slut,” she persisted.

I nodded, thrusting harder into my wife.

“Yeah. Up for anything.”

“Is that what you want of me?”

“You’re already that way. You’d never say no to Tommy.” Her cunt clenched my cock.

“Probably not,” she admitted. “But it’s especially hard to say no when I see you, watching, jerking off to it.”

“You’d still fuck him if I wasn’t there.”

“But I wouldn’t enjoy it as much,” she replied. “Anyway, you’d fuck Donna any time too.”

I laughed. “She’s hard to resist.”

“You should have put it in her ass,” she baited me.

“If I had, Tommy would have put it in yours.”

Our eyes met, a weird, fierce excitement coursed through both of us. I came suddenly and when I was done I realized she had as well.

“I don’t really want him in my butt, okay?” she asked.

I laughed. “Okay.”

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

Tommy waited the usual three or four days before contacting us again, and as before began slowly, probing to see if we were still on-board. We were. I pushed him again about the long-term plan. He again asked me to trust him.

–Dude, I’m not sure I can. I can’t risk it. If you’re playing games, I can’t do that to Rachel.

–I hear you. I like both of you. I don’t want to hurt you. But you two need to decide whether you trust me or not. Otherwise, I will just fade away and never pester you again.

He was always good with the reassuring response. He was just there to help us. But he would say that. That’s what a good con man does. And of course, he was some sort of con, and he’d already scored more than I would ever have previously imagined conceding. That’s what really kept me engaged. He’d already fucked my wife, come in her mouth, had her engage in a lesbian encounter, licking his jism off another girl’s twat. The only thing left was to steal her love. But if he could do that, then there was nothing I could do about it. Nor would I want to. As the cliché goes, if you love somebody, you have to set them free. And I did love Rachel.

Tommy proposed a quicker rendezvous than previously, but he also made clear he just wanted me for the evening. Even still, Rachel prepared herself for the meeting. We shipped off the kids. Tommy was nothing if not unpredictable. I tried to caution her. She was cleanly shaved and had chosen

a particularly sexy outfit, a play on the Catholic schoolgirl look that she pulled off to perfection. I think she thought Tommy was just testing her. And indeed, when he did see her, he seemed to hesitate.

But in the end, he held firm and two of us left together in his F-150. In a weird way I felt bad for Rachel. I almost wished he had stayed, maybe dominated her for a bit, at least gotten her off once or twice. Instead, we left her alone in an empty house.

We drove south, away from the city. Tommy was his usual entertaining, inscrutable self. I marveled again at his ability to monologue through an awkward silence. After forty-five minutes, we pulled up to a slightly run-down rambler in an older suburb.

“Party time,” Tommy exclaimed.

We got out of the truck and walked to the front door. He didn’t bother to knock and instead just walked in. The moment the door opened, I was struck by the loud music, a driving hip-hop beat, and the dim lights. It was like walking into a strip club.

Inside, the vibe was about the same, though perhaps mixed with a frat party. Lined up across the counter between the kitchen and living room was a line of bottles of alcohol. A keg in ice sat on the floor. There were maybe a half-dozen men, maybe a few more, in small clusters, talking. It was an eclectic mix, a few African-Americans, a couple of Latinos, a small group of white guys. Lots of tattoos. Everyone was sort of eyeing each other with skepticism.

It occurred to me that we’d walked into Rachel’s wet dream, a room full of “inappropriate” men, not a single one of whom you could bring home to daddy. I shuddered. It would have been easy enough for Tommy to talk my wife into coming along, and then... I knew... easy enough to let them loose on her. Would she have feigned resistance? Certainly, if I wasn’t

there, she wouldn't. But either way, she'd have ultimately given herself to these men, all of them, using her, abusing her, for their selfish pleasure. And yet, it would also have been her pleasure.

Tommy elbowed me and pointed toward a darkened corner. There was a man sitting there in a heavy armchair. He was tall and slender, with a mop of wavy hair, a narrow face, and thin lips. It took me a second to realize he was bound at the wrists and legs to the chair. Tommy led me over.

"Drew, this is Max. He's the guy who fucked your wife last week."

Drew glared at me malevolently. I took a half step back.

Tommy laughed. "Don't worry, Drew likes it."

"I don't," the bound man hissed.

"Then end it," Tommy suggested.

Drew looked at me and at Tommy. "I can't."

I looked at Tommy for an interpretation, but he was still focused in on Drew.

"Who are all these guys?" the man asked.

"You know most of them," Tommy replied. "Most of them have already fucked Donna."

"Not all," he replied, his eyes moving to the small cluster of black men by the bar.

Tommy laughed. "Work friends. They didn't believe me when I invited them to a gangbang. But our little Donna always needs a supply of fresh cocks, doesn't she?"

"She's a whore," Drew spit out.

As if hearing her cue, Donna suddenly appeared out of one of the bedrooms. Attired in spiked heels and a short, clingy, black party dress, her appearance certainly was unambiguous. She was a slut out for cock. I realized that this was the same impression Rachel must have made back in

the day when she went out hunting to get fucked. And indeed, with a shiver, I realized that even her attire earlier in the evening would have made her more than a match for Donna in this room.

Donna spotted Tommy immediately, but took a circuitous route to us, greeting the various men, letting them run their hands over her curves, watching their hunger for her grow. She reached us finally. Tommy gave her a kiss on the cheek, but also reached down and, inches from Drew's face, squeezed his wife's ass. She turned to me and kissed me on the lips, just a little too long to be chaste.

"Did you come by to fuck me again?" she asked, loud enough for her husband to hear. Indeed, it was obvious he was the intended audience.

"I don't know," I replied.

"And where's Rachel?" she continued. "I know she'd have a good time here tonight."

I looked from her to Tommy to Drew. So was that it? A plan to initiate my wife into some sort of gangbang club?

I shook my head. "No."

Donna pouted. "Oh, well, maybe next time." Then turning back to her husband she said, "I probably should get on with my hostess duties, right?"

She held his gaze until finally he seemed to break. "Yes, dear."

She smiled and peeled away from us, placing herself at the center of the nearest group of men. They pressed in close and began running their hands over her. Three pairs of hands, cupping her ass, massaging her breasts. One man leaned down and kissed her hard. Another lifted up the clingy fabric of her dress exposing her hard, naked ass. A man slipped his hands between her legs; her sudden jolt an indication that his fingers were inside her.

Her hands were active too. She unzipped one pair of pants after the other, pulling out hard cocks, stroking them firmly. From behind me I could hear her husband softly whimpering, but when I glanced down into his lap, I saw that his pants were tented in excitement.

I looked up and noticed Tommy had moved over to the front door. He beckoned me in his direction. I walked toward him, unable to completely take my eyes off Donna, who was now on her knees, alternating between swallowing three cocks. It was an intoxicating, erotically charged display, and one I knew would only become more debauched over the next few hours.

“So what do you want to do?” Tommy asked. I wasn’t sure what he meant. “You wanna stay and watch? You wanna stay and fuck? You wanna go get Rachel and bring her over?”

I hesitated, considering the first two at least, but was I maybe also considering the third? The idea made me feel ill, but I knew that Rachel would probably enjoy it. Was it fair for me to deny her that? *Deny her what? The opportunity to be used like a whore by a roomful of men?*

I shook my head silently. Tommy nodded and we walked back toward his truck.

“Don’t you need to stay?” I asked, worried about who would watch out for Donna.

“I’ll come back after I drop you off. She’ll be okay. She knows most of those guys. I know the rest. She’s done this before,” he added.

For the first time, Tommy didn’t fill the silence. Instead, he just drove, inviting me to speak.

“So what was that?” I asked finally.

“Ghost of Chistmas Future.”

“So you think that’s going to be me tied up in a chair and Rachel taking on a roomful of men?”

He shrugged. “That wasn’t the point of the book.”

“Unless I change my ways,” I corrected.

“Lots of possible futures. That’s one though. You realize it, right?”

I nodded. It was what I’d already thought about. The idea of giving Rachel a free pass, that’s where that could lead to. I shuddered. Or Jack could have brought her to this, if he was just a little more skilled, a little more patient. I wanted to ask Tommy again what to do, but I knew he wouldn’t, couldn’t answer.

“How did you get with Donna?”

“Drew and I were in the Navy together. I was getting out when he was getting in. Donna was one of those stereotypical young Navy wives. Married too young. Feeling lonely and sorry for themselves and entitled. It’s not a myth what happens in Navy towns when a ship pulls out.

“She’d gotten herself mixed up with a group of Marines. They were passing her around and she liked it. Problem was, they wouldn’t give her back when Drew’s ship came back from deployment. I can’t say I really blame them. The girl is an animal... as you know.

“But that sort of shit is cancer on a base, especially since the Marines were being assholes, bragging about it, showing her off in front of Drew’s buddies. If they’d just been willing to go by their apartment and fuck the shit out of her, Drew would have probably put up with it. It turns him on too, you know. But it doesn’t turn him on for everyone to know about it. Even cuckolds have a limit for humiliation.”

I thought of Drew, tied up with ten men in his house, watching them go at his wife. It was hard to imagine him having any limits.

“Is that what I am, you think, a cuckold?”

Tommy laughed. “Well, literally yeah. Your wife’s had sex with another man. But in terms of kinks... I don’t think so. Cucks like to watch. They like the humiliation of seeing another man take their woman. I don’t think that really describes you. I think you just like seeing Rachel get hot and bothered, and you definitely don’t seem satisfied in just watching.”

That rang true. And yet, if she only got hot and bothered when being taken by another man, what was the practical difference?

“What did you do about the Marines?”

“I told them to cut it out.”

“And they just did?”

He laughed again. “Oh, don’t imagine it was some big beat down. Any one of the could have thrown me through a wall.”

“So?”

“Fucking around with a junior Seaman’s wife and tormenting him is one thing. Getting into a scrape with a Senior Chief over a piece of ass is something else altogether.”

It occurred to me that his experience with command was part of his presence.

“And then what?”

He laughed. “She was twenty, a firecracker, her hubby got off on watching her fuck other men, but also hated it getting out. It would have been negligence to turn them loose. Guaranteed murder-suicide in a trailer park within five years.”

“So you’re a hero, huh?”

“No. Believe me, I’m no hero. Being with Donna has given me some of the most exciting sexual experiences of my life. But yeah, all things considered, I do think they’re better off with me in their lives.”

“What about me and Rachel. Are my kids going to know you as Uncle Tommy, the mysterious relative who shows up every once in a while and teaches Mommy a new aerobic routine?”

Tommy looked at me, disconcertingly long considering we were hurtling down the road at 45 miles per hour.

“I wouldn’t mind it,” he said as he finally turned back to the road. “Rachel is a very sexy woman. But that’s really up to you. There will come a time, pretty soon, when you two will need to pick a road.”

I sighed. “Tommy, I really wish you’d stop with the Zen shit.”

“That’s your problem Max. You want an equation, a script to follow. Even if I didn’t know you’d gone to business school, I’d have guessed it. You want certainty. That ain’t life. Life is messy and stupid and ugly and weirdly beautiful and passionate.”

I looked out the window. We were getting close to home again. What would happen then? Was he expecting to come in, have his way with Rachel? Not that she would mind. I thought again to her short pleated skirt, the sheer white blouse she’d put on earlier. If he did come in, she’d be angry we’d left her, but I had no doubt Tommy would be able to turn that anger to arousal, and arousal into a sexual explosion. It would be hot to watch. I groaned. Was I a cuckold after all?

Eager to change the conversation, I turned back to Tommy.

“So what’s your story? What do you do when you’re not a sexual therapist?”

He laughed. “I’m a plumber by trade.”

I could tell he was being modest. I didn’t know much about the Navy, but I knew enough to know that a Navy Chief did more than fix toilets. He’d been trained to build and maintain industrial, high-pressure systems, dangerous, technical work.

“And what? You have a stable of married women you’re involved with?”

I saw his jaw tighten, but he kept his tone level. “I know this is going to come off as weird, given everything else, but I’d rather not get into that. Let’s just say, I deal with my demons.”

It was bizarre. He’d asked us to share so much, and yet he was still a cipher. I thought to press the point, but then we pulled up to our house.

“Are you coming in?” I asked, looking at the lights burning inside the house.

“Do you want me to?”

I hesitated. “No, actually, probably not.”

He grinned as I stepped out. “I’ll give Donna your love.”

I had hoped Rachel would be waiting for me in her school girl outfit. *I’ve been waiting for you.* Instead, she was sitting on the sofa in her fluffy white bathrobe, the first time she’d worn it since our night with Donna. She was reading on her Kindle, and drinking red wine out of a huge goblet.

“You’re not supposed to fill those to the rim,” I joked.

She threw down her e-reader. “Did you boys have fun?”

I wasn’t really surprised she was upset, though her tone was harsher than I had expected.

“You don’t really care, do you, Rachel? All you care about is that you weren’t included. Everything has to be about you.”

“You didn’t answer me,” she continued. “Did he introduce you to his other little whores? Were they more accommodating than your selfish, pain-in-the-ass, wife?”

I laughed. “You’re jealous?”

“Should I take that as a yes?”

“Believe me, sweetie, there isn’t a girl out there who’s more accommodating than you are. You’re just upset that you weren’t the one surrounded by a roomful of men.”

Her eyed widened. “So, what, you went to a sex party?”

“Something like that. I didn’t participate.”

“You just watched.”

“I left before anything really happened. It was supposed to be a warning of sorts, I guess.”

“I don’t get it.”

“I don’t either,” I admitted.

“Tell me,” she insisted.

I went and got a glass from the kitchen and emptied half of hers into mine. I sat down beside her.

“We’re in a strange place,” I said, slowly shaking my head.

As we finished our wine, I described the scene in as much detail as I could remember. My overwhelming sense was the general tawdriness of it all. When I’d finished, we both sat for a moment in silence. I’d left early enough that most of what must have happened was left to our imaginations. After the men had gone and the music was off, and the house was filled with empty bottles, the trash cans with used condoms, how did Drew and Donna feel about it? It was an alien sensation to me. I tried to convey that to Rachel, but she seemed more interested in Donna. Had she seemed scared? Did she approach the men, or did they approach her? I’d moved on to the morning after, Rachel was still focused on the night before.

“Could you see yourself doing that?” I asked.

She looked at me, eyes wide, cheeks flushed. “No,” she replied, softly, without conviction.

“Could you really?” I asked in shock.

“I said ‘no.’”

“Yeah, and you’re blushing like a school girl.”

“Am not!”

Before she could react, I reached into her bathrobe, my hand cupping her small breast, noting her rock hard nipple.

“Don’t, Max, I’m not in the mood.”

“I need to check the oil.”

She rolled her eyes. “Don’t... God you’re so crude.”

She squirmed but didn’t quite resist as I slid my hand over her flat belly, between her legs, feeling her heat and wetness within.

“That doesn’t prove anything,” she protested as my finger explored her swollen slit.

“Come on, Rachel, tell me what part of it turns you on? The roomful of strangers? Is it the idea of men taking their turns with you, one after another?”

“It doesn’t,” she moaned.

But her excitement was palpable. I pulled open her bathrobe, took in her naked form.

“Or is it being watched, surrounded by eyes watching you get fucked.”

I plunged two fingers into her. They slipped in easily, squished wetly in her well-lubed cunt.

“Is it the idea of being ravaged? They wouldn’t stop at your pussy. They would also want your mouth, your ass.”

I pressed my pinky into her tight rosebud. She bucked against my hand as I thrust three fingers inside her. I couldn’t help myself. With my other hand I freed my hard cock. I rolled on top of her, plunged inside her.

“Or is it just the idea that someone might one day find out what a slut you are.”

She growled lustily. “No!”

“Friends and family knowing you’re the kind of girl who takes ten cocks in a single night.”

“No!”

“I’m going to tell them,” I teased, thrusting hard.

“No!” she hissed, now grabbing my ass, pulling me into her.

“Everyone will know.”

“No... aaarrghhh,” she cried out, bucking violently against me, until I also crashed over the edge, coming hard inside her.

I lay there between her legs and she continued moaning, “Oh God, oh God, Max.”

I kissed her passionately. “I know, baby, I know.”

It felt like a breakthrough... but as my excitement faded, I felt like I was again back to square one. Like the night with Tommy and then the encounter with Tommy and Donna, it had been hot. But now what?

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

This time Tommy didn't get back in touch. It fell to us to write to him. And it was consciously US. Rachel and I had discussed it, and from now on, any time we communicated with him, any plans, would involve both of us. It seemed weird, in retrospect that we had ever agreed to anything else.

We'd debated the issue for a while. Rachel raised the possibility of not writing at all. I felt that somehow we had unfinished business with him. By her rapid acquiescence, I realized she agreed, that her own reluctance to renew the dialogue was feigned. And that itself seemed to confirm the judgment. We were not done with him yet.

His tone in response to our email was cheerful.

--Hey guys, great to hear from you. I have an event in this city this weekend. Do you want to come along?

--What kind of event?

--In or out?

No explanation. I got that it was part of the game, but it was still frustrating. And yet, also weirdly irresistible.

"Screw him, we don't need to go," Rachel said as we read his email.

I laughed. I'd learned enough to see right through her attitude.

"What do you think it is?" I asked.

"Some sort of orgy?" she replied. *Was that a hopeful tone?*

"Maybe a gangbang," I teased.

She flushed.

"He was in the Navy," I continued. "A roomful of Sailors to ravage you. Sound like fun?"

“Sound like fun to you?” she asked.

I laughed. “Actually no.” Her face fell. “I don’t really want to be ravaged by a bunch of Sailors.”

She giggled. “They have lady Sailors nowadays.”

“Bunch of dykes,” I replied jokingly.

“Would you like to see me ravaged by a bunch of dykes?” she teased back.

“Hmmm, only if they were wearing big, black strap-ons.”

“Black, eh?”

I blushed.

She picked at the scab. “I’ve never had a black... strap-on.”

I decided to meet her challenge. I wrote back to Tommy.

--We’ll go, but only if you promise Rachel some chocolate.

“Don’t send that,” she said, aghast.

“Too late,” I replied as I clicked on send, though I noticed Rachel had done nothing to stay my hand.

--Deal!

Again, we turned to my folks. They were delighted by our increasing willingness to let Brent and Allison stay with them. And the twins were delighted by the amount of toys and candy they’d be able to extort from their grandparents. Happily, neither the kids nor my folks had any inkling about what was really going on.

Tommy had warned us to dress up, so no cheerleader or school girl outfits. Rachel picked instead a long, green, satin dress. It looked painted on

and made it impossible to wear underwear, not that she would have anyway for a date with Tommy.

Is that what it was? A “date” with Tommy? I suspected he’d be fucking her before the night was up. Was there a girl for me as well? A Donna to numb my jealousy, to distract me from what Rachel was doing, what was being done to her? I didn’t bother asking for details. I knew what he’d say. *Trust me.*

Tommy came to pick us up, though not in his F-150, but rather in a gleaming, black stretch limo. Was that some sort of joke? Rachel would get into something big and black before something big and black got into her.

I shared my insight with my wife. She laughed.

“God, you’re crazy,” she replied. But did I notice her regarding the limo in a new light?

Tommy and I were in matching black suits, though he’d gone full Mafioso, with a black silk shirt underneath, whereas I was wearing a white shirt and grey and white tie. As we got into the limo, he offered us each a glass of champagne.

“You’re the damnedest plumber I’ve ever met,” I said.

He laughed. “Nothing but the best for my favorite couple.”

We headed toward the city and again, Tommy allowed for no awkward silences. The topic this time was travel, and he’d been everywhere – Naples, Singapore, Hawaii, Dubai, a dozen other spots.

As we entered downtown, he moved beside Rachel. He withdrew a long, silk scarf from his pocket. Covered in multi-colored checks and splashes of pigment, it was obviously expensive, a work of art. Somehow its tones matched Rachel’s dress. I wondered if Tommy had a selection available or whether he’d just been lucky... or maybe Rachel had run the dress by him?

I didn't have time to contemplate this fully as Tommy slowly wound the scarf over Rachel's eyes, tying it firmly in the back.

"I can't see," she giggled.

"That's the point," he replied. "Max will make sure you don't fall."

I chuckled at the potential alternative meanings; then it occurred to me that wasn't an accident.

We pulled up to a marina. Or was there a different word they used for where luxury yachts were berthed? Valets were parking Mercedes, Porsches, and Teslas, though there were a couple of other limos as well.

The doorman opened our door and we stepped out. I held Rachel firmly by the hand.

"You won't believe this place," I said.

"I hear waves."

"We're going on a yacht," I said as I led her over the carpeted gangplank.

"Do I need to duck?"

I laughed. "I don't think you understand, this is a *yacht*."

I tried to describe it to Rachel. Was it 100 feet? 200? I had no idea. It wasn't quite big enough for its own helicopter, I guess, but was still more like a modern mansion than a ship. Every surface gleamed. Dark polished wood, mirrors, huge glass windows, long leather sofas, tuxedo-clad waiters serving champagne. It was a very smart crowd, the men handsome and self-assured, the women on display.

"I am the only one..."

She trailed off. *Blindfolded*? Yes. It struck me for the first time that I was now moving in a circle where I might be recognized. It was, indeed, frighteningly easy to imagine I might run into someone I knew from work, which would normally have been fine, except that I was leading my

blindfolded wife along beside me. I felt a shiver of concern and then one of excitement. I wondered if this was how Rachel felt with one of her inappropriate men, both fearing exposure and reveling in the delicious excitement of it.

Oddly we didn't seem out of place. Rachel might have been the only one blindfolded, but even that was obvious only on close observation. Otherwise, she might have been wearing her scarf eccentrically. And eccentricity was the name of the game.

There were women in five inch heels and mini-skirts, others whose boobs seemed desperate to burst free of their clothes. There were all sort of inappropriate couples. Men with women half their age, or a woman on each arm. There were men with shirts open to their navels, in a style not seen since the 1970s. A tall, butch lesbian in a tuxedo with a tattoo on the side of her neck played the straight-man in the group.

"What are we doing here?" I asked Tommy.

"Meeting a friend of mine," he replied.

I felt Rachel shudder. *A man to fuck her.* Or maybe a woman? Or maybe both? Or maybe, in homage to San Fran's *Behind the Green Door* past, maybe Rachel was going to be the entertainment, a participant in a live sex show for the enjoyment of the partygoers.

We moved into another parlor, and I realized he'd take my "chocolate" joke for real. Was it even a joke? Did I long to see that, another taboo broken, albeit it one now so common as to be a cliché? A man at the back of the room waved at Tommy, who nodded in response.

"I think that's his friend," I said.

"What's he like?" Rachel asked.

"He's black."

And he was, very, very black, but I immediately realized that wasn't the most notable thing about him. As we approached, he unfolded his long limbs, and I saw he was exceptionally tall, 6'6" maybe more. He looked familiar. A rap star? An athlete? I checked my assumptions. For all I knew he was a coder, who just happened to land early at Google or managed to get his latest App purchased for a billion dollars. As we approached, the others who'd been at his table scattered, though I could feel their eyes on us as they took up position around the room.

"He's big, really big," I added.

"So," he began in a deep, deep rumble, "this is the beautiful lady you wanted me to meet."

Tommy laughed. "Yeah, Ton, you like what you see?"

"She's a sexy little thing," Tony replied. He turned toward me. "And you don't mind me playing with her?"

I shook my head, though I wasn't sure if I was saying, *no, I don't mind* or *no, I do*.

Rachel was twisting her head, craning her neck, as if that would somehow render the scarf transparent, allowing her to see what was going on.

"That's a very sheer dress, you're not wearing anything underneath," Tony observed, his voice almost inaudible, blending in with the bass coming from elsewhere on the ship.

Rachel swallowed hard and then gave him a quick, confirming nod.

"Show me your pussy, beautiful," he ordered.

She hesitated just a moment, and then pulled her hand free of mine. Or maybe I'd released her, giving her unconscious encouragement to proceed. The sensation of being observed, judged was almost overwhelming. I forced myself to breathe slowly. I noticed Rachel was doing the same,

though she was moving at the same time, reaching down with both hands to seize the fabric of her dress and lift it up. The satin slid smoothly over her skin, her thighs. Though it remained covering her ass in the back, there was no uncertainty about what she was doing, exposing her naked pussy to this massive stranger.

He sat back down so that he was now face-to-face with my wife's sex. He reached out and grazed her thigh, by the knee. She shuddered but didn't withdraw. He touched her firmly, confidently, his fingertips finding her slit, pressing inside. She sighed.

"She's a juicy little thing," Tony rumbled.

His finger, his huge, long finger pressed further inside her.

"Think she can take me?"

Tommy chuckled. "Only one way to find out."

Tony rose again and gestured toward a dimly lit stairway down to a private stateroom. I breathed a sigh of relief. At least he wasn't going to take her in public. I took her firmly by the upper arm and began walking her toward the stairs.

She turned her neck behind her, and said, "Max, are you coming too?"

What did she mean?

Tony smiled as we passed. He was an experienced man. He'd led many women down into that cabin. She'd definitely have a good time. I sighed again. But why not with me? And then it struck me. As we passed him, I shook my head at him firmly. I saw him react with surprise, even anger, but Tommy's hand was on his shoulder and he remained still.

I led Rachel down the stairs.

"Is my husband coming?" she asked, a little frightened, but also clearly very excited.

I didn't answer her, and instead felt her tremble in my grip, realizing maybe that she was well and truly alone with a huge, deep-voiced black man. She looked back again, or maybe she was just trying to listen for more footsteps. We approached his big bed, covered with a gold-colored comforter. It was quieter down here, but we could still feel the music pulsing through the ship.

How would Tony handle her? It wasn't hard to imagine. The kind of man who'd straightaway asked to see her pussy, who'd immediately fingered her, was unlikely to provide much romance. I edged her forward until her legs touched the bed, and then like a submissive little slut she immediately fell forward onto her hands and knees, her gorgeous little butt wiggling back and forth in her shiny dress.

A surge of anger flowed through me. God, she really was that easy, that much of a whore. Any man could have her if he only knew how to ask. I lifted up her gown and spanked her ass hard. My hand stung.

"Ow!!" she whined. Then immediately set to counting, "One!"

Spanked her again. I wanted to beat her until she cried out for mercy. But even as her cheeks reddened, I could feel my fury refocusing on her tight, little, wet snatch. As much as I wanted to hurt her, I wanted to fuck her more.

I began to undo my belt. She shivered and apprehensively tried to look over her shoulder. I seized and yanked on the scarf as much to control her as to ensure it didn't come off. She stiffened as my pants hit the ground. I knew she was anticipating getting skewered by a huge cock. I knew that the moment my familiar prick entered her, she'd realize what was going on. I wanted to draw it out, but I couldn't resist.

I thrust halfway into her. She let out a long, low moan.

"Ugh, God, Tony, you're so big, so big. Go slow."

I almost gasped in shock. How long had she known this was a put on? Then I noticed her body. She was trembling, gulping down big mouthfuls of air. Whatever the reality of it, in her mind she was on her hands and knees getting fucked from behind by an oversized stranger.

I pulled out almost all the way and hammered back into her.

“Ugh, God!”

I spanked her ass.

“Three!” she groaned.

Thrust, spank, “Four!”

Thrust, spank, “Five! Ugh, God.”

I sped up, faster and faster, until she lost count.

“Ugh, God, I can’t keep up.”

Her ass was beet red, my hand ached. She couldn’t keep up with the count, but she was getting ever more into the fucking, rocking back against me. Her pussy wet and grasping. Then suddenly, she arched her back.

“Ah, ah, ah, AH!” she cried out.

I felt her pussy spasm on my shaft. *Tony’s shaft*. I pictured the scene from her perspective. I couldn’t quite understand it, not anymore than I could really understand Donna’s interest in being gangbanged. At the same time, I could see the exoticness of it, the undeniable wickedness of it. Being brought to a yacht, walked blindfolded through partygoers, exposed to a stranger, and then turned over by your husband to be taken by a big, black stud. My own excitement peaked and before I knew it was coming as well.

I stepped back, my eyes drawn inevitably to her pulsing, pink slit. She remained on her hands and knees, breathing heavily, but available. Was she expecting Tony to resume his pounding, other men to take his place?

“What are you thinking of?”

She jolted and turned her head toward my voice, though she still didn't try to remove the blindfold. "Max, did you watch the whole thing?"

I laughed. "It was me."

She shook her head. "No, before."

I removed the blindfold from her eyes. "Just me."

She registered disbelief. Maybe even some anger.

"Are you disappointed?"

"Was this a... some sort of prank?"

She sat down heavily on the bed.

"No. No, I just couldn't give you to him. I... I wanted you for myself."

She looked down. "I'm sorry to keep putting you through this... this weirdness. My fucked-upness."

"No, don't Rach. Don't. I wanted you for myself, but I loved that you thought you were with him. That you were able to lose yourself that way."

She looked around, still more than a little shell-shocked. "Are we really on a boat?"

I nodded. "And we probably should get out of here. Tony didn't seem pleased when I deprived him of you, and I doubt he's happy with us tying up his fuck pad."

We tidied up a little and then hand-in-hand crept up the staircase. We walked through the door into the salon. There were a few amused glances, but no one paid us much attention. Still, we stayed to the shadows and the edges of the room as we maneuvered out onto the deck. I spotted Tony, back to us, looming over a group of people. I pointed him out to Rachel, and she went wide-eyed. But I decided not to go over. *Hey, buddy, no hard feelings about not getting to fuck my wife. Hope we didn't leave a mess.*

As we approached the walkway to the dock, Tommy cleared his throat.

"Leaving so soon?" He asked, amused.

“Yeah,” Rachel replied. “I don’t think I could take another pounding like the one I just got.”

He smiled. “Take the limo.”

“No, we couldn’t,” I replied.

“Trust me, I’ll get home alright. Anyway, I have plans that will keep me out late.”

I followed his eyes to a pretty, forty-something blonde standing next to her husband, who’s eyes kept disappearing into the cleavage of the woman they were speaking to. An underappreciated wife who might welcome Tommy’s attention. I laughed. Someone should write a book about the guy.

He leaned over and kissed Rachel on the cheek, a gesture than felt like more of a final goodbye than I had expected. She jolted with the same realization.

“We’ll be in touch,” he said to cut off further discussion.

We sat in the limo and drank some more champagne. It was still early and the driver informed us the car was paid for until late, so we asked him to drive us around. Nowhere in particular, just to see the sights.

Rachel was curled up on the seat, dress pulled up and legs tucked beneath her. I rested my hand on her thigh, stroking it absentmindedly with my thumb. We were both lost in thought. Where we’d been as a couple, where we were going. I had a wicked thought.

“Do you regret not fucking him? Tony I mean.”

She looked at me. “No, of course not.”

A lie. The walls were building back up again.

“I bet he has a limo.”

She nodded. “Probably. Can you believe that yacht?”

“If you had screwed him, he probably would have driven you home.”

She laughed. “I doubt it.”

I ran my hand farther up her thigh.

“He might want another taste on the ride home.”

“Max, what are you talking.... Oh....”

I pulled the scarf from my pocket and fastened it again over her eyes.

I didn’t bother with an absurd attempt at his deep rumble.

“I shoulda put it in your mouth. You’d like that, right baby?”

She suppressed a small giggle, but played along. And actually the giggle worked for a ditzy whore who blows guys in the back of cars. “Of course, Tony.”

I quickly unzipped myself and pulled her face into my lap. She swallowed me deep and began bobbing down on my cock, not a wife making love to her husband, but a slut servicing her man. I rested my hand possessively on the back of her head.

“That’s it baby, suck it good. Get me nice and hard.”

She was almost too enthusiastic. I channeled the sentiment.

“Not so fast. I want to fuck you,” I growled.

“Now?” she asked, putting herself at my disposal.

“Yeah.”

I helped her climb into my lap. She reached down and worked my cock up and down her slit before settling onto me with a satisfied sigh. I slapped her ass lightly to get her moving, and she began to ride me vigorously, her sloppy pussy squishing on my prick. I lifted up her dress, exposing her ass.

“I put the divider down,” I whispered in her ear.

“Nooo.” She sighed.

“Yeah, baby, the driver can see just what a cheating whore you are.”

She growled excitedly.

I spread her ass apart, tickling her anus. I pushed my fingertip into her ass.

“Maybe I’ll give him a turn after I’m done.”

She came suddenly. I continued to thrust into her, hard at first, but then slowing down as we transitioned into making love. I removed the blindfold and we looked into each other’s eyes. We kissed, softly, tenderly, until I came inside her. Then we sat side-by-side, cuddling and enjoying a slow car ride home.

EPILOGUE

Tommy didn't respond to my emails. But after a week or so, a package arrived from him. I opened it and found our long, wooden spoon and a thumb drive.

Max and Rachel:

I'm returning your spoon. I didn't know if I'd need it again myself, but now you can put it to good use yourselves. And here are some lovely pictures of Rachel. I regretfully deleted them from my computer. It was great knowing you, and you can always count on me if you need me. But I think, you've got it.

Tommy

He was right about the spoon. Along with the scarf and the bathrobe that Donna had borrowed, they became like talismans for us, reminders of our wilder natures. Rachel wearing the bathrobe after a soak in the tub became an invitation to relive that evening with Donna. Sliding the spoon over her thigh elicited tingles of excitement. And the scarf... a wonderful blindfold, it was also perfect for binding her hands behind her back.

We were grateful to Tommy, both because he'd gotten us over a rough spot in our lives, but also because he'd let us go. He certainly needn't have, and if he'd sought to remain in our lives, I'm not sure either one of us would have had the strength to expel him.

But even though we didn't communicate with Tommy, he was still there. We speculated about his past. It was also a surefire prelude to a sizzling evening to imagine him with us. What would he do to Rachel? Where would he take us? Who would he introduce us to?

With her permission, I emailed him back Rachel's pictures. The ones she'd sent to him and the one's he'd taken of her. I like to think we'll always have a bond. And as he said, if we ever need him we could summon him back to rediscover our kink. We haven't had to do that yet, but then again, we're still young.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

I have been writing erotica for many years. I began publishing my work online at Literotica.com under the username Misterstan back in 2011. Those stories are a mixed-bag. Some were written more than twenty years ago and are, frankly, immature in both conception and execution. Still, some of those stories are pretty entertaining.

Reader feedback is what keeps me going. Please feel free to contact me at ben.boswell.author@gmail.com or visit my blog at benboswell.blogspot.com. You can follow me on Twitter @BenBoswellAut.

I have written three other pieces of longer-form fiction.

Two Sides of Terri

Bill has just about the perfect life. Good paying job. Lovely home. Perfect children. And most of all, he has his wife Terri--smart, funny, great with the kids. Thing is, she's a good girl trapped in a bad girl's body. Blonde, busty, and devastatingly beautiful, she makes him want to do dirty things--things you don't admit to wanting from the girl-next-door.

Or so he thought.

It starts with a revelation about Chucky, a past boyfriend, and everything he thought he knew about his sweet wife unravels. He becomes obsessed with learning more about this other side of Terri--and everything he learns points back to Chucky, a man she couldn't say no to. Does he dare

invite her past back into their present? And if he did, would she now be able to say no?

Available at Amazon: <http://www.amazon.com/Two-Sides-Terri-Ben-Boswell-ebook/dp/B00HSCMZTW>

Whatever it Takes

Daniel and Kris are as white bread as they come. Together since junior high, they have two kids, a house in the suburbs, and no excitements in their lives. Things change when Kris' little sister Jessi moves in. Jessi is everything Kris isn't, reckless, promiscuous, and mixed up with very bad people. As their two orbits intersect, Daniel and Kris get dragged into Jessi's world of drug dealers, strip clubs, and prostitution. Can they survive the dangers? And even if they do, will their marriage?

Fueled by their love for each other, and drawing on a strength and resourcefulness they never realized they had, Daniel and Kris are desperate to recover their old lives. To do so, they will do whatever it takes!

Available at Amazon: <http://www.amazon.com/Whatever-It-Takes-Ben-Boswell-ebook/dp/B00KABTO42>

Honeymoon Hazards

After being together for seven years, John and Claire marry and jet off to beautiful Hawaii for their honeymoon. It is a paradise of hard bodies in tiny

bikinis, mixed drinks consumed in the hot sun, and a resort built for private encounters.

But when John is struck down with a stomach flu, he can do nothing but sit on his balcony and watch others have fun. Discovering his inner voyeur, he finds that spying on a resort full of sexy and adventurous guests is an enjoyable distraction.

That is, until he spots his new bride flirting with an oh-so-handsome stranger by the pool. Things really heat up when Claire disappears from view, and he can't find the stranger, either. As John's imagination runs wild, the line between fantasy and lust blurs until he can no longer tell where his worst fears end and his fondest desires begin.

Available at Amazon: <http://www.amazon.com/Honeymoon-Hazards-Ben-Boswell-ebook/dp/B00N84NIRM>

Cuckolding Shorts

There are a number of short stories that I've written over the years that I am particularly fond of. I am in the process of editing and preparing them for publication. The first one is out.

Volume 1: The Cottage

Rich has always had fond memories of his parents' old lake cottage. When they decide to sell it, he invites some old friends to join him and his wife Becky for a weekend of beer and nostalgia. But Rich's plans are upset by the presence of Robby, who is boorish, aggressive, and makes no secret of his lust for Becky.

When Robby badgers Rich into a foolish bet, he learns that his wife is willing to go to any lengths to make sure he pays his debts.

Available at Amazon: <http://www.amazon.com/Cottage-Cuckolding-Shorts-Book-ebook/dp/B00NY1CQAE>

For more information on future projects, visit <http://benboswell.blogspot.com/>

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